

Art for Little Thinkers

Michael Gannotti



Figure 1: Cover

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This illustrated edition is the teaching-manual of 24 September 2026. Endnotes run in one series. Chapter-opening images are original still-lives, not portraits of persons or children. Documents still constrain the facts.

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Welcome

You do not need to be a studio artist to teach a five- to ten-year-old real art looking and making.

You need an object on the table before the name, and a child's mark on the child's page before polish.

That is what this book is for.

Why this book exists

Many adults remember art as coloring sheets, a laminated color wheel, and a quiet “make it nice” from the adult at the elbow. That memory can leave you feeling rusty when a child asks how to draw a dog, or freezes at a blank page, or wants you to finish the ear. Feeling rusty is normal. It is not a character flaw.

At ages 5–10, art does not begin with a medium survey or a gallery critique. It begins with looking and making. A child can notice yellow dots on a postcard before anyone says *pointillism*. A child can follow a mug's rim with a fat crayon. A child can tear paper and glue a scrap story. A child can pinch soft clay and redesign when a wall falls. A child can say what they see — and what makes them say that — without racing to “pretty.”

Those moves are not a waiting room for middle school. They are the work.

This book teaches you how to run a short **Art Hour** at home — roughly twenty to forty minutes — with the object down before the vocabulary, and with **look before name** and **make before polish** as the spine. Inside the chapters you will see two planning bands: 5–7 and 8–10. Place your child by skill, not by birthday.

A careful six-year-old and a fluent nine-year-old may sit in the same looking move on different days.

The focus lock for the whole book is simple:

Look before name. Make before polish.

Hold that, and the rest of the manual becomes practice.

What a good Art Hour looks like

Picture a kitchen table. Not a museum field trip every day. Not a silent “color this packet” hour. Not a product chase for the fridge.

You put a mug, a leaf, fat crayons, or two tempera puddles on the table. You cover any caption that already names the famous work. You ask what the child notices — before you tell them what this is called. You wait. They look. They make one short thing with the tool in *their* hand. You ask one authentic question about what they see or what the hand tried, and you wait again. Then you name the idea only as far as the looking and the mark can carry. Then you stop talking. You leave one crumb: a sticky notice, a three-word caption, a “whose mark” check, or the child’s choice of what goes on the wall.

That is the hour. Library picture-book sits, museum one-work visits, grocery color carts, and nature texture walks motivate. They do not replace the look-before-name move on the table.

You will meet the full session shape in **The Art Hour**. Later chapters point back to it. You do not rebuild the spine every week.

Two readers at once

This is a teaching manual for the parent or co-teacher at the table, with short student sections a child can actually use.

When you read a parent section, you are learning today’s looking-and-making move well enough to hear a wrong turn — a name-first rush, an adult-filled mark, a “draw it nice” freeze, a coloring-book-as-only-hour week, a generated image filed as the child’s work, a demo with no child’s page, a coverage lecture with no object

on the table. You learn what to say next without grabbing the brush or filling the silence with “pretty.”

When your child reads (or hears) a student section, they get respect. No baby-talk. No lecture about you. They get a tiny worked example, two tries, and a chance to explain it back.

At 5–7 they can notice before a name, mark freely with fat tools, tear and glue, pinch soft clay, choose whether a page goes on the wall, and say what they see. At 8–10 they can follow a mug’s rim more slowly, try blind contour soft, mix with fewer colors, write a short because-I-see caption, redesign a fallen pinch, and say whose mark is on the page. Write — and speak — as if they can.

What this book will not do

It will not hand you a 180-day craft dump.

It will not sell you a curriculum, crown one program, or promise a score.

It will not reprint *Art for Homeschooling* — that book serves grades 1–12, with later medium courses, portfolio edges, AP Art and Design, and solvent/oil/kiln safety for older work. For that map, see that book once. This book teaches the 5–10 Art Hour.

It is not a sequel to *History for Little Thinkers*, *Science for Little Thinkers*, *Critical Thinking Skills for Little Thinkers*, *English for Little Thinkers*, or *Math for Little Thinkers*. One pointer each is enough. Then we teach art as looking and making. The grain of those manuals — short hour, talk box, named try-its, exit crumb — rhymes. The content does not mash. Fair-test is science. Piece-from-then is history. Contour and tempera puddles are art.

It will not title your subject **Little Thinkers Art I**. A stranger-readable title is **Art**. Drawing only when the year’s work is mostly drawing.

It will not turn the hour into a culture-war pamphlet. Safe art objects only: a mug, a shoe, a leaf, a pear, a window view, fat crayons, tempera puddles, torn paper, a foam stamp, air-dry clay, a dated sketchbook. No child portraits in generators or book illustrations. No deepfake “artist friend.”

It will not pitch “art makes you smarter at reading or math.” Justify art by what art teaches — looking, marking, talking about the work.

It will not put solvents or craft knives on the kitchen table for this age band. Adult present. Materials with an ACMI **AP** seal and/or labelled **Conforms to ASTM D-4236**. Washable tempera and soft clay are enough.

It will not ask you to wait until middle school to begin. Children this age can look and make. They do not become artists because someone bought a sample craft kit.

How the book is built

Front matter tells you how to use the week, five things to remember, and the Art Hour once — including the safety spine and the AI box for ages 5–10, said carefully and only once.

Eight teaching chapters follow: what art looks like at 5–10; looking at art and objects; mark-making and line; color and paint light; collage, print, and paper; clay and 3-D soft; talking and writing about art; short assessments and progress checks.

Then records and resources. Records keep a dated sketchbook, a looking note, the child's make, and an optional process photo under **Art**. Resources name common programs by fit — parent load, look-then-make vs step-by-step, placement — with library, museum, and gallery first. Fit, not rank.

Every teaching chapter uses the same eight headings, a talk box with an exact opening question, named try-its inside the home and outside it, and age-band moves for 5–7 and 8–10.

Encouragement that is specific

This week you can learn one looking move well enough to hear a name-first rush and turn it back to the mug, the leaf, or the page.

Today your child can point at one thing they notice and keep their own mark on their own paper.

You do not need to be a studio artist. You do need to put the object on the table before the name, and to leave the child's mark on the child's page.

That is enough to begin.¹

— Michael Gannotti

¹Access date for locked numbers and program checks in this edition: 24 September 2026. Full citations for studies named in later chapters live in the Notes for those chapters and in end matter.

How to use this book this week

Pick one looking-and-making move. Run the Art Hour a few times. Leave one crumb on Friday.

That is the honest “lesson plan.” Not a 180-day craft calendar. Not a unit binder that never returns to the mug.

This week’s shape

1. **Choose one chapter focus.** Examples: notice before name on a mug or postcard; child’s first mark block; follow-the-edge; two-puddle mix; tear collage; foam stamp; pinch pot; tell-me talk (not “pretty”); a short whose-mark check.
2. **Run three to five Art Hours** of the named shape in **The Art Hour** (~20–40 minutes each). Same focus. Fresh object if you can; same mug or leaf revisited if that is what the week holds.
3. **Do one in-home try-it** from the chapter’s practice section (mug look, fat crayon block, tempera puddle, tear collage, foam stamp, pinch pot, window frame, light/dark water).
4. **Do one out-of-home try-it** once in the week when you can (museum one-work sit, sculpture walk, nature line/texture, library picture-book look first, grocery color cart, architecture edge walk, gallery child choice). Ordinary safety. Adult present outdoors.
5. **Friday: one diagnostic pattern + done-enough.** Hear one wrong turn without crushing the look — name-first, adult-filled mark, empty pretty loop, coloring-sheet-only week, generated image in the folder. Check whether the child can show the move two ways, and whether a page still feels like theirs after a night. Details live in each chapter’s “done enough” and in the

assessments chapter.

If a day only holds twenty minutes: object + notice + short make + exit crumb. One named move done well beats a rushed craft medley. There is no nationally representative study of art minutes per day in U.S. homes that this book can quote — so there is no honest “required” dose to post on the fridge — and no need to shame a week that held three short sits.

Placement by skill (5–7 / 8–10)

Use the bands as planning help, not as birthday locks.

5–7 leans look-heavy: fat tools, tear before fancy cut, playdough or air-dry, oral exit, you may scribe the caption they said, process over likeness.

8–10 may take a longer make: blind contour soft, foam print, overlap, written because-I-see crumbs — still refuse MFA critique. If looking habits are weak, stay on 5–7 LOOK and MARK longer, regardless of a ninth birthday.

A seven-year-old who can look at a rim and mark it may run early observation moves. A nine-year-old still melting down on long sits needs shorter material play. Soft band placement lives as a try-it shape in the assessments chapter — place by what they can show, not by the cake candles.

How to read a teaching chapter

Read **Why this matters** and **For the parent** first — alone, if you can. Do the five-minute parent warm-up with tomorrow’s object or paper before the child sits. Practice the sentence “What do you notice?” aloud once. Check that the materials are actually on the table, not still in a cupboard. Check the seal (ACMI **AP** and/or **Conforms to ASTM D-4236**) before you open a new bottle.

Then use **How to teach it this week** as your script for the table. Exact wording is there on purpose. Use it. Age-band moves for **5–7** and **8–10** live inside that heading.

Practice that actually builds learning names try-its with time, materials, mess/safety, the fun, and the skill — at least one inside the home and at least one

outside. The talk box gives the locked opening question, follow-ups, how to wait, and what a stuck silence usually means.

Read **For the student** with your child, or let them hear it. Warm, direct, short. Never a lecture about research.

Use **If it isn't clicking** when something stalls. Three diagnostics. No shame. Correct a wrong reason without crushing the look. Rescue order is ask, wait, hint, short demo on *demo paper*, return the tool.

Tools, including AI stays short and points back to the Art Hour AI box. Do not rebuild policy every chapter.

What “done enough” looks like is your leave-this-chapter checklist. Placement by skill, not birthday. A publisher's “grade 2 art workbook” is a scope, not a legal grade, and not a transcript line.

Sibling and mixed-age homes

Share the object. Split the make.

The younger child may tear, stamp, notice, or say one thing they see. The older child may follow an edge more slowly, write a short caption, or redesign a fallen pinch with help.

Give each child a turn to speak. After one answers, wait so the next can add — not so the older becomes unpaid tutor as their only role. They need their own mark too.

Multilingual homes

Looking works in the family's talk language.

Notice, mark, and talk work before English art labels arrive. When a book page is in another script, you read the name aloud after the look; the child still points at what they see. You may scribe a caption the child said. Do not delay Art Hour until decoding is “ready.” Looking is not decoding.

Activity banks are a menu

Later chapters pull named try-its from banks (look, mark, color, collage, print, clay, line, shape, space, talk, write, outings, safe, assessment — seventy-nine named across the book). A chapter picks a few. It does not assign all seventy-nine. Coverage itch is the enemy of looking.

What to skip for now

Skip chapters you are not ready to teach this month. The map is a path, not a race.

Skip vendor shopping until you have run a few Hours with free lookables: a mug, a leaf, a window, fat crayons, scrap paper, a library picture book, a museum postcard.

Skip AI tools until you have read the Art Hour AI box once. The child looks and marks. You may use a tool on your account. The child does not sit alone with an open chat or an unsupervised generator.

Records without drama

Date the sketchbook page. Title it **Art**. Keep the looking note, the child's make, and an optional process photo. That file is the record. Details live in the records chapter. You do not need a brand name on the spine. Never title the subject **Little Thinkers Art I**.²

²There is no nationally representative table of kitchen art minutes this book can honestly quote. Public-school “minutes with a specialist” figures are context for schools — not a home failure metric. Dose honesty lives in **The Art Hour**.

If you only remember five things

Keep this page short. Pin it where you plan the week. When the hour feels scattered, return here before you add more materials.

1. Look first

Put the mug, the leaf, the postcard (caption covered), the tempera puddles, or the clay on the table first. Looking is the lesson. The adult name waits. A fluent lecture with no object is not an Art Hour. Library, museum, and gallery days motivate; they do not replace the object on the table. One lookable beats a dizzying tour of twenty crafts.

2. Child's tool, child's mark

The child holds the crayon, brush, stamp, or clay. Your demo — if any — lives on *demo paper*, then you cover it or put it away. An adult-finished dog is not the child's drawing. A matched sample as the only product is craft display, not this hour's work. Process is the effect of making on the child. The fridge picture is evidence a sitting happened — not the grade. Presenting still exists: the child chooses which page goes up and can say one reason.

3. Struggle before rescue

Ask. Wait. Hint. Short demo on demo paper. Return the tool. Do not grab the brush. Do not fill the silence with “pretty.” Do not paste a machine's picture as

theirs. “I can’t draw” often means looking got ahead of the hand — shorten the task to one rim; do not talent-shame.

4. Talk points at the work

One authentic question about what they notice before a name, what they see and what makes them say that, whose mark and what the hand tried, what happened when colors met, what paper or press did, what clay did, what they can tell about the work — not whether it is pretty alone. Then a slow three. Look at the object or the page — not at the child — if the silence is hard. Empty pretty loops teach preference, not looking.

5. Safe materials and mess honesty

Check for an ACMI **AP** seal and/or **Conforms to ASTM D-4236** before you open a bottle (SAFE-01). No **CL** products through grade 6. No solvents — no turpentine, mineral spirits, or solvent adhesives as kitchen art. Labelled children’s scissors; no craft knives for this age book. Cover the table. Food and drinks out of the art area. Name the mess before you start. Wash hands. Adult present for wet, sharp, outdoor, and small parts. Poison Control 1-800-222-1222 if needed. “Non-toxic” does not mean edible.

These five are the book in miniature.³

AI honesty — a generated image is not the child’s mark; a model-written artist statement is not their talk; the parent holds the account; unaided first on looking and marking — lives once in **The Art Hour**. Point back there when you need it. Do not let a sixth rule crowd the fridge list. The full safety spine and the full talk-box shape live there too.

³ACMI product seals (**AP** / **CL**) and ASTM D-4236 labelling: follow the current package. Read the label every time you open a new product. Safety spine details live in **The Art Hour**.

The Art Hour



Figure 2: A kitchen table with a looking mug, fat crayons, a tempera puddle, and an open sketchbook — still-life, no people, no logos.

Twenty to forty minutes. Five beats. Stop while wanting one more mark.

This chapter is the session spine for the whole book. Later chapters say “run the

Art Hour” and point here. You do not rebuild the shape every week.

Parent warm-up (alone, about five minutes)

Before the child sits, put tomorrow’s object or paper on the table. Practice one sentence aloud: “What do you notice?”

Do not rehearse a lecture. Cover any caption that already names the famous work or the vocabulary word. If the only “still life” you have is a generated picture of a mug, put a real mug on the table instead.

Check the seal on new materials. Cover the table if paint or glue is coming. Preview the mess in one plain sentence.

Without this warm-up, the Hour collapses into name-first or polish-first.

The five beats

1. Look / notice (3–8 minutes)

One object, reproduction (caption covered), prior page, or materials on the table. One lookable, not a stack of kits.

Ask what they notice. Where does your eye go first? What do you see that you did not expect?

You do not dump the name yet. If they ask “what is this called?” right away, turn them back to what is on the table. Silent look for a slow count when that helps.

2. Short make (8–18 minutes)

One named try-it. The child holds the tool. Adult demo — if any — is short and on *demo paper*, then covered or put away.

Struggle before rescue: ask → wait → hint → short step on demo paper → hand the tool back.

This is the child’s make. A parent demo with no child’s page is a picture, not the hour’s work.

3. Talk box (3–8 minutes)

Point at the work or the materials. One authentic question. Wait. Specific uptake — yellow dots, a drip kept, a rim followed — not “pretty” alone.

4. Name lightly (2–5 minutes)

After evidence: one kid-language name that fits (“those repeated stamps are a pattern”; “you mixed a new orange”). Optional. Skip if the child is spent — naming can wait until tomorrow’s look.

5. Exit crumb / show choice (2–5 minutes)

One durable trace: a sticky notice, a three-word caption, a process sentence, a photo of process (not only product), a “whose mark” check. You note one diagnostic pattern if any — for tomorrow’s teaching, not a graded quiz.

Optional show: fridge, folder, or the child’s choice of display. Done-enough today is looked, marked, talked — right, or wrong-with-a-reason for tomorrow. The exit should stand without a chat window.

Optional sixth beat — siblings

After one child answers, wait so the next can speak. Share the object; split the make. Do not make the older child the unpaid tutor as their only role.

Bands inside the hour

5–7. Look-heavy; fat crayons, large brushes, tear before fancy cut; playdough or air-dry; oral exit; you may scribe captions they said; process over likeness. Prefer sits nearer twenty minutes when attention is thin. No live open chat as the child’s partner.

8–10. Longer make optional; blind contour soft; foam print; overlap; written caption crumbs; still refuse MFA critique. If looking habits are weak, stay on 5–7 LOOK and MARK longer — regardless of a ninth birthday.

Place by skill, not birthday. Move a child between bands by what they can show.

When the hour goes wrong

If the hour looks like...	Try this move
Child only copies adult sample “I can’t draw”	Cover demo; “your page”; process talk Return to looking; shorten to one rim; boost experience
Adult finishes the dog	Hands in lap; ask–wait–hint; demo paper only
Empty “it’s pretty” loop Silence after “what is it?” Every hour is a coloring sheet	Point with words; specific noticing “Tell me about your artwork” Schedule LOOK + MARK; sheets as optional quiet toy
Generated image in the folder	Authorship honesty; remove from “child work”
Meltdown over mess	Mess honesty preview; smaller paint amounts; AP washables
Solvent smell / CL seal	Stop; seal check; no solvents kitchen path
Child alone with open chat / generator	Close the tab; SCRIPT after the try; parent holds the account
Safety fails	Stop the hour; continue another day

Talk-box shape (once for the book)

Every teaching chapter carries a talk box. The shape is always the same.

Opening question. Authentic. About what they notice before a name, what they see and what makes them say that, whose mark and what the hand tried, what happened when colors met, what paper or press did, what clay did, what they can tell about the work (not pretty), or what they can show two ways. Not “did you have fun.” Not “what is the vocabulary quiz word.”

Locked openings live in each chapter. Chapter 1 opens with notice before name. Chapter 2 opens with what you see — and what makes you say that. Chapter 3 opens with whose mark and what the hand tried.

Three to five follow-ups. One for look (“what do you *see* / *notice*?”). One for

make (“what did your hand / the material do?”). One for evidence (“what do you see that makes you say that?”). One for process or check (“how did you do that?” / “whose mark?”). One that lets them revise (“you may change your mind” / “try another look” / “keep the drip — what could it become?”).

How to wait. After you ask, a slow three is a useful convention — drawn from classroom wait-time research, labelled as classroom-origin, used here as pause craft for Art Hour, not an art experiment on your kitchen table.⁴ After they stop, wait again. If they are mid-look or mid-mark, do not cut them off. Look at the object, the page, or the materials if the silence is hard.

Stuck silence usually means: the question was vague; you did not wait; they are hunting a vocabulary word because you asked name-first; they fear “draw it nice”; every hour has been coloring-book lines; they point at a phone image as “my art”; they shrug at “what is it?” (use tell-me); the caption was uncovered before looking.

Pose, wait, and point back at the object or the page — do not fill the silence with “pretty.”

In-home try-it shape (once)

Every named in-home try-it in this book carries:

- **Time** (kitchen estimate)
- **Materials** (what is on the table)
- **Mess / safety** (ordinary and non-negotiable — see the spine below)
- **The fun** (why a child might want to try)
- **The skill** (the looking-and-making move being practiced)

Typical in-home lookables and makes: mug look, fat crayon block, two-puddle mix, tear collage, foam stamp, pinch pot, light/dark water, window frame, follow-the-edge.

⁴Mary Budd Rowe, “Wait-Time and Rewards as Instructional Variables,” NARST / ERIC ED061103 (1972): elementary *science* tapes; typical wait near one second; extending wait to about three to five seconds changed student discourse. Robert J. Stahl, “Using ‘Think-Time’ and ‘Wait-Time’ Skillfully in the Classroom,” ERIC ED370885 (1994): classroom think-time convention near three seconds. Both are classroom-origin. They are not a kitchen-table art trial. Used here as pause craft for Art Hour.

Out-of-home try-it shape (once)

Same fields — time, materials, mess/safety, the fun, the skill — plus ordinary outing care.

Typical outings: museum one-work sit, sculpture walk, nature line/texture, library picture-book look first, grocery color cart, architecture edge walk, gallery child choice.

Safety and courtesy. Roads, weather, poison plants, museum hands-off rules, grocery courtesy. Leave living things unharmed. Cover plaques and captions until after the look when you can.

Outings motivate. They do not replace the look-before-name move at home.

Safety spine (once for the book)

1. **Adult present** for wet media, scissors, outdoors, small parts, clay tools, and anything that drips or stains.
2. **ACMI AP** and/or **Conforms to ASTM D-4236** for child materials; **no CL** products through grade 6.⁵ Read the current label. (SAFE-01 seal check before open.)
3. **No solvents** as the default kitchen path for ages 5–10 — no turpentine, mineral spirits, or solvent-based adhesives as kitchen art. (SAFE-04.)
4. **Labelled children's scissors**; adult present; snips before interior cuts; **no craft knives for this age book**. Follow the tool label and the child's skill — this book invents no age statute.
5. **Mess honesty** before you start; cover the table; food and drinks out of the art area. (SAFE-02, SAFE-05.)
6. **Small amounts** of paint; wash hands; ventilate ordinary rooms.
7. **Outdoor:** traffic, poison plants, leave living things unharmed.
8. If you cannot name the hazard and the adult control, do not run the try-it.
9. Poison Control **1-800-222-1222** if needed. "Non-toxic" does not mean edible.

⁵ACMI **AP** / **CL** product seals; materials labelled **Conforms to ASTM D-4236**. Follow the current package. No CL products through grade 6 per ACMI guidance for this age path. Poison Control: 1-800-222-1222. "Non-toxic" does not mean edible.

10. **Stop the hour when safety fails.** Looking and making continue another day.

When in doubt, do not run it. A chatbot cannot be the safety officer. Later chapters point back here in one sentence.

Dose honesty

If a day only holds twenty minutes: object + notice + short make + exit crumb. One named move done well beats a rushed craft medley. Three to five Art Hours plus one out-of-home try-it is a full week.

There is no nationally representative study of art minutes per day in U.S. homes that this book can quote.⁶ Public-school “minutes with a specialist” figures are school context — not a home failure metric.

Life of the habit (session rhythm — not a ninth chapter)

Revisit yesterday’s page. Mix last week’s mark into a warm-up. Stop while wanting one more mark.

That rhythm lives here, in later “done enough” checklists, and in the records you keep. This book does not invent a ninth teaching chapter titled “life of the habit.”

AI at the art hour (ages 5–10) — said once

The child looks at a real object and makes the mark. You may use a tool on your account. The child does not sit alone with an open chat or an unsupervised generator.

Ages 5–7: no live open chat as the child’s partner. You may generate a four-line SCRIPT for after the attempt, and you may ask a tool to explain a named page or invent still-life setups *to you*. No child-facing chat. No child account.

⁶Access date for program and product checks named in this edition: 24 September 2026. There is no nationally representative table of kitchen art minutes this book can quote.

Ages 8–10: still parent in the room. The child may sit next to you while you use a tool. They may hear a hint after they have tried. They may not have their own companion account. They may not be asked to “prompt the image tool until it looks finished.” Unaided first on looking and marking. SCRIPT after the try.

You may, on your account, after the child has tried (or before, for your prep):

1. Explain this week’s idea *to you* from a named textbook or lesson page — not to the child as a live partner.
2. Still-life setup ideas using objects already in the kitchen — then the child draws from the **objects**, not from tracing a generated mockup as the project.
3. A composition thumbnail to look at together (What’s cropped? Where is the darkest dark?), then **put it away** before the child draws from life or from a print on paper.
4. Sketchbook-challenge prompts the child will *draw* — the model wrote the list; the child made the marks.
5. A short labelled SCRIPT you will say *after* they look and mark — questions that keep *your* voice and the child’s eyes on the object or the page.
6. A hint after an attempt — a question or a named looking move, not a finished drawing.
7. Diagnose work they already produced (crop the photo to the **paper**, not the face) — then *you* talk to the child.
8. Discussion questions you will vet and ask yourself — the child answers you, not the tab.

You may not:

1. Ask the tool to **make my child’s project** or hang a generated image as Drawing.
2. **Turn in a generated image as student work** (name it generated if it appears in process notes; do not label it the child’s drawing).
3. Leave a **generator unsupervised during making** — not at 5, not at 10.
4. Ask the tool to **generate a “child drawing” / crayon-kids style picture as the child’s mark**.
5. Photograph a looking quiz for a filled-in key (**photo-to-key**).
6. Ask the tool to **write the child’s artist statement as the only draft**.
7. Run a **voice-clone “artist friend”** or companion that generates pictures when you leave the room.
8. **Upload the child’s face** into a generator.
9. **Detector-grade** the child’s drawing or short statement and call the score

honesty.

10. Invent research or trust a fluent citation / artist quote without opening the book.
11. Hand the child an agent (Hermes Agent, Grok Bot, or any cloud-computer worker) as an art partner.

Grids vs generators (one line): a grid, trace, or projector still goes through the child's eye and hand; a generator skips looking and marking. Grids can be misused. Generators used as the project are not the child's art.

One crutch sentence, labelled OFF-AGE for art hour, then teach: in a **high-school math** trial (not this art band), an unguarded chatbot made practice look better and left students worse on the test with the window closed (Bastani et al., 2025).⁷ This is a useful study, not a promise that every home will see the same result — and it is **not a 5–10 art experiment**. The paper itself notes creative subjects lack that kind of scoring. The kitchen-table rule it supports: the model may prepare the adult and the next looking page; it may not do the child's looking or marking when those are the lesson.

COPPA. Ages 5–10 are under 13. Parent holds the account always.⁸ Parent in the room. The 22 April 2026 compliance date has passed. Keep accounts, logs, and keys where you can open them. An art tool is not a secret friend.

Names that stay separate. Hermes 4 is not Hermes Agent. Grok is not Grok Bot and is not a national “Grok-as-tutor” program. Grok Imagine is not Grok Bot. There is no Grok Bot education product this book can honestly name as a school SKU. Game artist makes pictures, not an art course. Agents are not chatbots.

Detectors and fake citations (parent-side). Do not grade a child's contour from a detector score.⁹ If you asked a tool for a paper on looking, open Lowenfeld, Salome, or the National Core Arts Standards framework yourself.

⁷Hamsa Bastani, Osbert Bastani, Alp Sungu, Haosen Ge, Özge Kabakcı, and Rei Mariman, “Generative AI without Guardrails Can Harm Learning: Evidence from High School Mathematics,” *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences* 122, no. 26 (2025): e2422633122. Turkish high-school math; **OFF-AGE for art hour**. The paper notes creative subjects lack that kind of scoring.

⁸COPPA: Children's Online Privacy Protection Rule, 16 C.F.R. part 312; amended rule 90 Fed. Reg. 16918 (22 April 2025); general compliance date 22 April 2026.

⁹Weixin Liang et al., “GPT Detectors Are Biased Against Non-Native English Writers,” *Patterns* 4, no. 7 (2023). William H. Walters and Esther Isabelle Wilder, “Fabrication and Errors in the Bibliographic Citations Generated by ChatGPT,” *Scientific Reports* 13 (2023): 14045.

Later chapters point back here in one sentence. They do not reprint this box.

SCRIPT shapes (you say these; the child never chats)

After the child has looked and marked: “What do you notice?” → “Point to one thing your hand tried.” → “Tell me about your artwork — not whether it is pretty.”

Put any “right” names under PARENT KEY only. A generated still-life is not the mug on the table.

Ready to begin

You have the hour, the talk-box shape, the try-it shapes, the safety spine once, and the AI box once.

Chapter 1 puts look-before-name and make-before-polish on the table. Open tomorrow’s mug. Practice “What do you notice?” once. Then sit down.

Chapter 1



Figure 3: A looking mug beside a blank sticky and pencil — still-life, no people, no logos.

What art looks like at 5–10

Why this matters

Art at five to ten is not a waiting room for middle school. It is looking and making right now — with a mug on the table, a fat crayon, a torn scrap of paper, a short sit that ends while the child still wants one more mark.

Two flips unlock the whole book.

Look before name. Put the object or the picture first. Ask what they notice. Wait. Only then offer a light name — edge, texture, crop — if a name helps. Vocabulary after eyes, not instead of them.

Make before polish. The child's tool stays in the child's hand. A demo lives on demo paper. Accidents can be kept. Likeness is not the grade. The fridge picture proves a sitting happened; it is not the score.

These flips matter because the wrong week is easy to slip into. You name “still life” before anyone looks. You finish the dog's ear so it will look nice on the fridge. You hang a generated “kids crayon” picture and call it theirs. You wait until they are “ready,” or you run five crafts that match a sample and call the year Art. None of those teaches looking. None of those leaves the child's mark on the child's page.

What this chapter unlocks is a spine you can trust for every later Art Hour: notice first, mark first, talk that points at the work, place by skill not birthday, and stop while wanting one more mark. Later chapters add color puddles, tear collage, soft clay, captions, and short kitchen checks. They do not retire these two flips. If a week gets loud with materials and thin on eyes, return here.

A path through elementary art looking is the promise. A diploma is not. A percentile is not. An art-makes-you-smarter pitch is not. Coverage is a map. Depth is the hour.

Why struggle is allowed. Looking past the first obvious name is work. Leaving a wobbly line on the page is work. Waiting through silence is work. The struggle is the learning. Rescue too early and the child learns that the adult's hand is the real artist. Rescue too late with shame and the child learns that art is a talent audition. Ask, wait, hint, demo on demo paper, return the tool — that order keeps dignity and skill in the same Hour.

Why ordinary objects beat fancy kits this week. A mug already lives in your kitchen. A shoe already has edges worth following. Kits can wait. Coverage itch is the enemy of looking. One object, five notices, one open mark block, one talk box — that is a real Art Hour.

You do not need to be a studio artist. You do need to put the object on the table before the name, and to leave the child's mark on the child's page.

For the parent: understand it yourself

Many adults feel rusty on the art they were taught as coloring sheets and a laminated color wheel. That is normal, not a character flaw. Your job this week is not to become an MFA critic. Your job is to hear a name-first rush, an adult-filled mark, a “draw it nice” freeze, a coloring-book-as-only-hour week, a generated image filed as the child's work, a demo with no child's page, and a coverage lecture with no object on the table — and to ask one good question without grabbing the brush or filling the silence with “pretty.”

Everyday picture. Tomorrow morning, set one mug on the cleared table. Do not say “mug,” “still life,” or “cylinder.” Sit for one quiet minute and list five things you notice — the handle's shadow, a chip on the rim, the way the glaze pools near the base, a fingerprint in the dust, the oval of the opening from where you sit. Only after that list would you teach a word. That is look before name in your own body. If you catch yourself racing to a label, start the minute again.

Precise picture — maps, not verdicts. Teachers and researchers have long described how children's drawings often change across childhood. Lowenfeld and Brittain mapped typical graphic behaviors — a **map**, not a giftedness or delay verdict.¹⁰ Roughly: pre-schematic around ages 4–7 (marks and early symbols), schematic around 7–9 (repeated symbols that “stand for” things), dawning realism around 9–11 (more care about how things look). Use the map to choose a try-it, not to crown or shame a child. Davis's U-curve pattern about expressiveness judgments near 8–10 is a research pattern about how adults rate children's work —

¹⁰Viktor Lowenfeld and W. Lambert Brittain, *Creative and Mental Growth*: stages as a map of typical graphic behaviors (pre-schematic ~4–7; schematic ~7–9; dawning realism ~9–11) — not diagnosis or giftedness labels.

teach through a stiffer week; do not pathologize it as “not an art kid.”¹¹

The National Core Arts Standards (voluntary, dated 4 June 2014) name four processes — Creating, Presenting, Responding, Connecting — as a voluntary map for schools, not a mandate for your kitchen table.¹² Presenting still exists at home as the child’s choice of which page goes on the wall plus one reason — not as polish panic. NAEYC process defaults fit early years: process is the effect of making on the child. The fridge picture is evidence a sitting happened.¹³ It is not the grade.

REAP (Winner and Hetland) reviewed arts education research at scale (188 reports, 275 effect sizes, 10 meta-analyses in that project’s framing) and found that arts-rich education **correlates** with verbal and math indicators in some datasets; they did **not** find evidence that studying the arts **causes** those academic indicators to improve. This is a useful study map, not a promise that every home will see the same result. Justify art by what art teaches — looking, making, noticing, talking about work — not by a smarter-at-reading sales pitch.¹⁴

Studio Habits of Mind name eight studio habits from **high-school** studio research. Adapt lightly for a kitchen Hour (stretch and explore when a drip happens; observe; reflect). Do not claim a K–2 randomized trial from high-school studio findings.¹⁵ TEKS and other state element timing (for example, when “value” appears in a state list) are labelled state maps when you meet them — not universal kitchen law.

Grip and attention as limits, not excuses to withhold looking. Schneck and Henderson (1990) tracked mature pencil grips in young children (n=320, ages 3.0–6.11); mature grips rose from 48% to 90% across that span. Fat tools and short sits respect developing hands.¹⁶ CDC names attention of about 5–10 minutes for arts

¹¹Jessica Davis, U-curve / U-shaped pattern research on adult ratings of children’s expressive work near ~8–10: teach through a stiffer week; do not pathologize as “not an art kid.”

¹²National Core Arts Standards (voluntary; dated 4 June 2014): Creating, Presenting, Responding, Connecting — a voluntary school map, not a kitchen mandate.

¹³NAEYC process defaults for early years: process is the effect of making on the child; the fridge picture is evidence a sitting happened, not the grade.

¹⁴Ellen Winner and Lois Hetland, REAP project framing (188 reports / 275 effect sizes / 10 meta-analyses): arts–academic correlation in some datasets; no causal proof that arts study improves verbal/math — justify art by art.

¹⁵Studio Habits of Mind (Harvard Project Zero / high-school studio research origin): eight studio habits; adapt lightly for kitchen Art Hour — do not claim a K–2 RCT from high-school studio findings.

¹⁶Schneck and Henderson (1990): n=320, ages 3.0–6.11; mature grips rising ~48%→90% across that span — fat tools and short sits respect developing hands; useful context, not a promise

and crafts at age 5 as a milestone pattern; scissors skill at that age is a tip, not a locked milestone.¹⁷ Do not withhold looking from a five-year-old who can notice yellow dots. Do not dump grades 6–12 design, high-school Drawing credit, or AP Art and Design as the spine of this book. Those live in *Art for Homeschooling* if you need them later.

What this book is not (one pointer each, then teach). This book is not a reprint of *Art for Homeschooling* (grades 1–12 grade map, medium courses, portfolio for strangers, later solvents and kiln depth). One pointer, then teach five-to-ten looking and making here. It is not a sequel to *History for Little Thinkers*, *Science for Little Thinkers*, *Critical Thinking Skills for Little Thinkers*, *English for Little Thinkers*, or *Math for Little Thinkers*. Rhyme the grain of short sits and talk boxes; do not mash History’s piece-from-then or Science’s fair-test into the art spine. Never title the subject Little Thinkers Art I. The transcript title a stranger can read is **Art**.

Wrong answers you should be able to hear

1. **Name-first rush.** Child draws an almond “eye” or a circle “sun” without looking at *this* object. Usually means a symbol bank or vocabulary arrived before eyes. Fix: put the mug present; ask notices first (LOOK-01); catch it softly later with AS-03.
2. **Fridge-as-grade.** Success equals “pretty enough for the door.” Usually means process got swapped for display. Fix: child chooses whether a page goes up and can say one reason; still keep the messy try in the folder.
3. **“Wait until middle school for real art.”** Usually means fear of mess or a memory of craft mania. Fix: short open mark + notice this week; depth is the hour.
4. **“This will raise reading / math.”** Usually means a sales pitch replaced the art reason. Fix: one plain REAP mute sentence, then teach looking.
5. **Lowenfeld as gifted/delay label.** “She’s schematic so she’s behind / he’s gifted so skip looking.” Usually means map turned into identity. Fix: place by today’s skill — looking, mark control, talk — not by birthday or chart alone (AS-04).

Neighbor wrong turns you will meet again: adult-filled marks; “draw it nice”

every home matches the curve.

¹⁷CDC age-5 arts/crafts attention milestone pattern ~5–10 minutes; scissors skill as a tip, not a locked milestone.

freeze; coloring-book-as-only-hour; generated image as child's work; demo with no child's page. Chapter 3 owns authorship depth; Chapter 8 owns the full assessment shapes. Hear them early so you do not build a week on them.

Five-minute parent warm-up (alone, before the lesson). Set tomorrow's object or a blank sheet. Practice saying aloud: "What do you notice — before I tell you what this is called?" Count a slow three after you ask. Touch the object, not an answer key. Put the phone face down. If you invent a lecture in your head, erase it and look again. You are practicing wait, not rehearsing coverage.

How to teach it this week

Session shape (Art Hour, ~20–40 min). Five beats you already met in the Art Hour chapter:

1. **Look / notice** — 3–8 minutes. Object or image present. Caption covered if there is one.
2. **Short make** — 8–18 minutes. Child holds the tool. Demo on demo paper only.
3. **Talk box** — 3–8 minutes. Locked opening below. Wait.
4. **Name lightly** — 2–5 minutes. Optional. Can wait until tomorrow.
5. **Exit crumb / show choice** — 2–5 minutes. Notice / make / wonder; optional wall choice with one reason.

Dose honesty: three to five Hours this week beat one marathon craft day. Stop while they still want one more mark.

Exact wording you can say.

- Opening (locked): "What do you notice — before I tell you what this is called?"
- After a silence: "I'm looking at the handle. What do you see?"
- Before make: "Your tool. My demo stays on this other paper."
- Mid-make (if they freeze): "One more mark. You choose where."
- After make: "Tell me one thing your hand tried."
- If they ask "is it good?": "Tell me what you notice on your page."
- Exit: "One notice, one make move, one wonder — sticky note or say it."

- Show choice: “Does this page want the wall, the folder, or the recycle — and why?”

First try-it for the student this week. LOOK-01 Object Before Name with a mug or shoe, then MARK-01 Child’s First Mark Block on large paper with a fat crayon. No sample to match. No “draw a mug” prompt until after free mark — and even then, prefer “follow one edge after looking” later in the week or in Chapter 3.

How to fade help.

- Day 1: You may point at one edge after they speak a notice.
- Day 2: You wait longer; paraphrase one notice without adding vocabulary.
- Day 3: They lead the notice list; you only ask the opening.
- Any day: hands off their page. Struggle before rescue — ask, wait, hint, short demo on *demo paper*, return the tool.

When to stop talking. After you ask the opening, wait. After they answer, wait again. If they are mid-look or mid-mark, do not cut them off. Name lightly only after looking and making — or skip naming until tomorrow. Specific noticing (“yellow dots near the rim”) beats generic praise.

Age-band moves inside this week

5–7. Look-heavy. Fat crayons, tempera sticks, large paper taped down. Oral exit crumbs; you may scribe their words on a sticky note. Process over likeness. Tear and open mark beat fancy cut this week. Keep sits inside honest attention windows; a second short sit beats one drained hour. Playdough and air-dry arrive in later chapters — this week’s spine is notice + free mark.

8–10. Slightly longer look and make. They can try a slower rim follow after looking (preview of LINE-04 in Chapter 3) once free mark has happened. Written three-word crumb if ready (WRITE-01 soft preview). If looking habits are weak — name-first drawings, freeze at “draw it nice,” only coloring-book talk — stay on 5–7 LOOK/MARK longer. Place by skill, not birthday (AS-04). Refuse MFA critique voice; keep kitchen warmth.

This-week plan (honest object). One focus: look before name + one open mark. Three to five Hours. One out-of-home try-it. Friday: exit crumb + name-first catch soft.

Day	Focus	Try-it
Mon	Notice before name	LOOK-01 Object Before Name
Tue	Open mark	MARK-01 Child's First Mark Block
Wed	Talk that points	TALK-03 Yellow Dots Notice on Tuesday's page
Thu	Placement soft	AS-04 Band Placement Soft with recent folder
Fri	Exit + diagnostic	AS-01 Exit Crumb Trio + AS-03 Name-First Catch
Weekend OUT	One look	OUT-04 Library Picture-Book Look First <i>or</i> OUT-01 if a museum day is open

Refuse: 180-day spreadsheet; five crafts Monday; product-only fridge as the only success metric.

Practice that actually builds learning

Named try-its below include time, materials, mess/safety, the fun, and the skill. Practice lives **in the home and outside it**. Library, walk, museum, kitchen, and window *are* the practice — they do not replace the look-before-name move; they host it.

In-home — LOOK-01 Object Before Name

- **Time:** 10–20 min
- **Materials:** One ordinary object (mug, shoe, leaf, key); blank paper optional
- **Mess / safety:** Low mess; table clear of food; adult present
- **The fun:** Silence feels like a game. Five notices before any adult art word.
- **The skill:** Eyes before vocabulary; wait craft; refuse name-first.

Steps. Clear the table. Place the object. Cover any label if there is one. Say the locked opening. Silent look about 60–90 seconds. Child names five notices. Only then may you lightly say a word if it helps — “rim,” “shadow” — or wait until tomorrow. Optional: quick sketch after notices, not before.

Stuck pattern. Child shrugs and says “it’s a mug.” Reply: “Yes — and what do you *notice* on it before we use any art words?” Point at the object. Wait.

In-home — MARK-01 Child’s First Mark Block

- **Time:** 15–25 min
- **Materials:** Large paper taped down; fat crayon or tempera stick (look for ACMI AP seal and/or “Conforms to ASTM D-4236”); table cover
- **Mess / safety:** Low–med; cover table; washable preferred; food/drinks off the art area; wash hands after; no solvents; read the current label (“non-toxic” does not mean edible)
- **The fun:** No “draw a ___” for the first 5–8 minutes. Freedom is the point.
- **The skill:** Authorship; tool in child’s hand; make before polish.

Steps. Tape paper so it does not slide. Hand over the tool — do not hover with a second crayon “just in case.” Free mark block. Your hands stay off their page. Demo, if any, on demo paper only, then cover it (MARK-05 depth in Chapter 3). Stop while they still want one more mark. Optional process photo of hands and paper — crop to the work; do not upload the child’s face into a generator.

Stuck pattern. “I don’t know what to draw.” Reply: “You don’t have to draw a thing-with-a-name yet. Make marks. Fast ones. Slow ones. Your choice.”

In-home — LOOK-08 Window Frame Find (warm-up companion)

- **Time:** 10–20 min
- **Materials:** Window; cardboard viewfinder or hands as frame
- **Mess / safety:** Low; no climbing sills
- **The fun:** Framing a slice of the world like a tiny movie.
- **The skill:** Notice edges that cut objects; name “crop” lightly only after looking.

In-home — AS-04 Band Placement Soft

- **Time:** 10 min

- **Materials:** Recent folder of work (a few pages is enough)
- **Mess / safety:** —
- **The fun:** Sorting “what my hand can do” without a birthday lecture.
- **The skill:** Place by looking, mark control, and talk — not by age alone.

Lay out three piles soft: “notices came easy,” “marks felt free,” “needed more looking first.” An eight-year-old may still need 5–7 LOOK/MARK. That is placement, not failure. A five-year-old who notices carefully and marks boldly may stretch toward longer sits — still fat tools, still short honesty.

In-home — AS-06 Done-Enough Checklist Soft (preview)

- **Time:** 5 min
- **Materials:** This week’s focus sticky note
- **Mess / safety:** —
- **The fun:** A short yes-list instead of a perfect sample.
- **The skill:** Done enough = looked, made with own mark, talked once, left a crumb — not identical to a sample.

In-home — AS-01 Exit Crumb Trio (Friday shape)

- **Time:** 5 min
- **Materials:** Sticky notes
- **Mess / safety:** Low
- **The fun:** Three tiny tickets out the door of the Hour.
- **The skill:** Reflect without grading.

Exit: (1) one notice, (2) one make move, (3) one wonder. Not a grade. Adult may scribe at 5–7.

Out-of-home — OUT-04 Library Picture-Book Look First

- **Time:** 20–30 min
- **Materials:** Picture book; card or sticky to cover words until after looking
- **Mess / safety:** Low; library manners
- **The fun:** Pictures first feels like a secret spy mission.
- **The skill:** Notice before story dump; same flip as the mug.

Steps. Choose one spread. Cover the text. Silent look. Ask notices with the locked opening adapted to the page (“What do you notice — before we read what this is

called?”). Then uncover and read. National survey tables show library visits are common among homeschool families in a past-month window — use the outing as looking practice. Browsing alone is not Art Hour; this sit is.

Out-of-home — OUT-01 Museum One Work Sit (when available)

- **Time:** 20–40 min at site
- **Materials:** Museum or gallery; optional tiny sketchbook; follow no-touch rules
- **Mess / safety:** Venue rules; adult present
- **The fun:** One work only — scavenger mania off.
- **The skill:** Depth over coverage; notice before the wall label.

Steps. Child helps choose one work (OUT-07 ownership soft). Cover or ignore the label first. Silent look. Notices. Optional tiny sketch of one edge. Then read the label if you want. Art gallery/museum/historical site visits also show up in homeschool outing rows — motivate with the outing; still run look-before-name.¹⁸

If museum is not this week, the library sit still counts as OUT. A grocery produce aisle with three different greens (OUT-05) can wait for the color chapter; this week’s OUT stays on looking without a name race.

Talk box (this chapter)

Opening (locked): “What do you notice — before I tell you what this is called?”

Follow-ups (3–5):

1. **Look:** “What do you see on the rim / in the shadow / in the shiny spot?”
2. **Make:** “What did your hand try on the big paper?”
3. **Evidence:** “What do you see that makes you say that?”
4. **Process / check:** “Whose mark is on this page?”
5. **Revise:** “You may change your mind — look again. What else? Keep the drip — what could it become?”

How to wait. After you ask, a slow three is a classroom-origin pause craft (Rowe’s elementary science wait-time work; Stahl’s think-time) used here as Art Hour

¹⁸NCES homeschool outing rows (library; art gallery/museum/historical site) motivate looking practice; they do not replace look-before-name.

pause craft — labelled classroom-origin, not an art RCT, not a kitchen wait coefficient.¹⁹ After they stop talking, wait again. If they are mid-look or mid-mark, do not cut them off. If silence is hard, look at the object or the page, not at the child.

What a stuck silence usually means. The question was vague; wait-time was zero; they are hunting a vocabulary word because you asked name-first; they are waiting for you to finish the dog; they fear “draw it nice”; every hour has been coloring-book lines; they point at a phone image as “my art”; they shrug at “what is it?” (bad question — use notice / tell-me); the caption was uncovered before looking. Pose, wait, point back at the object or page. Do not fill with “pretty.” Do not turn the table into a fight.

Blocked for a new move. Name-first drawing; adult finishing marks; “wait until middle school”; art-makes-you-smarter as the reason to sit; Lowenfeld chart as identity; generated image in the child-work folder.

Mixed — when to use this week’s spine. Every Art Hour from here forward. Color, collage, clay, talk/write, and short assessments add moves; they ride on look-before-name and make-before-polish.

One incorrect example to diagnose (illustration, not a reported family). Parent uncovers a postcard caption, says “This is Cubism,” then asks the child to “draw it nice like the sample.” Child freezes, then copies a phone JPEG of a “kids drawing style” picture into the folder labelled Drawing. Diagnosis: explain-before-look + polish pressure + generated-as-mark. Rescue order: cover the caption; LOOK-01 with a real mug; MARK-01 with the child’s crayon; AS-02 honesty that tool-made images are not their mark; delete the JPEG from the child-work folder; keep process notes truthful.

Mixed practice notes for the week

Blocked. Do not start the Hour with a vocabulary list. Do not leave a sample collage or printed “how it should look” on the table during MARK-01. Do not praise only neatness. Do not use the Hour to lecture about famous movements before eyes have worked.

¹⁹Mary Budd Rowe (1972) wait-time and Robert J. Stahl (1994) think-time: classroom-origin pause craft used here for Art Hour — not a kitchen art experiment.

Mixed — combine lightly. LOOK-01 then MARK-01 in one Hour is enough. Add TALK-03 on a later day, not as a seventh beat that crowds out making. AS-04 belongs once midweek when you have a few pages, not as a daily chart.

Materials still-life for this spine week (illustration). Mug; fat crayons; large paper; tape; sticky notes; one picture book with a card to cover text; optional cardboard viewfinder. No solvents. No craft knives. No need for a full studio kit.

Mess honesty preview (SAFE-05 soft). Tell yourself and the child before Tuesday's mark block: "This hour may leave crayon on the table cover. That is expected. We wash hands after." Product-only fridge hour is not the goal of the week.

Safety spine reminder (full detail in Art Hour). Adult present. Materials with ACMI AP and/or Conforms to ASTM D-4236. No CL products through grade 6. No solvents (no turpentine, mineral spirits, solvent adhesives as kitchen art). Labelled children's scissors when cutting arrives in later chapters. Cover the table. Food and drinks out of the art area. Wash hands. Poison Control 1-800-222-1222 if needed. Read the current label.

What success feels like by Friday. You hear notices before titles. You see a page that is clearly theirs. You used the locked opening and survived a silence. You did not need a percentile. You know whether this child needs more 5–7 looking or can stretch an 8–10 rim follow next week — by skill, not by birthday cake.

Companion talk moves you can borrow this week

These are portable from the TALK bank; Chapter 7 owns them in depth.

- **TALK-03 Yellow Dots Notice:** "Look at all the ____ you made." Description as care (NAEYC noticing grain). Use on Tuesday's mark page Wednesday.
- **TALK-01 Tell Me About It:** Replace "What is it?" with "Tell me about your artwork." Wait.
- **TALK-02 Point With Words:** Describe by pointing with words. Specific noticing beats "pretty."

Keep talk short this week. Do not turn the talk box into a second lecture. One authentic question + wait is the craft.

Band placement soft — worked kitchen picture (illustration)

You lay out four pages from two weeks. Page A: free marks, bold, child can say “I pressed hard.” Page B: almond eyes and a sun disk with no object present when drawn. Page C: a careful rim start that stopped when an adult offered to “just fix it.” Page D: a coloring sheet finished neatly.

Reading by skill: Page A suggests ready for more LOOK + longer MARK. Page B needs LOOK-01 with a real object (name-first catch). Page C needs cover-the-demo and hands-off (Chapter 3). Page D is fine as a quiet toy but is not the Art Hour (AS-05). Birthday is irrelevant to that reading. An eight-year-old with mostly Page B work stays on 5–7 looking longer. A six-year-old with mostly Page A work still uses fat tools and short sits — stretch looking, not polish.

Friday diagnostic mini-script

1. Put the same mug back on the table.
2. Ask the locked opening. Wait.
3. If notices come, celebrate the looking with specific words — not “good job” alone.
4. Peek at a recent named-object drawing. If it is symbol-only, say warmly: “Tomorrow we look at *this* mug again before we draw any part of it.”
5. AS-01 sticky: notice / make / wonder.
6. Done-enough checklist soft — then stop. Do not add a sixth craft to “catch up.”

For the student

Art hour is looking and making — not guessing the right name first.

Here is the idea in one line: **look first, then make your own mark.**

You are a person who can notice. You are a person who can hold a tool. You do not have to be “an art kid” to belong at this table. You belong because you look and you try.

Tiny worked example. Imagine a blue mug on the table. You look without talking for a little while. Then you say: “There’s a shiny spot. The handle makes a dark shape. There’s a tiny chip. The top looks like an oval from here.” Only later might

someone say “rim” or “shadow.” Then you get a fat crayon and a big paper taped so it does not slide. You mark for a few minutes — swirls, presses, quiet lines. Nobody finishes your page for you. That page is yours. Maybe you choose it for the wall. Maybe it goes in a folder. Either way, you can say one thing you notice on it.

Try 1 — Notice five. Pick one thing on the table (mug, shoe, leaf, key). Look quietly. Tell five things you notice before anyone says the art word. You may change your mind when you look again.

Try 2 — First mark block. Tape a big paper down. Hold a fat crayon. Mark freely for several minutes. No “draw a perfect ____” yet. Stop when you still want one more mark.

Explain it back. Tell a grown-up in your own words: What does “look before name” mean? What does “my mark” mean? What is one thing you are *not* supposed to pretend is your drawing (hint: a picture a machine made)?

Challenge. At the library (or with a picture book at home), cover the words on one page. Look. Notice. Then uncover. Same game as the mug. If you visit a museum, pick **one** work and sit with it — not a race through every room.

You are allowed to wait. You are allowed to keep a drip or a smudge if you want to turn it into something. You are allowed to say a page is yours. You are allowed to say you want the folder instead of the fridge.

If it isn’t clicking

Diagnostic 1 — Everything becomes a vocabulary quiz. They freeze until you say the “right” word. Next move: cover labels for two whole Hours; ask only notices; name lightly tomorrow or not at all this week. Put the object back on the table every time the talk drifts to quiz mode.

Diagnostic 2 — They only color inside printed lines. Sheets as the only hour; talk is only about staying in the lines. Next move: demote coloring books to optional quiet toys; schedule MARK-01 and LOOK-01 as the Art Hour. Chapter 8’s AS-05 owns the full coloring-book-only flag — plant the habit now.

Diagnostic 3 — “I can’t draw” / talent shame rose early. Looking got ahead

of the hand, or polish arrived too soon, or an adult finished yesterday's dog. Next move: shorten the task to free mark or one rim; refuse talent lectures; struggle before rescue — ask, wait, hint, short demo on *demo paper*, return the tool. Do not grab the brush. Do not fill silence with “pretty.”

Extra pattern — phone JPEG as “my art.” Honesty first (AS-02): tool-made is not their mark. Delete from child-work folder. Start MARK-01 today.

When to slow down. Name-first drawings dominate; adult hands keep “helping”; silence never gets a wait; every success metric is fridge polish.

When to go ahead. Child offers notices before titles; open mark happens without a matched sample; exit crumb is spoken or sticky-noted; they can say whose mark is on the page.

When to get a human tutor. Persistent pain, sensory distress with materials, or a need beyond kitchen Art Hour — seek a person who knows children's art and your child. A Lowenfeld chart is not a clinic. Screening is not an identity verdict.

Never correct the look by crushing it. Rescue order is ask, wait, hint, short demo on demo paper, return the tool. “Never correct the child” is not this book's rule — correct a wrong *reason* kindly (name-first, adult-filled marks, generated-as-theirs) without grabbing the brush.

Tools, including AI

Keep this short. The full Art Hour AI box lives in the front matter — point back there for allows, bans, COPPA, and the Bastani off-age caution.²⁰

Parent holds the account. Ages 5–10 are under 13. Parent in the room. Ages 5–7: no live open chat as the child's partner. Ages 8–10: still parent in the room.

Useful this chapter (to you, the adult):

²⁰Bastani et al. (2025) high-school math chatbot trial: **OFF-AGE for art hour** — one caution in The Art Hour. COPPA under-13: parent holds the account. Safety spine: ACMI AP and/or ASTM D-4236; no CL through grade 6; no solvents; labelled children's scissors; mess honesty; Poison Control 1-800-222-1222 if needed. Access date 24 September 2026. Limit line: useful study context, not a promise every home will see the same result.

- Invent three kitchen still-life setups using objects you already own — then the child looks at the **objects**.
- A labelled SCRIPT after the try — sentences *you* say, not an artist statement for them to copy.
- Discussion questions you will vet and ask yourself.
- Explain look-before-name *to you* from today's mug plan.

Not useful / not allowed as the lesson: make-my-child's-project; turn in a generated image as their drawing; generate a “kids crayon” picture as their mark; unsupervised generator during making; write their artist statement as the only draft; upload the child's face; detector-grade a drawing. A fluent finished picture from a machine is performance, not their looking. Grids and traces still pass through eye and hand; generators skip looking and marking.

Unaided first on looking and marking. SCRIPT after the try. Details: see The Art Hour.

What “done enough” looks like

Before you move on from this spine week, check:

- ☐ You can state the two flips in plain words: look before name; make before polish.
- ☐ The child noticed something on a real object *before* an art vocabulary word.
- ☐ One open mark session happened without a matched sample; child's tool, child's page.
- ☐ Talk box used the locked opening at least once; you waited after asking.
- ☐ Exit crumb happened (notice / make / wonder — oral or sticky).
- ☐ Placement thought used skill (looking, mark, talk), not birthday alone.
- ☐ No generated image filed as the child's drawing; demo stayed on demo paper if you demoed.
- ☐ You stopped at least one Hour while they still wanted one more mark.
- ☐ One OUT or library picture-book look-first happened, or is scheduled for this weekend.

A “grade 2 art workbook” is a publisher's scope, not a legal grade, and not a transcript line. The subject title a stranger can read is **Art** — never a brand, never

Little Thinkers Art I. Dated sketchbook + looking note + child's make (+ optional process photo) live inside Art.

Done enough is not identical to the sample on the box. Done enough is looked, made with own mark, talked once, left a crumb.

Revisit next Tuesday if the flips slipped. Mix last week's free mark with a new object. Life of the habit is rhythm, not a ninth teaching chapter.

Chapter 2

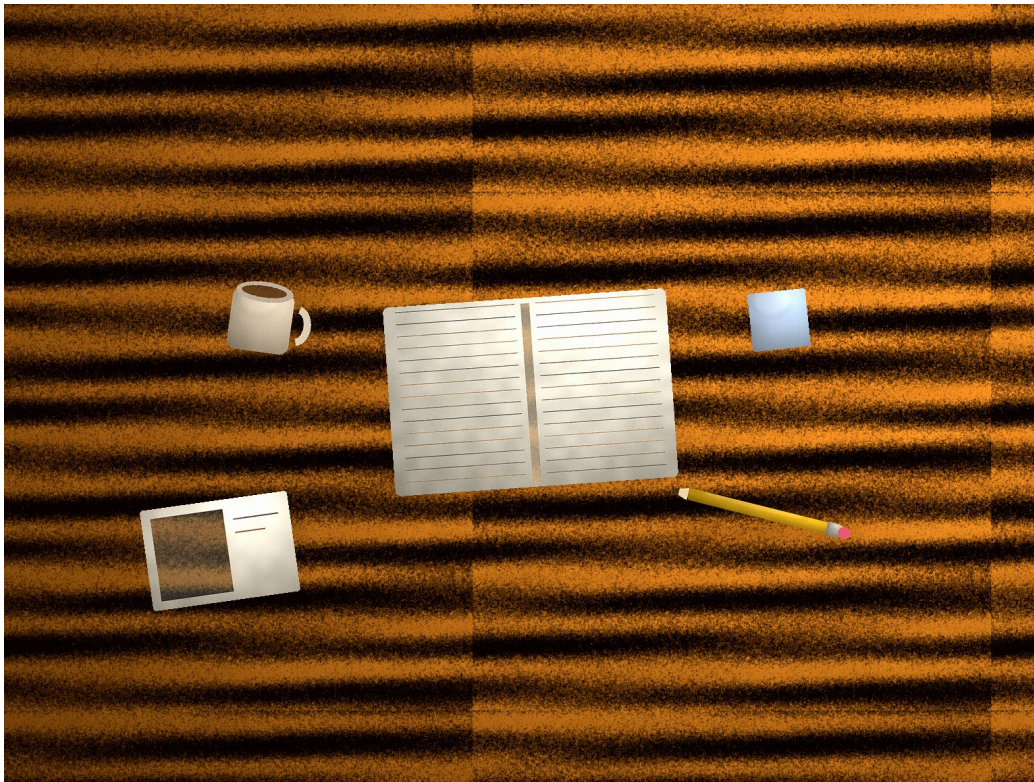


Figure 4: A mug, open sketchbook, and soft postcard for looking — still-life, no people, no logos.

Looking at art and objects

Why this matters

Looking is a skill you can practice on a mug, a postcard, a library picture book, a window slice, and one museum work — not a talent you either woke up with or missed.

This chapter owns the eyes. Chapter 1 gave you the spine: look before name; make before polish. Here you learn how to *run* looking — caption covered, silence first, notices with evidence, texture with eyes and hands, the same object in two lights, a fridge tour that talks process instead of “pretty,” a window frame that crops the world, and one focused sit outside the home.

Without this chapter, Art Hour drifts into scavenger mania at the museum, “guess the famous artist,” uncovering the caption first, or explaining the picture before anyone has looked. With it, a five-year-old can notice yellow dots and a rough patch of bark. An eight-to-ten-year-old can add evidence talk — what they see that makes them say that — and a soft VTS three-question sit when the image has a little mystery.

Looking matters because making without looking becomes symbol-copy and polish panic. Talk without looking becomes empty preference. Outings without looking become worksheets that never look twice. The move is simple and hard: put the work or the object first, ask what they see, wait, ask what makes them say that, wait again.

Library, museum, gallery, grocery aisle, and nature walk motivate. They do not replace the look-before-name move. They are where you practice it with new things to see.

Why struggle is allowed. Staying with one image when your feet want the next room is work. Saying “because I see the dark rectangle” instead of “I don’t know” is work. Letting a child’s story differ from the wall label — while still asking for evidence — is work. Rescue too early with the “right” title and they learn looking is a quiz. Shame a wrong story and they learn silence is safer than eyes. Ask for evidence. Wait. Look again together.

Why ordinary looking beats fancy culture quizzes this week. A covered postcard teaches the same flip as a famous canvas. Depth is the hour. Coverage is a

map. One work, well seen, beats twenty works checked off.

You do not need museum membership to teach looking. You need one image, one object, one question, and the courage to wait. That is enough to begin — and enough to repeat next Tuesday when the flips slip.

Shared looking and outings motivate — and still need the move. A family that loves museums but always reads the plaque first is practicing culture, not yet practicing Art Hour looking. Keep the love. Add caption cover. A family that never leaves home can still run LOOK-02 and LOOK-01 richly; schedule OUT-04 at the library when you can. Neither family is behind if eyes work first.

Process on the fridge is looking too. When you tour prior work, you are looking at the child's marks as evidence of sittings — not grading prettiness. That habit stitches Chapter 1's process lock to this chapter's eyes.

For the parent: understand it yourself

Many adults were trained to read the plaque first and the painting second. That habit feels responsible. In Art Hour it steals the lesson. Your job is to become fluent enough in looking craft to hear caption-first, scavenger mania, guess-the-artist, explain-before-look, and pretty-only talk — and to put eyes back on the work without scolding.

Everyday picture. Take a postcard or a picture-book page. Cover the title and any wall-label words with a sticky note. Set a quiet minute. List five notices without saying the artist's name or the story. Only then uncover. Notice how fast your brain wanted the caption. That itch is what your child feels when you uncover first.

Precise picture. Several looking traditions travel into a kitchen talk box without becoming a museum course. Project Zero's See–Think–Wonder offers three stems: What do you see? What do you think about that? What does it make you wonder?²¹ Visual Thinking Strategies (VTS) offers a family of three questions often used with narrative images: What's going on in this picture? What do you see that makes you say that? What more can you find? Parent paraphrase and pointing matter

²¹Project Zero See–Think–Wonder stems: What do you see? What do you think about that? What does it make you wonder?

more than praise contests.²² Barrett’s “point with words” keeps talk specific.²³ NAEYC noticing grain (“look at all the yellow dots”) treats description as care. Kennedy Center “Start with the Arts” grain supports picture-first before text in picture books. None of these require you to become a docent.²⁴ All of them refuse explain-before-look.

Caption cover is the practical lock. If the label is visible, many children hunt for the “right” answer instead of looking. Cover it. Look. Talk. Then uncover if you want the name.

Object looking still belongs beside picture looking. A mug under two lights teaches edges and shadows before anyone says “value.” Fabric and bark teach texture before the quiz word. A window viewfinder teaches crop before the vocabulary sentence. Fridge work teaches process talk when you refuse pretty-only.

Wrong answers you should be able to hear

1. **Uncover caption first.** Child freezes or recites the title. Usually means explain-before-look. Fix: cover; LOOK-02; wait.
2. **Scavenger mania at the museum.** Clipboard race through twenty works; no second look. Usually means coverage itch. Fix: OUT-01 one-work sit; optional OUT-07 child choice.
3. **“Guess the famous artist.”** Quiz replaced noticing. Usually means adult anxiety about culture knowledge. Fix: notices and evidence first; name lightly after, or tomorrow.
4. **Explain-before-look.** Adult story-dumps the myth or the movement before eyes work. Usually means teaching urge outran the Hour. Fix: silent look; then “What do you see?”
5. **Empty pretty loop.** Only talk is “I like it” / “It’s pretty.” Usually means preference without evidence. Fix: TALK-02 point with words; locked opening with “what makes you say that?”

Neighbor patterns: name-first drawing when looking never happened (return to Chapter 1 + AS-03); pointing at a phone JPEG as “my art” (AS-02 honesty —

²²Visual Thinking Strategies (VTS) three-question family protocol — soft kitchen use with point + paraphrase; not a franchise requirement.

²³Terry Barrett, “point with words”: keep talk specific to what is on the page or object.

²⁴NAEYC noticing grain for description as care; Kennedy Center Start with the Arts grain: pictures before text in picture books.

looking week still needs authorship honesty).

Five-minute parent warm-up. Cover a caption on any image in the house. Practice aloud: “What do you see — and what do you see that makes you say that?” Count a slow three. Paraphrase your own notice without adding a lecture. Put the phone away. Tomorrow you will ask the child the same way.

How to teach it this week

Parent fluency goal for Friday. You can hear caption-first in your own mouth and stop mid-sentence. You can paraphrase a child’s notice without upgrading it into a lecture. You can walk past nineteen works to sit with one. You can leave a label covered until after the talk box. If those four are true, looking is becoming a habit in the adult — which is half the teaching.

Student fluency goal for Friday. They can offer a notice before a title. They can add one because-I-see. They can survive a short silence. They can choose whether a tiny edge sketch goes in the folder. If those are true, eyes are working — which is the whole point of this chapter.

Session shape. Keep Art Hour’s five beats (~20–40 min). This week beat 1 (look/notice) grows — often 5–10 minutes. Beat 2 (make) can be a tiny edge sketch, a texture rubbing, or a quick window crop sketch — looking still leads. Beat 3 uses this chapter’s locked opening. Beat 4 names lightly after, or waits until tomorrow. Beat 5 exit crumb: one notice, one evidence phrase (“because I see...”), one wonder; optional show choice.

Dose honesty: three strong looking sits beat seven rushed ones. Stop while they still want one more look.

Exact wording you can say.

- Opening (locked): “What do you see — and what do you see that makes you say that?”
- Silent start: “We’ll look without talking first. I’ll tell you when.”
- After silence: “What’s going on here?” (VTS soft) or “What do you see?” (See–Think–Wonder soft)
- Evidence nudge: “What do you see that makes you say that?”
- More: “What more can you find?”

- Paraphrase: “You’re noticing the dark shape under the handle — did I get that right?”
- Texture: “Feel this one. Where else do your eyes see something like that?”
- Two lights: “What changed when the flashlight moved?”
- After uncover: “The label says _____. Does that change what you notice, or not?”
- Exit: “One see, one because-I-see, one wonder.”

First try-it for the student. LOOK-02 Picture Silence Then Notice with a post-card or picture-book page, caption covered. Same day or next: LOOK-01 with a real mug so looking stays tied to objects, not only reproductions.

How to fade help. Early week you model one paraphrase. Midweek you only ask the questions. Late week the child leads “what more can you find?” Do not turn paraphrase into a grade. Do not correct a wrong story mid-look — ask for evidence.

When to stop talking. During silent look — stop. After each question — wait. If they point, let the point finish. If you feel a lecture rising about a movement or artist, write it on a sticky for *tomorrow* and return to notices today.

Age-band moves

5–7. Picture silence + notices (LOOK-02). See–Think–Wonder soft (LOOK-03) with short stems. Texture eyes-and-hands (LOOK-05). Fridge gallery as process talk (LOOK-07). Window frame (LOOK-08). Oral evidence (“because of the dark line”). Adult may scribe. VTS three is a stretch — use lightly if the image has mystery; do not force long protocol. Keep sits inside honest attention windows.

8–10. Add LOOK-04 VTS Three Soft on a narrative image with mystery. Same object two lights (LOOK-06). Stronger evidence talk and “what more.” Written because-I-see crumb soft (WRITE-02 preview). Architecture edge walk (OUT-06) as stretch OUT. If looking habits are weak — caption hunt, pretty-only, scavenger itch — stay longer on 5–7 silence and notices before VTS length. Place by skill, not birthday.

This-week plan (honest object)

Day	Focus	Try-it
Mon	Caption cover + silence	LOOK-02 Picture Silence Then Notice
Tue	Object looking	LOOK-01 Object Before Name
Wed	STW or VTS soft	LOOK-03 (5–7) or LOOK-04 (8–10)
Thu	Texture or two lights	LOOK-05 or LOOK-06
Fri	Fridge process tour + crumb	LOOK-07 + AS-01 Exit Crumb Trio
Weekend OUT	One focused look	OUT-01 or OUT-07; else OUT-04 library picture-book look first

Optional swap: LOOK-08 window frame on a rainy day instead of texture. Refuse: scavenger worksheet as the only museum plan; five artist biographies Monday.

Practice that actually builds learning

Named try-its include time, materials, mess/safety, the fun, and the skill. Practice lives **in the home and outside it**. Library, walk, museum, kitchen, and window *are* the practice — they host the looking move; they do not replace it.

In-home — LOOK-02 Picture Silence Then Notice

- **Time:** 10–20 min
- **Materials:** One reproduction / picture-book page / postcard; caption covered with sticky or card
- **Mess / safety:** Low
- **The fun:** Secret looking before the “answer” appears.
- **The skill:** Silence; notices; refuse explain-before-look.

Steps. Cover caption. Silent look. Ask “What do you notice?” Wait a slow three (classroom-origin pause craft). No story dump yet. Collect notices. Uncover last.

Stuck. Child peeks under the sticky. Smile: “Eyes first — we’ll read after.” Recover.

In-home — LOOK-01 Object Before Name

- **Time:** 10–20 min
- **Materials:** Mug, shoe, leaf, or key; blank paper optional
- **Mess / safety:** Low; food off table
- **The fun:** Ordinary object becomes interesting.
- **The skill:** Object before vocabulary — Chapter 1 spine inside looking week.

In-home — LOOK-03 See–Think–Wonder Soft

- **Time:** 15–25 min
- **Materials:** Artwork or interesting object; three sticky notes or paper columns
- **Mess / safety:** Low
- **The fun:** Three columns feel like a tiny lab of eyes.
- **The skill:** See / think / wonder with evidence talk.

Steps. Columns: See / Think / Wonder. Fill See first with observable notices. Think only after See has words — and ask what they see that makes them think that. Wonder last. Adult paraphrases; does not grade.

In-home — LOOK-04 VTS Three Soft (band 8–10; stretch 5–7)

- **Time:** 15–25 min
- **Materials:** Narrative image with some mystery; no caption
- **Mess / safety:** Low
- **The fun:** Detective talk without a single right plot.
- **The skill:** What’s going on? Evidence? What more?

Steps. Ask the three. Point and paraphrase. No praise contest. No “actually it’s ____” mid-protocol. Name lightly after if needed.

In-home — LOOK-05 Texture Eyes-and-Hands

- **Time:** 15–25 min
- **Materials:** 3–5 safe textured objects (fabric, bark rubbing paper, sandpaper scrap)
- **Mess / safety:** Low–med; wash hands; choke check for younger siblings
- **The fun:** Touch-and-sort before the vocabulary quiz.

- **The skill:** Look and touch; sort by feel/look before naming “texture.”

In-home — LOOK-06 Same Object Two Lights

- **Time:** 15–25 min
- **Materials:** One object; window light + flashlight; optional quick sketch
- **Mess / safety:** Low
- **The fun:** Magician light changes the same mug.
- **The skill:** Notice edges/shadows before naming “value” or “shade.”

In-home — LOOK-07 Fridge Gallery Tour

- **Time:** 10–20 min
- **Materials:** Family fridge / wall of prior work
- **Mess / safety:** Low
- **The fun:** Child as curator of their own wall.
- **The skill:** Process talk; specific noticing; refuse pretty-only.

Steps. Child picks one piece. “Tell me about how you made it — not whether it is pretty.” Adult offers specific noticing (“I see repeated dashes in the corner”).

In-home — LOOK-08 Window Frame Find

- **Time:** 10–20 min
- **Materials:** Window; cardboard viewfinder or hands as frame
- **Mess / safety:** Low; no climbing sills
- **The fun:** Crop the world like a tiny movie.
- **The skill:** Edges that cut objects; “crop” named lightly after looking.

Out-of-home — OUT-01 Museum One Work Sit

- **Time:** 20–40 min at site
- **Materials:** Museum/gallery; sketchbook optional; follow no-touch rules
- **Mess / safety:** Venue rules; adult present
- **The fun:** One deep sit beats a blur of rooms.
- **The skill:** Depth; label after looking.

Steps. Choose one work. Ignore label first. Silent look. Locked opening. Optional tiny edge sketch. Then label. Refuse scavenger mania.

Out-of-home — OUT-07 Gallery Child Choice

- **Time:** 20–40 min
- **Materials:** Museum; child’s pick
- **Mess / safety:** Venue rules
- **The fun:** They choose; you follow.
- **The skill:** Ownership of looking.

Out-of-home — OUT-04 Library Picture-Book Look First

- **Time:** 20–30 min
- **Materials:** Picture book; cover words until after looking
- **Mess / safety:** Low; library manners
- **The fun:** Spy mission on the pictures.
- **The skill:** Pictures before text — same flip as caption cover.

National survey tables show library visits and museum/gallery/historical-site visits appearing in homeschool outing rows for a past-month window — use those outings as looking practice. Browsing or gift-shop time is not the Art Hour; the sit is.²⁵

Out-of-home stretch — OUT-02 / OUT-03 / OUT-06

Sculpture garden: walk around; notice from two sides (OUT-02). Nature line and texture: rubbings with adult; poison-ivy check; leave living things unharmed (OUT-03). Architecture edge walk at 8–10: windows, doors, repeated shapes; quick sketch optional; traffic safety (OUT-06).

How a looking Hour can include a tiny make

After LOOK-02, invite a two-minute edge follow on scrap paper: “Pick one edge you noticed. Follow it slowly.” That make is a record of looking, not a polish project. If the make eats the look, shorten it.

²⁵NCES homeschool outing rows (library; museum/gallery/historical site) motivate; do not replace the looking move. REAP mute on art-makes-you-smarter from Chapter 1. Safety and AI full spines in The Art Hour. Banks mapped: LOOK-01...08; TALK portable; OUT-01, 02, 03, 04, 06, 07. Access date 24 September 2026. Limit line: useful frameworks, not a promise every home will see the same result.

Materials still-life for looking week (illustration)

Postcards or free museum cards; one picture book; sticky notes; mug; flashlight; fabric and sandpaper scraps; cardboard viewfinder; clipboard for OUT. No solvents. No craft knives. Library books count.

Talk box (this chapter)

Opening (locked): “What do you see — and what do you see that makes you say that?”

Follow-ups (3–5):

1. **Look:** “What do you see near the edge / in the dark part / in the shiny spot?”
2. **Make (if a tiny sketch happened):** “What did your hand try to follow?”
3. **Evidence:** “What do you see that makes you say that?”
4. **Process / check:** “What more can you find?” / “Whose eyes found that first — yours or the label’s?”
5. **Revise:** “You may change your mind. Look again. What else?”

How to wait. After you ask, a slow three is classroom-origin pause craft (Rowe’s wait-time work; Stahl’s think-time) used here as Art Hour pause — not an art RCT, not a kitchen coefficient.²⁶ After they stop, wait again. If mid-look, do not cut off. Look at the work, not at the child, if silence is hard.

Stuck silence usually means. Vague question; zero wait; hunting vocabulary because caption was up; fear of wrong story; scavenger habit; explain-before-look hangover; shrug at “what is it?” (bad question — use see / tell-me). Pose, wait, point at the work. Do not fill with “pretty.” Do not fight.

Blocked for a new move. Caption first; scavenger mania; guess-the-artist as the Hour; adult story dump before silence; pretty-only talk.

Mixed — when to use. LOOK sits most days this week; keep one short make so the week stays Art Hour. OUT once. Carry caption cover into every later chapter when reproductions appear.

Ear-training table

²⁶Rowe (1972) / Stahl (1994) classroom wait/think-time as pause craft for Art Hour, not an art RCT.

You hear / see	Likely meaning	Next move
Child reads label first	Caption-first habit	Cover; silence; LOOK-02
“Is this Picasso?”	Guess-the-artist	Notices first; name later
Clipboard with many checks	Scavenger mania	OUT-01 one work
“It’s pretty.” (only)	Empty preference	Evidence question
Adult monologue about a movement	Explain-before-look	Stop; ask what they see
Shrug	Vague or quizzy question	Point at work; locked opening

One incorrect example to diagnose (illustration, not a reported family). Family enters a gallery with a printed scavenger list: find three animals, two blues, one famous name. Child runs, checks boxes, never stands still. Parent reads every label aloud first. Diagnosis: coverage + caption-first. Rescue: put the list away; OUT-01; child chooses one work (OUT-07); locked opening; label last.

Second incorrect example (illustration). Parent shows a bio sheet with the artist’s name first, then asks the child to “find swirls like the famous painter” on a poster. Child hunts swirls to please, never describes anything else. Rescue: hide the sheet; LOOK-02 on the poster alone; locked opening; only after notices may you say the name once, lightly — or wait until tomorrow.

Portable TALK moves inside looking week

Chapter 7 owns talk in depth. This week borrow lightly so looking does not stay mute.

- **TALK-02 Point With Words:** After a notice, ask them to point with words — “the jagged edge near the top left,” not only “that thing.”
- **TALK-03 Yellow Dots Notice:** On fridge tour, “Look at all the ____ you made.” Description as care.
- **TALK-01 Tell Me About It:** On their own page after a tiny edge sketch, replace “What is it?” with “Tell me about your artwork.”
- **TALK-06 Feelings First (soft):** “How do you feel about this picture?” before adult gush — then return to evidence so feelings do not erase looking.

Keep talk boxes short. One authentic question + wait beats five quiz questions.

OUT logistics without killing the look

Before you go. Agree on one-work or one-spread rule aloud. Pack sticky notes and a pencil. Practice the locked opening once in the car on a photo with caption covered.

On site. Phones away during silence unless the child photographs *their chosen work* for a later home talk — then phone away again. Stand or sit where you can see without blocking others. Follow venue no-touch rules. Adult present.

After. Sticky crumb in the sketchbook: see / because / wonder. Optional process sentence: “First we looked, then we ____.” Gift shop is optional and not the assessment. If the child is done early, leave while curiosity remains — that is dose honesty, not failure.

Homeschool outing rows in national survey tables show library and museum/gallery/historical-site visits in past-month windows for many families. Those numbers motivate getting out. They do not invent a required minutes count for your week. Your OUT is one focused sit.

Band cues while you listen

5–7 listening for success. Lists of notices; pointing at the work; color and dark/light words; willingness to touch safe textures; choosing a fridge page and saying how they made a mark; surviving a short silence without panic.

8–10 listening for success. “Because I see...”; “what more”; revising a first idea; comparing the mug in window light vs flashlight; sitting with one museum work without begging for the next room first; optional written crumb.

Both bands — teach, do not shame. Caption hunt; artist-name guess as the only game; running room to room; adult filling every silence with facts; pretty-only loop.

Connecting looking to later chapters (plant, do not steal)

Color will ask what happened when colors met — after eyes see the puddle. Collage will ask what paper did — after eyes see the tear edge. Print will ask what

the press did — after eyes see the pull. Clay will ask what clay did — after hands and eyes meet. Mark and line (Chapter 3) will ask whose mark and what the hand tried — after looking has somewhere to land. Talk/write will deepen captions. Assessment will catch name-first and coloring-book-only weeks. This chapter's job is to make eyes trustworthy.

A fuller Friday looking diagnostic

1. Cover a new postcard caption.
2. Silent look.
3. Locked opening. Wait. Evidence follow-up. Wait.
4. Paraphrase one notice; ask “what more?”
5. Uncover label last — or save uncover for tomorrow if looking was rich.
6. AS-01 sticky: see / because / wonder.
7. Peek at the week: did any Hour skip silence? Schedule LOOK-02 again next week if so.
8. Done-enough checklist — then stop. Do not add a scavenger worksheet to “make it count.”

Safety and mess during looking week

Looking sits are usually low mess. Texture trays and outdoor rubbings add wash-hands and poison-ivy checks. Museum and street walks need adult presence and traffic sense. Materials still follow AP / ASTM D-4236 when crayons or rubbings enter. No solvents. Food off the looking table so the mug is an art object, not a snack prop, during the sit.

What “coverage itch” sounds like in a parent brain (and how to answer it)

“We only did one painting at the museum — is that enough?” Yes, if they looked. “We didn’t name complementary color.” Not this chapter’s job. “We should have hit every element of art.” Elements timing in state lists (for example TEKS) is a state map when labelled as such — not a kitchen dump. Depth is the hour. Return to Chapter 1’s flips if coverage anxiety rises.

Worked kitchen sequence — one Hour from silence to crumb (illustration)

Minute 0–1. Table clear. Postcard down. Caption covered. You say: “We’ll look without talking first.”

Minute 1–2. Silence. You look at the postcard, not at the child.

Minute 2–6. Locked opening. Wait. Child: “A person.” You: “What do you see that makes you say that?” Child points to a head-shaped oval and a blue sleeve. You paraphrase. “What more can you find?” Child notices a tiny window.

Minute 6–10. Tiny make: “Follow the oval edge only.” Demo on demo paper once if needed, then cover. Child’s scrap page.

Minute 10–14. Talk box again briefly: “Tell me about the edge you followed.” Wait.

Minute 14–16. Name lightly optional: “Some people call that shape a figure — we noticed it before the word.” Or skip.

Minute 16–18. Exit sticky: see / because / wonder. Stop while they want one more look at the postcard.

That Hour taught looking. It did not teach a movement lecture. It left a mark that belonged to the child.

When reproductions are imperfect — and still useful

Blurry phone photos, folded postcards, and library books with glare still work if eyes lead. Perfect digital zooms can wait. If a tool offers a generated “cleaner” version of the art, decline for the sit — look at the physical page you have. Generators skip looking when they become the object; a real postcard does not.

Sibling and multi-age soft notes

If a younger and older child share the sit, ask the locked opening once. Let both notice. Paraphrase both. Do not turn it into a contest for the “best” interpretation. The 8–10 child may add evidence language; the 5–7 child may lead with raw notices. Same postcard. Same respect. Place later try-its by skill when they work alone.

Grocery and town looking without stealing the color chapter

OUT-05 Grocery Color Cart — find three greens that differ — can appear as a short weekend stretch after looking week if you keep the talk on *noticing differences* before naming “hue.” Do not require a paint lesson in the produce aisle. Courtesy to staff; adult present; no purchase required. Looking practice travels.

Public art on a walk (OUT-02 soft) counts when you stop for notices from two sides. Architecture edges (OUT-06) at 8–10 count when windows and repeated shapes get a slow look. Always: eyes first, name lightly after, one sit deep enough to remember tomorrow.

Done-enough conversation script (parent to self)

“Did we cover the caption at least once? Did I ask what they see and what makes them say that? Did I wait? Did we leave one outing or library sit deeper than a checklist? If yes, looking week did its job — even if we never said the word Contour.”

For the student

Looking is a superpower you already have. Art hour asks you to use it before anyone tells you the title.

The idea. You look. You say what you see. You say what makes you say that. You may change your mind when you look again.

Tiny worked example. A postcard sits on the table. The words are covered. You look quietly. You say: “I see a big dark shape on the left. I think it might be a doorway because I see a rectangle and a slice of light. I wonder what is on the other side.” Then you uncover the words. Maybe the title matches your idea. Maybe it does not. Either way, your looking counted.

Try 1 — Cover and notice. Cover the title on a picture-book page or postcard. Look without talking. Then tell three things you see. For each one, add “because I see ____.”

Try 2 — Object, texture, or window. Choose one: (a) look at a mug and name five notices; (b) feel two safe textures and say how eyes and hands agree or dis-

agree; (c) frame a piece of the window with your hands and tell what the frame cuts off.

Explain it back. Why do we cover the words first? What is the difference between “I like it” and “I see a jagged edge”? What should you do at a museum — race every room, or sit with one work?

Challenge. At a museum or library, choose **one** picture or one book spread. Sit with it. No race. Use the question: “What do you see — and what do you see that makes you say that?” Optional: sketch one edge you noticed.

You are allowed to wonder. You are allowed to be wrong about the story and still be a good looker — if you point at what you see. You are allowed to change your mind on the second look.

If it isn’t clicking

Diagnostic 1 — They only recite the title or the myth. Caption or adult story came first. Next move: cover labels for several sits; LOOK-02 only; paraphrase notices; uncover at the very end or next day. Write your own urge to explain on a sticky for tomorrow.

Diagnostic 2 — Museum meltdown or boredom race. Too many works; feet ahead of eyes. Next move: one-work rule; child chooses (OUT-07); short sketch of one edge; leave while they still want one more look. Gift shop is not the assessment.

Diagnostic 3 — Pretty-only talk. Preference loop with no evidence. Next move: TALK-02 / locked evidence question; require one “because I see” before any like/dislike. On fridge tour, ask how they made a mark, not whether it is pretty.

Extra pattern — looking quiz on a phone. Photo-to-key is banned in the Art Hour AI box. If a tool offers a filled answer key for a postcard quiz, close it. Eyes first.

Diagnostic 4 — They look for two seconds and demand the next picture. Coverage itch in the child. Next move: timer visible for a short silent look (even one minute); celebrate staying; one-work rule on outings; stop before boredom turns into fight.

Diagnostic 5 — Adult cannot stop narrating. Your own explain-before-look

habit. Next move: parent warm-up alone daily for three days; write facts on tomorrow's sticky; during the Hour only questions and paraphrases.

When to slow down. Silent look keeps getting skipped; every sit becomes a quiz; outings are worksheets only; VTS length arrives before silence habits.

When to go ahead. Notices before vocabulary; one OUT or reproduction sit with caption covered; evidence phrases showing up orally; child revises a first idea kindly.

When to get a human tutor. Vision concerns, language access needs, or anxiety that does not ease with shorter sits — ask a human who knows your child. Looking protocols are not therapy claims. A scavenger failure is not an identity verdict.

Rescue order: ask, wait, hint, short demo of *looking* (you model one notice on the shared image), return the turn to them. Do not grab the conclusion. Do not fill silence with “pretty.”

Tools, including AI

Keep this short. Full allows and bans live in The Art Hour — point back there.

Parent holds the account. Ages 5–10 are under 13. Parent in the room. Ages 5–7: no live open chat as the child's partner. Ages 8–10: still parent in the room.

Useful to you this chapter: still-life setup ideas from kitchen objects; discussion questions you will vet; a composition thumbnail to look at together **then put away** before anyone draws from life; SCRIPT after the try for *your* mouth; explain a named postcard *to you* after the child has looked.

Not allowed as the lesson: photograph a looking quiz for a filled-in key (photo-to-key); make-my-child's-project; turn in generated as student work; unsupervised generator during looking/making; generate “child drawing” as the mark; write artist statement as only draft; upload child's face. Looking is unaided first. SCRIPT after the try.

What “done enough” looks like

Before moving on from looking week, check:

- ☐ Child gives notices before adult vocabulary on an object or image.
- ☐ At least one sit with caption/label covered (LOOK-02 or OUT with label last).
- ☐ Locked opening used; evidence follow-up used once (“what makes you say that?”).
- ☐ You paraphrased without a praise contest or a quiz fight.
- ☐ One OUT: museum one-work, gallery child choice, or library picture-book look first (or scheduled).
- ☐ Fridge tour or window frame happened once as process/crop looking.
- ☐ Pretty-only talk got redirected once with point-with-words.
- ☐ Texture or two-lights sit happened, or is on next week’s plan if this week was short.
- ☐ Placement: if VTS length failed, you stayed on silence + notices without shame.
- ☐ No photo-to-key; no generated image filed as looking “answers.”

Done enough is not a docent certificate. Done enough is eyes first, evidence once, one deep sit in or out of home.

A publisher workbook level is not a legal grade. Transcript title stays **Art**. Revisit next Tuesday with a new postcard. Mix last week’s mug with this week’s window frame. Looking is a habit of attention, not a unit you graduate from forever.

Chapter 3



Figure 5: Fat crayon marks on a sheet beside three fat crayons — still-life, no people, no logos.

Mark-making and line

Why this matters

Marks are how a hand thinks on paper. Lines are paths and edges — fat, thin, shaky, bold, accidental, kept.

This chapter owns authorship. Chapter 1 locked make before polish. Chapter 2 trained eyes. Here the tool stays in the child's hand: first mark block, tool swap, cover-the-demo, accident keep, fat-to-thin ladder, follow-the-edge mug, blind contour soft at 8–10, line hunt walk, music line map, left/right-hand soft as a fun stretch — not a therapy claim.

Without this chapter, Art Hour becomes adult-finished dogs, uncovered demos the child copies stroke-for-stroke, “I can’t draw” met with talent shame, and coloring-book lines as the only hour. With it, a five-to-seven-year-old marks freely with fat tools and learns that drips can become something. An eight-to-ten-year-old slows along a mug’s rim after looking, tries blind contour soft, and can say whose mark is on the page.

Why struggle is allowed. A wobbly rim is information. A drip is a chance. A demo that stays covered forces the hand to search. Rescue too early — grabbing the pencil “just to show” — teaches that the adult’s hand is the real artist. Shame a wobbly line and they learn to freeze. Ask, wait, hint, short demo on *demo paper*, return the tool.

Why the child’s page is sacred this week. Matching a sample is not the goal. Likeness may grow later from looking. Process is the effect of making on the child. The fridge picture proves a sitting happened. It is not the grade. Presenting still exists: they choose whether a page goes up and can say one reason.

You do not need to be a studio artist. You do need to leave their mark on their page — and to keep your demo on demo paper.

Why coloring books are demoted, not demonized. Sheets can quiet a waiting room. They are not Art Hour when they are the only mark diet. Open mark teaches authorship. Sheets teach staying inside someone else’s edge. Both can exist in a house. Only one fulfills this chapter.

Why generators fail this lesson even when they look charming. A fluent “kids crayon” JPEG skips the child’s looking and marking. Filing it as Drawing lies

about whose mark. Parent tools may prepare *you*; they may not become the project. Chapter 1 and the Art Hour AI box already said this — this chapter enforces it at the page.

For the parent: understand it yourself

Many adults “help” by finishing. The ear looks better. The dog stands up. The fridge looks nicer. The child learns a quiet lesson: my hand is not enough. This week you practice a different fluency — hearing adult-filled marks, uncovered demos, “draw it nice” freezes, coloring-book-as-only-hour, and “I can’t draw” talent talk — and answering with a shorter task and a returned tool.

Everyday picture. Put two papers on the table. On yours, draw one slow rim of a mug while they watch once. Cover your paper with a folder. Hand them a blank. Say: “Your page. My demo stays covered.” Sit on your hands if you must. That discomfort is the lesson landing in the adult.

Precise picture. Contour, in ordinary language, means slow edge-following — eyes on the edge, hand reporting. Blind contour soft means eyes on the object while the pencil moves, with a peek version allowed for younger or nervous hands.²⁷ Salome’s studio emphasis on points of high visual information and contour travel as looking moves — keep as studio craft, not as a kitchen RCT. Edwards-style exercises can be borrowed as try-its; left-brain/right-brain creativity cartoons are refused (Corballis).²⁸ Schneck and Henderson grip data (n=320, ages 3.0–6.11; mature grips rising across that span) support fat tools and patience — useful context, not a promise every home matches the curve.²⁹ CDC-pattern short attention at the young end supports short mark blocks. Studio Habits “Stretch and Explore” grain fits accident keep — adapt lightly from high-school studio research; do not claim a K–2 trial.³⁰

²⁷Contour in ordinary language = slow edge-following; blind contour soft with peek version for younger or nervous hands. Salome contour / high-visual-information moves as studio craft, not a kitchen RCT.

²⁸Edwards-style exercises can be borrowed as try-its; Corballis — refuse left/right-brain creativity cartoon as fact.

²⁹Schneck and Henderson (1990) grip context (n=320; ages 3.0–6.11; ~48%→90% mature grips); fat tools and patience — useful context, not a matched-curve promise.

³⁰CDC attention pattern at the young end supports short mark blocks. Studio Habits Stretch & Explore grain for accident keep — high-school studio research origin; adapt lightly.

Shape play (SHAPE bank) may support mark and collage later; this chapter stays on MARK and LINE as primary. Color puddles wait for Chapter 4 unless a washable drip appears in accident keep.

Wrong answers you should be able to hear

1. **Adult finishes the dog.** “I’ll just fix the ear.” Usually means polish anxiety. Fix: hands off; MARK-05 cover-the-demo; AS-02 whose mark.
2. **Demo left uncovered.** Child copies your page as the assignment. Usually means demo became the sample. Fix: show once, cover, blank for them.
3. **“I can’t draw” met with talent shame.** “Some people are art people.” Usually means looking got ahead of the hand or polish arrived early. Fix: shorten to one rim or free mark; refuse talent lecture.
4. **Coloring-book as only hour.** Talk is only about staying in lines. Usually means open mark never scheduled. Fix: MARK-01; demote sheets to quiet toys (AS-05).
5. **Generated “kids crayon” JPEG as their mark.** Phone picture filed as Drawing. Usually means authorship blur. Fix: AS-02 honesty; delete from child-work folder; start MARK-01.

Five-minute parent warm-up. Alone with a mug and two papers. Draw one edge on demo paper. Cover it. On a second paper, try a blind-contour soft of the handle for one minute. Notice wobble without erasing. Practice saying: “Whose mark is on this page — and what did your hand try?” Tomorrow you will ask them — and mean it.

How to teach it this week

Parent fluency goal for Friday. You can demo once and cover it. You can sit on your hands through a wobbly rim. You can answer “I can’t draw” with a shorter task. You can tell whose mark is whose.

Student fluency goal for Friday. Their page is theirs. They followed one edge after looking. They can say what their hand tried. They kept or transformed one accident without shame.

Session shape. Art Hour five beats (~20–40 min). Beat 1: short look at the mug or line environment (3–5 min) — eyes still first. Beat 2: make grows (10–18 min) — child’s tool. Beat 3: locked opening talk box. Beat 4: name lightly (contour =

slow edge-following; weight = fat/thin) after making — or tomorrow. Beat 5: exit crumb + whose-mark check soft.

Exact wording you can say.

- Opening (locked): “Whose mark is on this page — and what did your hand try?”
- Before demo: “Watch once. Then this paper gets covered.”
- After cover: “Your blank. Struggle is allowed.”
- Freeze: “One rim only. Slow. Eyes on the mug.”
- Accident: “What could this drip become — before we wipe?”
- Tool swap: “What did the crayon do that the marker didn’t?”
- “I can’t draw”: “Looking got ahead of your hand. Let’s try just the handle.”
- Exit: “Whose mark? One thing your hand tried. One wonder.”

First try-it. MARK-01 Child’s First Mark Block (or revisit if Chapter 1 already did it), then MARK-05 Cover-the-Demo Struggle with one edge move. Midweek: LINE-04 Follow the Edge Mug after looking. OUT: LINE-01 Line Hunt Walk or OUT-03 Nature Line & Texture.

How to fade help. Day 1: demo once, cover, hint with words only. Day 2: no demo unless asked after struggle. Day 3: they teach you what their hand tried. Never finish their marks.

When to stop talking. During the mark block — stop narrating. After “what did your hand try?” — wait. If they are mid-line, do not cut off. Do not fill wobble-silence with “pretty” or “want me to fix it?”

Age-band moves

5–7. Fat crayons, tempera sticks, large taped paper. MARK-01 free block. MARK-02 tool swap. MARK-06 accident keep. LINE-03 fat-to-thin. LINE-05 music line map. LINE-04 mug edge with peek allowed. Blind contour only as playful intro if curiosity is high — peek version. Oral exit; you may scribe. Process over likeness.

8–10. Longer edge follows. LINE-02 Blind Contour Soft (peek version still kind). MARK-05 with stricter cover. MARK-03 left/right soft as fun stretch. LINE-01 hunt walk with quick sketches. If “I can’t draw” dominates, shorten tasks and stay on fat tools longer — skill placement, not birthday. Refuse MFA critique.

This-week plan

Day	Focus	Try-it
Mon	Free mark authorship	MARK-01 Child's First Mark Block
Tue	Cover-the-demo edge	MARK-05 + look at mug first
Wed	Follow the edge	LINE-04 Follow the Edge Mug
Thu	Tool or weight play	MARK-02 Tool Swap <i>or</i> LINE-03 Fat-to-Thin
Fri	Accident keep + whose mark	MARK-06 + AS-02 Whose Mark Check
Weekend OUT	Lines in the world	LINE-01 Line Hunt Walk <i>or</i> OUT-03 Nature Line & Texture

Refuse: adult-finished fridge showpiece as the week's only success; uncovered demo left as the assignment; coloring sheets as the only mark diet.

Practice that actually builds learning

Named try-its with time, materials, mess/safety, the fun, the skill — **in the home and outside it.**

In-home — MARK-01 Child's First Mark Block

- **Time:** 15–25 min
- **Band:** 5–7 (both as warm-up)
- **Materials:** Large paper taped down; fat crayon or tempera stick (ACMI AP and/or Conforms to ASTM D-4236)
- **Mess / safety:** Low–med; cover table; food/drinks off art area; wash hands
- **The fun:** No “draw a ____” for 5–8 minutes.
- **The skill:** Authorship; tool in child's hand; make before polish.

Steps. Tape paper. Hand tool over. Free mark. Hands off. Stop while they want one more mark.

In-home — MARK-05 Cover-the-Demo Struggle

- **Time:** 20–30 min
- **Band:** both
- **Materials:** Demo paper adult keeps; child blank; mug optional for edge demo
- **Mess / safety:** Low–med
- **The fun:** Magic trick — demo disappears under a folder.
- **The skill:** Struggle before rescue; child’s page theirs.

Steps. Show one mark move once (slow rim, or press-and-twist). Cover demo. Child works from memory and looking. Rescue order only after struggle: ask, wait, hint, re-demo on demo paper, return tool.

In-home — MARK-02 Tool Swap Marks

- **Time:** 20–30 min
- **Band:** both
- **Materials:** Same paper; three tools (crayon, marker, soft pastel or chalk)
- **Mess / safety:** Med; chalk dust — wipe
- **The fun:** Same idea, three voices.
- **The skill:** Child names what each tool does.

In-home — MARK-06 Accident Keep

- **Time:** 15–25 min
- **Band:** both
- **Materials:** Paper; washable paint or marker
- **Mess / safety:** Med; washable only; cover table; smock; no solvents
- **The fun:** Drip becomes a feature.
- **The skill:** Stretch & explore; refuse wipe-first panic.

Steps. When drip/smudge happens: “What could this become?” before wiping. Keep if they choose.

In-home — MARK-03 Left-Hand / Right-Hand Soft

- **Time:** 15–25 min
- **Band:** both

- **Materials:** Paper; one crayon
- **Mess / safety:** Low
- **The fun:** Silly control vs freedom.
- **The skill:** Notice difference — fun stretch, **not** a therapy claim.

In-home — MARK-04 Mark Over Music Soft

- **Time:** 15–25 min
- **Band:** both
- **Materials:** Paper; crayon; short instrumental track; kind volume
- **Mess / safety:** Low
- **The fun:** Hand dances with slow/fast sections.
- **The skill:** Marks change with sound; talk after — what changed in your hand?

In-home — LINE-04 Follow the Edge Mug

- **Time:** 20–30 min
- **Band:** both
- **Materials:** Mug or bottle; pencil; paper
- **Mess / safety:** Low
- **The fun:** Slow spy mission along the rim.
- **The skill:** Look then follow; struggle before adult takes pencil.

Steps. LOOK first (Chapter 2 opening soft). Then slow edge follow. Peek allowed at 5–7. One rim is enough.

In-home — LINE-03 Fat-to-Thin Line Ladder

- **Time:** 15–25 min
- **Band:** both
- **Materials:** Markers/brushes of different widths; paper
- **Mess / safety:** Low–med
- **The fun:** Same path, three weights.
- **The skill:** Notice line weight before naming “weight” lightly.

In-home — LINE-02 Blind Contour Soft (8–10; intro 5–7)

- **Time:** 15–25 min
- **Band:** 8–10 (peek intro 5–7)
- **Materials:** Object; pencil; paper; optional second sheet for peek version
- **Mess / safety:** Low
- **The fun:** Funny honest wobble lines.
- **The skill:** Eyes on object; process over pretty.

Steps. Eyes on object; pencil moves. Peek version allowed. Laugh kindly at wobble — never talent-shame. Keep the page.

In-home — LINE-05 Music Line Map

- **Time:** 15–25 min
- **Band:** both
- **Materials:** Paper; marker; short music
- **Mess / safety:** Low
- **The fun:** Line that walks the music.
- **The skill:** Path as listening; talk after.

In-home — SHAPE soft support (optional)

SHAPE-01 Shape Sort Tray or SHAPE-03 Object to Shape Soft may warm hands — geometry names after seeing. Do not let shape worksheets replace open mark.

Out-of-home — LINE-01 Line Hunt Walk

- **Time:** 15–25 min
- **Band:** both
- **Materials:** Clipboard or phone; outdoors with adult
- **Mess / safety:** Low outdoors; traffic sense
- **The fun:** Straight, curved, zigzag safari.
- **The skill:** Find lines in environment; sketch or photo; name after hunt.

Out-of-home — OUT-03 Nature Line & Texture

- **Time:** 20–40 min

- **Band:** both
- **Materials:** Park/yard; rubbing paper; crayon
- **Mess / safety:** Adult; poison ivy check; leave living things unharmed
- **The fun:** Rubbing reveals hidden lines.
- **The skill:** Nature lines/textures into marks; looking still first.

Out-of-home stretch — OUT-06 Architecture Edge Walk (8–10)

- **Time:** 20–40 min
- **Materials:** Street/building with adult
- **Mess / safety:** Traffic
- **The fun:** Building as edge jungle.
- **The skill:** Windows, doors, repeated shapes; quick sketch optional.

Talk box (this chapter)

Opening (locked): “Whose mark is on this page — and what did your hand try?”

Follow-ups (3–5):

1. **Look:** “What edge did you notice before the pencil moved?”
2. **Make:** “What did your hand try — press, slow line, scribble, drip-keep?”
3. **Evidence:** “What do you see on the page that shows that try?”
4. **Process / check:** “Whose mark is this — yours, mine on demo paper, or a machine’s?”
5. **Revise:** “Keep the drip — what could it become? Try another slow rim if you want.”

How to wait. Slow three after the question (classroom-origin pause craft — Rowe/Stahl labelled; not art RCT).³¹ After they stop, wait again. Mid-mark: do not cut off. Look at the page, not at the child, if silence is hard.

Stuck silence usually means. Fear of “draw it nice”; waiting for you to finish the dog; uncovered demo dependency; coloring-book-only diet; hunting a perfect likeness; “I can’t draw” identity; pointing at phone JPEG as theirs. Pose, wait, point at *their* page. Shorten the task. Do not fill with “pretty.” Do not grab the tool.

³¹Rowe/Stahl wait as pause craft. Safety: AP/ASTM D-4236; no solvents; no craft knives; mess honesty. AI bans point to The Art Hour; Bastani OFF-AGE caution there.

Blocked. Adult-filled marks; uncovered demo as assignment; talent shame; coloring-book-as-only-hour; generated image as mark.

Mixed. Free mark early week; edge follow after looking midweek; OUT for lines in the world; accident keep when mess appears. Carry cover-the-demo into color, collage, clay chapters.

Ear-training table

You hear / see	Likely meaning	Next move
Adult pencil on child's page	Adult-filled marks	AS-02; demo paper only
Child copies uncovered demo	Demo became sample	Cover; blank
"I can't draw"	Looking ahead of hand / polish fear	Shorten to one rim; MARK-01
Only sheet talk	Coloring-book-only	Open MARK; AS-05
Phone JPEG as "mine"	Generated-as-mark	Honesty; delete; MARK-01
Wipe-first panic	Accident refused	MARK-06 ask before wipe

Incorrect example (illustration). Parent draws a complete dog on the child's paper "so it looks nice for Grandma," leaves the demo uncovered beside a blank that the child never marks, then photographs a generator's "crayon dog" for the folder. Diagnosis: adult-filled + uncovered demo + generated-as-mark. Rescue: new blank; MARK-01; MARK-05 with cover; AS-02; delete JPEG from child-work; Grandma gets a process photo of the child's real page — wobble included.

Second incorrect example (illustration). Child says "I can't draw." Parent answers "You're just not an art kid — here's a coloring book." Rescue: refuse identity verdict; fat crayon; one mug rim after looking; locked opening; celebrate what the hand tried.

Worked kitchen sequence — cover-the-demo Hour (illustration)

Look (3–5 min). Mug down. "What do you notice — before we draw any part?" (Chapter 1 opening soft as warm-up.) Five notices.

Demo (1 min). On demo paper only: one slow rim. Narrate lightly: “My eyes stay on the edge.”

Cover. Folder over demo. Blank to child.

Make (10–15 min). “Follow the rim. Peek ok.” Adult sits on hands. If freeze: “Just the place where the handle starts.”

Talk box (5 min). Locked opening. Wait. Follow-ups. Whose mark check.

Name lightly (optional, 2 min). “That slow edge-following is sometimes called contour — we did it before the word.”

Exit. Sticky: whose mark / what hand tried / wonder. Stop while they want one more rim tomorrow.

Materials still-life for mark week (illustration)

Large paper; tape; fat crayons; pencil; markers of two widths; washable marker or tempera for drips; folder for covering demo; mug; clipboard for OUT; rubbing paper for nature lines. AP / ASTM D-4236. Table cover. Smock for wet. No solvents. No craft knives. Labelled children’s scissors wait for collage chapter unless already practiced safely.

Safety spine reminder

Adult present for wet and outdoor. Mess honesty before paint drips. Food/drinks off art table. Wash hands. Read current labels. Poison Control 1-800-222-1222 if needed. “Non-toxic” $\neq$ edible. No CL products through grade 6.

Connecting to other chapters

Looking (ch02) feeds every edge follow — if rims are symbol-only, return to LOOK-01. Color (ch04) will refuse adult rainbow fixes the way this chapter refuses adult-finished dogs. Collage/print (ch05) keep child’s arrange and press. Clay (ch06) redesigns when it falls — same struggle-before-rescue. Talk/write (ch07) asks how you did that. Assessment (ch08) formalizes whose-mark and coloring-book-only flags you already planted.

Dose honesty

Three mark Hours with real authorship beat five polished craft copies. If attention is short, free mark for five minutes and stop while curiosity remains. Blind contour can wait a week. Fat tools are not “baby” — they are smart for developing hands.

Sibling soft note

Two children may share a mug look and then mark on separate papers. Demo once for both, still cover. Do not finish the younger one’s page so it “matches” the older. Place next try-its by skill when they work alone.

Friday authorship diagnostic (run aloud)

1. Lay out this week’s pages.
2. Point to each: “Whose mark?” Child answers.
3. If any page has adult finishing, say warmly: “That part is my mark on your paper — next time my marks stay on demo paper.” Do not shame; change the rule going forward.
4. Ask locked opening on their strongest try.
5. AS-01 crumb: notice (from looking), make move, wonder.
6. AS-02 honesty: any phone image? If yes, remove from child-work folder.
7. Done-enough checklist. Stop. Do not “fix” a page for the fridge after the diagnostic.

What polish pressure sounds like — and replies that teach

Polish pressure	Teaching reply
“Make it nice for the fridge.”	“Folder or wall is your choice after we talk about what your hand tried.”
“Let me just fix that.”	“Demo paper is over here if you want a tip after you try.”
“Copy mine so it matches.”	“Mine stays covered. Yours can wobble.”
“You’re not an art kid.”	“Looking and trying are enough. Let’s shorten the task.”

Polish pressure	Teaching reply
“The machine can draw it better.”	“Machines don’t get your mark. You do.”

Line language — light names after making

Say these only after eyes and hands have worked — or save for tomorrow:

- **Contour** — slow edge-following.
- **Blind contour soft** — eyes on the object while the hand moves (peek ok).
- **Weight** — fat vs thin lines.
- **Path** — where the line walks across the page.

Refuse a vocabulary quiz before free mark. Refuse left/right-brain creativity lectures as science fact.

Blind contour kindness script (8–10)

“We’re going to make a funny honest line. Eyes on the shoe. Pencil moves. It will look weird. Weird is the point today. We keep the page. We do not erase into shame. Ready — one minute.”

After: locked opening. Celebrate the try, not likeness. Optional second minute with peek. Optional third with eyes allowed — compare what changed. Process over pretty.

Music and non-dominant hand — why they belong

MARK-04 and LINE-05 loosen polish panic by giving the hand a different boss (sound). MARK-03 loosens control myths with a silly swap. Label them fun stretches. Do not claim therapeutic outcomes. If a child dislikes the swap, skip — authorship still stands on MARK-01 and LINE-04.

OUT weather alternatives

Rain cancels line hunt? Hunt lines indoors: door frames, stair rails, blanket weaves, window mullions. Still sketch one. Nature rubbings move to dry day. Architecture walk waits for safe weather and daylight. Library picture-book look

first (OUT-04) can host line noticing in illustrations if outdoor OUT slips — still eyes first, then optional line copy of one illustrated edge on scrap, child's mark.

Multi-day thread — one mug all week (illustration)

Monday: free marks beside the mug (not of it yet). Tuesday: cover-the-demo rim. Wednesday: full LINE-04 slow follow. Thursday: fat-to-thin versions of the same handle curve. Friday: accident keep on a washable rim try + whose mark. Weekend: line hunt comparing outdoor curves to the mug's handle. Same object. Deepening authorship. Coverage itch loses.

Parent rehearsal — sit on your hands (five more minutes)

After the warm-up in “For the parent,” add this: set a timer for three minutes while a child (or imaginary child) “marks.” Every time you feel the urge to reach, make a tally mark on a sticky instead. At the end, count the tallies. That number is your polish itch. Tomorrow, aim for fewer tallies. This is adult practice, not a joke at the child's expense.

What “done enough” is not

Done enough is not: identical to the sample; adult-corrected for Grandma; erased until lifeless; generated and printed; a coloring sheet with every cell filled; a talent verdict; a percentile; a brand-named workbook level used as a transcript line.

Done enough is: looked, marked with own hand, talked about the try, left a crumb, demo stayed separate.

Cross-check with Chapter 1 and 2 before you advance

If name-first symbols still dominate every “mug,” return to LOOK-01 before more LINE-04. If caption-first still owns every postcard, return to LOOK-02. Mark and line sit on looking. Do not polish a symbol bank into a “better” dog with your own pencil — that teaches the wrong authorship story.

If looking is strong but hands freeze, this chapter is the right medicine: shorten, fatten the tool, cover the demo, keep the drip.

Optional shape bridge (do not steal collage chapter)

After a mark block, SHAPE-03 Object to Shape Soft can ask: “What simple shape is hiding in the mug from this angle?” Names after seeing. Keep it under ten minutes. Tear collage and stamp print wait for Chapter 5 so authorship of mark stays the headline now.

A note on erasers

Erasers are tools, not judges. If erasing becomes shame-loops — erase, frown, erase, freeze — put the eraser aside for one Hour. Keep the honest line. You can try a second page instead of wounding the first. At 8–10, light erasing for construction is fine after a full try; it is not a license to adult-perfect the page.

Encouragement that is specific (models you can steal)

- “I see a slow line along the top edge — your hand stayed with it.”
- “You pressed harder near the handle; the page shows it.”
- “You kept the drip and turned it into a shadow shape.”
- “Your marks are yours — I can tell because I watched your hand.”

Avoid empty “pretty” and empty “good job” as the only sentences. Specific noticing teaches them what to try again.

When an older sibling or visiting adult breaks the rule

Warm, public reset: “In Art Hour, demos stay on demo paper — even for helpers.” Hand the visitor a demo sheet. Protect the child’s page without humiliating the helper. Consistency teaches authorship faster than any speech.

Closing the week without a craft dump

Friday is diagnostic and crumb — not the day to add foam stamps, glitter, and three printmaking extras “so we covered media.” Media richness arrives in later chapters. Authorship is the medium this week. If energy remains, repeat LINE-04 on a bottle instead of the mug. Same move, new edge. Depth beats novelty.

Life-of-the-habit seeds (not a ninth chapter)

Next Tuesday: pull Monday's free-mark page beside a new rim try; ask what the hand learned. Mix last week's accident-keep drip into a new story. Stop while they want one more mark. Records later will hold the dated page under **Art**. The habit is returning to the table — not graduating from looking and marking into a diploma.

You now have the spine (Chapter 1), the eyes (Chapter 2), and the hand's honesty (Chapter 3). Color, collage, clay, talk, and short checks will ride on these. When a later week goes loud with materials and thin on authorship, return here and ask the locked opening again.

Carry forward. Next week's color puddles will tempt adult rainbow fixes — meet them with the same hands-off rule you practiced on rims. The locked opening travels: whose mark, what the hand tried, what the material did. You built that muscle here.

One more incorrect pattern — praise that steals authorship

“You're such a little artist — let me hang the good one and recycle the practice.” That sentence crowns polish and trashes process. Reply with action: date both pages; keep the try; let the child choose the wall page and say one reason. Authorship includes the wobble. Looking and making for ordinary challenges needs the try in the folder, not only the fridge showpiece.

For the student

Your marks matter. Nobody else gets to pretend their hand was yours.

The idea. You look. You hold the tool. You try. Wobbly is allowed. Accidents can stay. A picture a machine made is not your mark.

Tiny worked example. A mug sits on the table. You look at the rim. A grown-up draws one slow rim on their own paper, then covers it. You get a blank. You follow the rim. It wobbles. You keep going. Later someone asks: “Whose mark is on this page — and what did your hand try?” You say: “Mine. I tried a slow rim. I pressed harder on the handle side.” That is art hour working.

Try 1 — First mark block. Big paper. Fat crayon. Mark freely for several minutes. No perfect picture required. Stop while you still want one more mark.

Try 2 — Cover-the-demo rim. Watch one slow edge once. Demo gets covered. On your blank, follow one edge of a mug after looking. Peek if you need to. Keep the wobble.

Explain it back. What does “my mark” mean? Where should a grown-up’s demo live? What should you do with a drip before anyone wipes it? Why isn’t a phone picture of a “kids drawing” your art?

Challenge. On a walk, hunt straight, curved, and zigzag lines (LINE-01). Sketch one. Or rub a leaf or bark (OUT-03) and talk about the lines you got. At home, try blind contour soft of a shoe for one minute — funny lines welcome.

You are allowed to struggle. You are allowed to ask for a hint after you try. You are allowed to say “please don’t draw on my page.” You are allowed to keep a page that is not pretty.

If it isn’t clicking

Diagnostic 1 — Adult hands keep “helping.” Polish anxiety. Next move: physical rule — adult pencil never lands on child paper; demo paper only; AS-02 every Friday until habit sticks.

Diagnostic 2 — Freeze at likeness / “I can’t draw.” Looking ahead of hand or talent story. Next move: shorten to free mark or one rim; fat tool; refuse talent lecture; peek blind contour; celebrate what the hand tried.

Diagnostic 3 — Only coloring books all week. No open mark diet. Next move: schedule MARK-01 and LINE-04 as Art Hour; sheets become optional quiet toys (AS-05). Not banned as toys — banned as the only hour.

Diagnostic 4 — Demo addiction. Panic when demo is covered. Next move: shorter demo; longer cover; hint with words (“watch the place where the handle meets the cup”) before any re-demo.

Diagnostic 5 — Generated image in the folder. Authorship blur. Next move: honesty talk; delete from child-work; MARK-01 today; process notes may name a tool used for *parent* prep, never as their drawing.

When to slow down. Adult-filled marks recur; every page aims at fridge polish; free mark never happens; scissors/knives enter early (they don't belong in this age book's spine).

When to go ahead. Child's page is theirs; one edge followed after looking; demo stays covered; they can answer the locked opening; accident kept or transformed once.

When to get a human tutor. Pain while gripping, sensory distress with tools, or fine-motor concerns beyond kitchen tips — ask a human who knows your child. Fun left/right swaps are not therapy. Grip research is context, not diagnosis.

Rescue order: ask, wait, hint, short demo on *demo paper*, return the tool. Correct the reason (adult-filled, generated-as-theirs) without crushing the look or the try.

Tools, including AI

Short pointer to The Art Hour AI box.

Parent account; parent in the room; 5–7 no child open chat partner; 8–10 still parent present.

Useful to you: sketchbook-challenge prompts the child will *draw*; still-life setups from kitchen objects; SCRIPT after the try for your mouth; diagnose a photo of the *paper* (crop to work, no child's face) after they tried — you hear the hint and decide.

Not allowed: make-my-child's-project; turn in generated as student work; unsupervised generator during making; generate “child drawing” / crayon-kids style as their mark; write artist statement as only draft; detector-grade a contour. Grids/traces/projectors still pass through eye and hand if you ever use them later; generators skip looking and marking. Unaided first on marking. SCRIPT after.

Tools stay short here on purpose — the Art Hour chapter already holds the full AI box. Point back. Teach marks with hands, not with generators.

What “done enough” looks like

Before moving on from mark and line week, check:

- ☐ Child's page is theirs — no adult-finished marks on their paper.
- ☐ Demo, if any, stayed on demo paper and was covered for the try.
- ☐ One open mark block happened (MARK-01 or equivalent).
- ☐ One edge followed after looking (LINE-04 or blind contour soft).
- ☐ Locked opening used; child named what the hand tried.
- ☐ Accident keep practiced once, or tool swap / fat-to-thin happened.
- ☐ OUT: line hunt walk or nature line/texture (or scheduled).
- ☐ "I can't draw" (if it appeared) met with shorter task, not talent shame.
- ☐ Coloring books not the only mark diet this week.
- ☐ No generated image filed as their drawing; AS-02 honesty clear.³²

Done enough is not a matched sample. Done enough is authorship + one looked edge + talk about the try.

Transcript title stays **Art**. Revisit next Tuesday if adult hands crept back. Mix last week's free mark with this week's rim. Stop while they want one more mark — that is the habit, not a diploma.

³²AS-02 / AS-05 links to Chapter 8. Bank names for writers: Child's First Mark Block; Tool Swap Marks; Left-Hand/Right-Hand Soft; Mark Over Music Soft; Cover-the-Demo Struggle; Accident Keep; Line Hunt Walk; Blind Contour Soft; Fat-to-Thin Line Ladder; Follow the Edge Mug; Music Line Map. Access date 24 September 2026. Limit line: useful study context, not a promise every home will see the same result.

Chapter 4 — Color and paint light



Figure 6: Tempera color puddles and a fat crayon on a wooden table — still-life, no people, no logos.

Why this matters

Color arrives at the kitchen table before anyone opens a wheel chart. A yellow puddle touches a blue puddle. Something new shows up on the paper. That meeting is the lesson.

If you teach the name first — primary, secondary, complementary — the child hunts for the right word instead of watching the paint. Look before name still holds here. Make before polish holds too. A muddy orange that the child mixed is worth more than a perfect rainbow the adult painted on the side for “how it should look.”

This chapter unlocks three ordinary skills. First, the child learns that colors change when they meet — on paper, on a tray, in water, even in the grocery aisle where three greens refuse to be the same. Second, the child learns to notice light and dark inside one hue before anyone says *value* or *tint*. Third, you learn to keep your hands off a mix you would “fix,” and to cover the table before the lid comes off.

Worth the struggle: a five-year-old who can point at what happened when red met yellow will later mix with purpose. An eight-year-old who can work from two tubes plus white will not freeze when a sample kit offers twelve. A parent who can say “what happened when the colors met?” instead of “now make green” is teaching looking, not decorating.

You do not need a studio. You need washable paint with an **AP** seal (or labelled **Conforms to ASTM D-4236**), a covered table, a fat brush, and the courage to leave a drip alone. Mess honesty before you start. Food and drinks off the art table. The Art Hour safety spine already said this once; this chapter lives it with paint.

Color week is not a miniature design course and not a promise that art raises reading scores. Justify the hour by what looking and mixing teach. Then put two puddles down.

A second reason this chapter matters: paint teaches honesty about materials. Washable tempera behaves differently from a crayon. Water changes a pan color. A covered table is part of the craft, not a punishment. When you preview the mess and keep food off the table, you are teaching the same care a studio teaches — scaled to a kitchen. When you refuse solvent cans from the garage, you are protecting the hour so looking can stay the point.

A third reason: color is one of the places adult polish shows up fastest. “Pretty” and “right green” arrive before the child has looked. If you can hold the line here — notice the meeting, name lightly, leave the drip — you will hold it more easily in collage, print, and clay. Look before name; make before polish. Color is the loud practice ground for both.

For the parent: understand it yourself

Everyday picture. Your child has two puddles on a tray — yellow and blue. They swirl. The mix turns a soft green-brown. Your hand wants to grab a clean brush, add more yellow, and rescue the rainbow. You say, “That’s muddy — let’s fix it so it looks like real green.” The child’s face closes a little. The page becomes yours. Tomorrow they wait for you to finish every mix.

Precise picture. Same puddles. Same soft green-brown. You wait. You ask, “What happened when the colors met — before we name the mix?” The child points: “It got darker.” or “It turned funny green.” You say, “Yes — you made that.” Later, lightly, you may say *green* or *olive* if the word helps. You do not wipe the mix away. Muddy is data. The child’s mark stays the child’s mark. Next week they swirl on purpose to see what happens.

Color play at this age is noticing change. Limited palette — two or three colors, maybe white — is a craft constraint that sharpens looking. It is not a punishment for wanting more tubes. Warm and cool can wait until the child has sorted piles by feel; then you name lightly. Light and dark in water come before the word *value*. A grocery aisle with three different greens is real color study without opening a bottle.

Many adults feel rusty because their own art hours were laminated wheels and “stay inside the lines.” That is normal. You are not behind. You are learning to hear a name-first rush and an adult-filled fix — and to ask a good question instead of grabbing the brush.

Wrong answers you should be able to hear

1. **“Make it the right green like the chart.”** Usually means name-first and sample-matched polish. Reply: “Show me what your green did. We can look at the chart tomorrow — after your mix.”
2. **“I’ll just fix this muddy part for you.”** Adult rainbow fix. Reply: hands

off. Talk muddy as information. Offer a clean corner of paper if they want a second try — their brush, not yours on their page.

3. **“We can’t paint until we learn all the color words.”** Coverage itch. Reply: two puddles first; words after seeing. Depth is the hour; the wheel is a map.
4. **“These oil paints from the garage are fine — it says art on the can.”** Wrong materials. Stop. Check for ACFI **AP** and/or **Conforms to ASTM D-4236**. No solvents for this age book. No **CL** products through grade 6. Kitchen $\neq$ adult oil studio.
5. **“Snack on the paint table while we mix.”** Food on the art table. Move food. Cover the table. Wash hands after. “Non-toxic” does not mean edible.

Five-minute parent warm-up. Alone, before tomorrow’s Hour: cover a scrap of newspaper. Put two washable puddles down. Mix once with a fat brush. Ask yourself out loud: “What happened when the colors met?” Practice waiting three slow counts before any vocabulary sentence. Notice one drip you would usually wipe. Leave it. Put the scrap away. You do not need to be a painter. You need to leave the child’s mix alone long enough for looking to happen.

One more precise picture — light and dark. Same blue pan. One fat wet stroke. One watery pale stroke. The child says “that one is sleepy” or “that one is loud.” You do not rush to say *tint* and *shade*. You say, “You noticed a light one and a dark one in the same blue.” Tomorrow you may offer the word *lighter* as a bridge. The word *value* can wait until it earns its keep at the table — and even then, one plain sentence is enough.

About charts. A color wheel is a map, not a gate. Some families enjoy looking at a wheel *after* several mix hours, the way a map is useful after a walk. Looking at the wheel before any puddle often turns the hour into vocabulary class. If a vendor page or workbook opens with the wheel, you may skip to the mix, then return to the chart as a “does this match what we saw?” check — child’s mix first.

How to teach it this week

Session shape (Art Hour, ~20–40 min).

1. **Look / notice (3–8 min).** Put tomorrow’s two colors out still closed, or put three crayon stubs of “yellow” that are not the same. Ask what they notice — before any wheel, before any mix.
2. **Short make (8–18 min).** Child holds the brush. Two puddles meet. Or

same hue with more and less water. Demo only on *demo paper*, then return the tool. Do not paint the “right” version on their sheet.

3. **Talk box (3–8 min).** Locked opening below. Wait. One or two follow-ups. Stop talking while they look.
4. **Name lightly (2–5 min, optional).** One word after seeing: green, darker, warmer, olive. Naming can wait until tomorrow. Do not turn the end of the hour into a quiz.
5. **Exit crumb (2–5 min).** Child chooses: keep the drip, wash for next time, point at one place the colors met, or dictate three words you write in the margin.

Exact sentences you can say

- “What do you notice about these two puddles — before we mix?”
- “Your turn with the brush. I’ll watch.”
- “What happened when the colors met — before we name the mix?”
- “Muddy tells us they mixed a lot. That’s information, not a mistake.”
- “We can name it after you’ve looked.”
- “I’m leaving your mix. Tell me what it did.”
- “Same blue family — what changed when you added water?”

First try-it for the student: COLOR-01 Two-Puddle Mix (band 5–7; fine for both).

- **Time:** 20–30 min inside the Hour.
- **Materials:** Tempera or liquid watercolor with **AP** seal; two primaries (yellow + blue, or yellow + red); fat brush; paper; table cover; smock; wet cloth.
- **Mess / safety:** Medium–high. Cover table first (**SAFE-02**). Smocks. Food off table. Wash hands. Washable only. Adult present for wet media.
- **The fun:** Watching a third color appear that neither bottle held alone.
- **The skill:** Mix on paper or tray; notice the new color; name after seeing. No perfect rainbow chart required on day one.

How to fade help. Day one: place the two puddles and wait. If the child freezes, hint: “What if the brush visits both puddles?” Short demo on demo paper — one swirl only. Return the brush. Do not finish their green. Day two: they choose which two colors meet. Day three: they decide whether to mix a little or a lot, then tell what changed.

When to stop talking. After the opening question. After one follow-up. While the brush is moving. When they are mid-look at the meeting place. Silence is part

of the mix. Do not fill it with “pretty” or with a lecture on primaries.

Age-band moves inside this week

- **5–7:** Liquid tempera or tempera sticks; fat brush; large paper; two puddles only on day one; oral notice; adult may scribe “yellow met blue.” Keep paint amounts small. Mess preview (**SAFE-05**) before lids open: “This hour will be wet. We have cover, smock, and wash time.” Prefer water-based washables. Tear-and-crayon color walks are allowed on a low-energy day.
- **8–10:** Add **COLOR-02** light/dark water; **COLOR-04** warm/cool sort after looking; **COLOR-05** limited palette still life (2–3 colors + white) from a real mug or pear. Still refuse adult rainbow fix. Still washable AP. Written three-word crumb optional. If looking habits are weak, stay on two-puddle and grocery greens longer even if the birthday says nine. Place by skill, not birthday.

This-week plan (honest “lesson plan”). One focus: notice mix before name. Three to five Art Hours. One out-of-home color look (**OUT-05** or a neighborhood yellow hunt). Friday: one diagnostic pattern (did an adult fix appear?) plus done-enough checklist. Not twelve tubes. Not a 180-day craft dump.

Sample dialogue (illustration).

Parent: “Two puddles. What do you notice before we mix?”

Child: “Yellow is brighter.”

Parent: “Your brush.” (*waits while child mixes*)

Parent: “What happened when the colors met — before we name the mix?”

Child: “It went kind of green-brown.”

Parent: “What do you see that makes you say that?”

Child: “The middle is darker than the yellow edge.”

Parent: “Yes. You made that meeting.” (*optional, later*) “Some people call a mix like that green. We can use that word if you want.”

Demo-paper rule, painted. If you must show a swirl, use a sheet labelled DEMO in the corner. One swirl. Put your brush down. Hand theirs back. If they ask “can you make it nice?”, answer: “I can show a tip on demo paper. Your page stays yours. What do you want to try?”

Stopping while wanting one more mark. End the make block while energy is still curious. Wash together. Leave a puddle scrap to look at tomorrow if it will not ruin the table. The urge to “just finish the rainbow” is polish talking. Exit crumb

instead.

Safety this week (paint). Before the first open lid: **SAFE-01** — find AP and/or ASTM D-4236 on the package. Refuse CL for this band. **SAFE-04** — no mineral spirits, turpentine, or solvent adhesives as kitchen art. Read the current label. Poison Control 1-800-222-1222 if needed. Adult present. Cover, smock, wash.

Practice that actually builds learning

Pick one COLOR try-it for most Hours this week. Keep **SAFE-01** / **SAFE-02** / **SAFE-05** as ritual, not optional garnish. Add one out-of-home look. You do not need all six COLOR cards in seven days. Coverage itch is the enemy of looking.

In-home try-its

COLOR-01 Two-Puddle Mix (above) — default first session. Repeat with a different pair (yellow + red; red + blue) before you add complexity.

COLOR-02 Light/Dark Water Soft — band both; 20–30 min.

Materials: pan watercolor or diluted tempera (AP); water jar; paper; towel; table cover.

Mess / safety: medium; spills happen — towel ready.

The fun: the same blue that turns sky-pale or deep with water alone — no second tube required.

The skill: notice lighter/darker before naming *value* or *tint*. Say: “Same color family — what changed?” Keep one watery bloom on purpose.

COLOR-03 Color Walk Collect — band both; 15–25 min.

Materials: clipboard, crayon match strips, or phone photos the child takes with you; outdoors or at a window.

Mess / safety: low outdoors with adult; traffic awareness.

The fun: three yellows that are not the same — sign, leaf edge, pencil stub.

The skill: color looking without paint. Talk differences. Name lightly after the hunt. No paint required.

COLOR-04 Warm/Cool Sort Soft — intro 5–7; own at 8–10; 15–25 min.

Materials: paint chips, magazine scraps, or crayon stubs (safe scraps only).

Mess / safety: low.

The fun: making two piles by “feel” of the color — sunny vs shady, fire vs water

— in the child’s words first.

The skill: sort first; adult names *warm* / *cool* lightly after the child’s sort — not before. If they sort by favorite instead, ask “what do you see that makes you put those together?” and try again without shaming.

COLOR-05 Limited Palette Still Soft — band 8–10; 25–40 min.

Materials: one kitchen object (mug, pear, shoe); only 2–3 colors + white if needed; AP paint; paper; cover.

Mess / safety: medium.

The fun: “We only get these tubes — what can they do?” Constraint becomes a game.

The skill: look at the object; mix from the few; stop while wanting one more mark. Put away any generated still-life thumbnail before the child paints from life. The object is the teacher.

COLOR-06 Refuse Adult Rainbow Fix — band both; 10–15 min meta, any day the reflex rises.

Materials: child’s painting in progress.

Mess / safety: —.

The fun: keeping a drip or muddy patch as part of the story.

The skill: if you want to “fix” muddy mix, stop. Talk muddy as data. Child’s mark first. Exact line: “I’m going to leave your mix. Tell me what it did.” If you already touched their page, own it: “That corner is my demo. Here’s a fresh sheet for your next mix.”

Out-of-home try-it

OUT-05 Grocery Color Cart — band both; 15–25 min.

Materials: store produce aisle; optional phone photos the child takes with you; no purchase required.

Mess / safety: adult present; courtesy to staff; don’t block the aisle.

The fun: three greens that differ — lime, spinach, cucumber skin — or three reds that refuse to match.

The skill: color walk looking without paint. Talk differences. Optional tomorrow: match one green to a crayon strip at home. No vocabulary quiz in the cart. Library picture-book color walks and window-sill plant greens count as cousins of this move.

Talk box

Opening (locked): “What happened when the colors met — before we name the mix?”

Follow-ups (pick three to five):

1. Look: “What do you see in the place they touched?”
2. Make: “What did your brush (or the water) do?”
3. Evidence: “What do you see that makes you say that?”
4. Process: “How did you get that darker part?” / “Whose mark made that swirl?”
5. Revise: “You may change your mind — want another look? Keep the drip — what could it become?”

How to wait. After you ask, count a slow three (classroom wait-time craft used as pause skill for Art Hour — not an art RCT). Look at the paper, not at the child, if the silence is hard. After they stop talking, wait again. If they are mid-swirl, do not cut them off.

Stuck silence usually means: the question was vague; you asked for the word *green* first; they fear “make it nice”; every art hour has been a coloring-book outline; they wait for you to finish the mix; wait-time was zero; they point at a phone image as “my art.” Pose again, point at the meeting place on the paper, and wait. Do not fill the silence with “pretty.” Do not turn the table into a fight.

Blocked / mixed / incorrect example

Blocked for a new move. Do not open twelve tubes the first color week. Do not require a laminated wheel before the first puddle. Do not use solvent paints “just this once.” Do not hang a generated “perfect mix” as the child’s work.

Mixed — when to use which move. Use two-puddle when the child only names colors from memory. Use light/dark water when mixes always go straight to mud and they need another variable (water). Use warm/cool sort when they are ready to group by feel after looking. Use limited palette when they stall in front of too many choices. Use grocery color cart when kitchen mess is too high that day but looking still needs practice. Use refuse-adult-fix any time your hand reaches for their brush.

Incorrect example to diagnose (illustration, not a reported family). Parent

prints a rainbow chart, paints a perfect secondary strip on demo paper, then hands the child the same two colors and says, “Make yours match mine.” Child freezes, then copies the adult strip. Diagnosis: name-first plus adult-filled standard. Repair: cover the demo strip. Ask the locked opening about *their* meeting place. Tomorrow, two puddles with no chart on the table. Keep the accidental drip.

Sample week B — Color mix light (menu, not mandate)

- **Monday:** SAFE-02 cover ritual + COLOR-01 two-puddle (yellow + blue). Talk box locked opening. Exit: point at meeting place.
- **Tuesday:** COLOR-02 light/dark water with one hue. Name lightly after. Scribe three words at 5–7 if useful.
- **Wednesday:** Short look at yesterday’s dry page — “what do you notice now?” Then COLOR-06 check: any adult fix urge? Keep a drip story.
- **Thursday:** OUT-05 grocery color cart (or COLOR-03 walk if no store trip). Optional photo of three greens.
- **Friday:** COLOR-04 warm/cool sort (8–10) *or* repeat COLOR-01 with a new pair (5–7). Done-enough checklist. Note one diagnostic for next week.

Dose honesty: three Hours plus one OUT is a full week. Five Hours is generous. Skipping Wednesday after a hard Tuesday is allowed. Rest is part of dose honesty.

What “fun” is doing here

The fun is not matching a sample. The fun is the surprise of the third color, the pale bloom from water, the three greens that refuse to match, the kept drip that becomes a planet tomorrow. If the only fun is “it looks like the chart,” polish has taken the hour. Steer back to what the materials did.

Another incorrect pattern. Parent photographs the child’s unfinished mix, uploads it to a generator, and prints a “finished” version for the fridge as Drawing. Diagnosis: generated image filed as the child’s mark. Repair: fridge shows the child’s actual page; generated print, if kept at all, is labelled generated and is not the child’s work. Point back to the Art Hour AI box.

Materials ritual worth repeating

Before paint week becomes chaos, run the safety cards as a two-minute play:

1. **SAFE-01 Seal Check Before Open** — child helps find the AP seal or the ASTM D-4236 line on a new bottle. If you only find a CL seal, that product waits for older students; it does not enter this Hour.
2. **SAFE-02 Table Cover Ritual** — newspaper or vinyl down; smock on; wet cloth ready; drinks and snacks moved.
3. **SAFE-05 Mess Honesty Preview** — say the mess level out loud: “Medium-wet today. We will wash at the end.” High-mess needs time on the clock.

These rituals are teachable moves, not nagging. They protect looking. A meltdown over an uncovered table is often a planning miss, not a character flaw in the child.

Mixing variables you can name lightly (after seeing)

When the child is ready, you may point at *what changed* without a lecture:

- **Which colors met** (yellow + blue vs yellow + red).
- **How much of each** (a little blue vs a lot).
- **How much water** (fat dark vs pale bloom).
- **How long the brush stirred** (quick touch vs long swirl).

Each variable is something they can try on purpose next time. You are not assigning a science fair write-up. You are giving handles for the next mix. Science for Little Thinkers shares the grain of observe-before-explain; this is still art looking — the object is the puddle and the page, not a fair-test board.

Window and sink cousins

If grocery day fails, a window plant and a sink rinse still teach. Look at leaf greens in daylight vs shadow. Rinse a brush from dark to pale in a jar and watch the water change. Ask the locked opening about the water: “What happened when the color met the water — before we name it?” Same spine. Different sink.

For the student

Color is what happens when paints or crayons meet — and when light or water changes how a color looks. You do not have to know the fancy names first. You look. You mix. Then we talk about what you see.

Tiny example. Yellow puddle. Blue puddle. Your brush visits both. A new color shows up in the middle. That new color is yours because your hand made the meeting. If it looks “funny” or muddy, it still counts. Muddy means the colors mixed a lot. That is useful information.

Try 1 — Mix and point. Put two puddles on your paper or tray. Mix once. Point to where they met. Tell someone what you see — before anyone says the color’s name. You can say “darker,” “softer,” “like grass,” or “weird green.” Your words are enough.

Try 2 — Same color, different water. Take one color and a water jar. Make a fat dark spot. Make a pale watery spot of the same color. What changed? Point at both. Keep one watery bloom on purpose.

Explain it back. In your words: what should you do first — mix and look, or say the name of the mix? Tell a grown-up. If you change your mind after another look, that is allowed.

Challenge. Keep one accidental drip on purpose. Tomorrow, tell what that drip could become without wiping it away. Optional: at the store or on a walk, find three greens (or yellows) that are not the same. Tell how they differ.

You are allowed to wait. You are allowed to use a fat brush. You are allowed to stop while you still want one more swirl. Your muddy mix is still your mark. Nobody else gets to finish it for you unless you ask for a tip after you have tried — and even then, the tip happens on demo paper, then the brush comes back to you.

A note about “I can’t paint.” Often that means looking got ahead of the hand, or someone once wiped your mix away. Shorten the job: two puddles, one meeting, one sentence about what you see. You do not have to fill the page. You do not have to make a rainbow. You have to notice.

Whose mark? If a grown-up paints on your page to “help,” ask for a fresh sheet. Your Art folder should show your swirls. A picture a computer made is not your mix — even if it looks “better.” Your looking counts.

If it isn’t clicking

Diagnostic 1 — Adult rainbow fix.

You hear yourself saying “I’ll just fix this,” or you reach for their brush, or you

paint the “right” green on their page.

Next move: put your hands in your pockets. Say the locked opening. Offer a clean corner for a second try with *their* brush. If you already painted on their page, label that corner “demo” honestly and start a fresh sheet for them. Rescue order: ask → wait → hint → short demo on demo paper → return the tool. Do not grab the brush. Do not fill the silence with “pretty.”

Diagnostic 2 — Mess meltdown.

Tears, refusal, panic, or shutdown when paint hits the table or the sleeve.

Next move: you likely skipped mess honesty. Next time, **SAFE-05** before lids: “This hour will be wet. We have cover, smock, and wash time.” Smaller puddles. Washable AP only. Shorter make block; keep look and talk. Tempera sticks or crayon color walks on a hard day. Product-only fridge hour is not the goal — but a flooded table is not required either. Build wash time into the clock so the hour does not end in a rush.

Diagnostic 3 — Wrong materials or solvent smell.

Can says oil, enamel, or shows a **CL** seal; or you smell solvent; or someone suggests “real artist” turpentine for kids.

Next move: stop. Cap it. **SAFE-01 / SAFE-04**. Switch to washable children’s tempera or watercolor with AP / ASTM D-4236. Kitchen art for ages 5–10 does not use turpentine, mineral spirits, or solvent adhesives. Read the label. “Non-toxic” is not a snack invitation. If something was swallowed or got in eyes, follow the label and call Poison Control 1-800-222-1222.

Extra pattern — Name-first freeze. Child shrugs, whispers “green?” and watches your face. Soften: point at the paper. “What do you see — before the name?” Accept “darker” as a full answer.

When to slow down. Stay on two puddles and oral notice until the child can point at a meeting place without hunting a vocabulary word. Stay there even if a workbook says “grade 2 color wheel.”

When to go ahead. If they mix and notice easily, add light/dark water, then warm/cool sort, then limited palette still from a real object.

When to get a human tutor. If sensory distress with wet media stays intense after mess preview and small amounts, or if fine-motor pain appears with brushes, ask a trusted teacher or occupational therapist for tool ideas — fat tools, tempera sticks, crayon resist — while you keep look-before-name. No shame. Looking can continue with dry color walks. A tutor helps tools and comfort; they do not

replace the child's mix with a sample.

Diagnostic note on boredom. If the child says “this is babyish,” check skill not birthday. Offer limited palette still from a real object, or grocery greens with a because-I-see sentence. If they are actually tired of wet mess, switch to COLOR-03 dry collect for a day, then return. Boredom can mean wrong band *or* too much polish pressure — ask which.

Correcting without crushing. Wrong reason: “Muddy means I failed.” Better frame: “Muddy means a lot of meeting happened. Next time you can mix less if you want a brighter middle — your choice.” Then let them try. Do not brighten it for them.

Correct a wrong reason without crushing the look: “You thought muddy meant broken. Muddy means the colors mixed a lot. That’s useful.” Never correct by wiping their page clean for them.

Tools, including AI

Keep this short. Point back to the Art Hour AI box for the full allow-and-ban list.

Physical tools that serve this chapter. AP tempera or watercolor; fat brushes; water jar; towels; table cover; smocks; optional white for limited palette at 8–10; crayon stubs for dry color walks; clipboard for grocery or neighborhood collects. Seal-check new packages (**SAFE-01**). No craft knives. No solvents. Labelled children’s materials only.

Optional AI (parent account only). After the child has mixed, you may ask a tool to explain *to you* what “limited palette” means for a kitchen still life, or to invent three object setups using items already in your kitchen — then the child paints from the **objects**, not from a generated picture. You may look at a composition thumbnail together, then put it away before the child works from life. You may ask for a labelled SCRIPT of questions for *you* to say after the try. You may ask for a hint that is a question (“what if you rinse and try a watery corner?”), not a finished painting.

You may not ask a generator to “make my child’s painting,” hang a fluent mix as theirs, generate a “kids crayon” JPEG as their mark, turn in a generated image as student work, leave a generator unsupervised during making, or write their artist statement as the only draft. Do not upload the child’s face. Do not detector-grade a

mix. Ages 5–7: no live open chat as the child’s partner. Ages 8–10: still parent in the room. Unaided first on looking and mixing. Bastani’s high-school math trial is **OFF-AGE for art hour** — one caution from the Art Hour box, not a kitchen coefficient.

Storage and reuse. Cap bottles. Dry brushes flat or bristles up per your habit — just do not leave them in muddy water overnight. A dried accidental swirl on scrap can become a collage scrap next chapter. Process continues across weeks.

What you can skip buying. You do not need a full spectrum set, a light box, or solvent mediums. Two or three AP bottles, white if you add limited palette, fat brushes, paper, cover, smocks. Library how-to picture books can sit beside the table *after* the mix for “does this match what we saw?” — not as the only hour.

What “done enough” looks like

Before you leave a focused color week (or before you thin the focus to one COLOR card as review):

- ☐ Child mixed at least two colors (or one color with water) and noticed a new color or a light/dark change.
- ☐ Naming happened **after** looking — or waited until tomorrow.
- ☐ Table was covered; food off the art table; washable **AP** (or ASTM D-4236) materials used; mess preview said out loud at least once.
- ☐ You caught at least one adult-rainbow-fix impulse and left the child’s mix alone (or labelled your demo honestly).
- ☐ Talk box used the locked opening once; child pointed at something on the page or produce.
- ☐ One out-of-home color look happened (grocery, walk, or window) *or* is clearly scheduled this week.
- ☐ Exit crumb exists: oral notice, three-word caption (adult may scribe at 5–7), kept drip with a reason, or a photo of *their* page in the dated folder — not a generated stand-in.
- ☐ Folder or sketchbook shows the child’s marks, not adult-finished rainbows filed as theirs.

Place by skill, not birthday. A seven-year-old ready for limited palette may try it. A nine-year-old who still freezes at mud may stay on two puddles and grocery greens. A “grade 2 art workbook” rainbow page is a publisher’s scope — not a

legal grade, and not your transcript line. The work lives under **Art**. Never under a brand name. Never under Little Thinkers Art I.

Done enough is permission to move toward collage and print with the same spine: look before name; make before polish. Revisit a favorite mix next Tuesday if you want. Mix last week's idea into a torn-paper hour later. Stop while wanting one more swirl. The fridge picture is evidence a sitting happened — not the grade. Process is what the mix did to the child's looking. **Life of the habit (no ninth chapter)**. Next Tuesday, reopen a dry mix page and ask what they notice now. Mix last week's leftover idea into a torn-paper hour in Chapter 5. Stop while wanting one more swirl. The habit is the rhythm — look, mix, talk, name lightly, crumb — not a diploma and not a percentile.

If energy is low, shorten the make block, keep the look and the talk box, and stop while wanting one more mark. Dose honesty includes rest. There is no national study that says otherwise — and you do not need one to choose a shorter Tuesday.

Tomorrow's object can be as small as two closed bottles and a covered table. That is enough to begin. Look first. Mix second. Name lightly. Leave the drip. Your child's meeting place on the paper is the curriculum for this chapter.

When in doubt, ask the locked opening again and wait. The paint will answer if you let it.

Chapter 5 — Collage, print, and paper



Figure 7: A tear collage beside a foam stamp — still-life, no people, no logos.

Why this matters

Paper teaches two big looking moves before any fancy knife enters the room. First: arrange, then stick. Second: press, lift, look. Collage and print share this chapter because both ask the child to notice what the *material* did — a torn edge, a layered peek, a stamp's repeat, a leaf's veins on the page — not only whether the finished page matches a sample on the fridge.

Look before name still holds. You do not begin with “this is monoprinting” while the paper is still dry. Make before polish holds harder here than in crayon hour. Adult hands love to cut the “nice” shapes, line up the mosaic, and reprint the stamp until it looks store-bought. The child's torn edge and slightly crooked press are the work.

This chapter unlocks authorship in paper. A five- to seven-year-old who tears before fancy cutting learns that irregular edges are information. An eight- to ten-year-old who pulls a foam-plate print compares plate to paper and sees what the press changed. You learn to keep craft knives out of this age book, to prefer glue stick over solvent adhesives, and to ask what the paper or the press did that they can point at.

Worth the struggle: collage without a photocopied template teaches decision. Print without intaglio tools teaches cause and effect you can see. Library scraps and fallen leaves cost little. The skill is arrange-before-stick and press–lift–look — not a craft-store diploma.

Safety stays ordinary and firm: labelled children's scissors; adult present; no craft knives; washable inks and AP glues; non-toxic plants for leaf prints; choke check on small scraps if younger siblings share the floor. Tear before fancy cut. Air and paper first; polish never first.

Paper is also a bridge between drawing and making in space. A torn shape sits on a page the way a coil will later sit on a board. Overlap in tissue prepares eyes for overlap in drawing. A stamp's repeat is rhythm you can hear with your eyes. You are not rushing into a print studio credit. You are giving the child material cause-and-effect they can point at — the same spine as color week's puddle meeting, now with paper and pressure.

Homeschool art hours often default to coloring-book outlines because they feel tidy. Collage and print politely refuse tidy as the only virtue. Mess honesty still applies: ink hours need cover and wash time. Glue hours need a wipe cloth. The

goal is not chaos. The goal is authorship you can see in a torn edge.

Worth one more sentence for busy parents: you do not need a die-cut machine, a silhouette cutter, or a craft-knife set to teach real paper art at 5–10. You need scraps, a glue stick, washable ink, time to arrange, and the will to leave a crooked stamp alone. That will is the teaching. The materials are ordinary.

If your home has been coloring-book-only for months, this chapter is a gentle reset. Tear week is not an insult to a nine-year-old. It is skill placement. AS-style honesty later will ask whose mark is on the page — start practicing that honesty with torn edges now.

For the parent: understand it yourself

Everyday picture. Everyone at the table gets the same printed template. You pre-cut the shapes “so it looks nice.” The child glues where the dotted lines suggest. Three pages look identical. You praise “pretty.” Tomorrow they wait for you to cut again. Authorship quietly left the room.

Precise picture. A stack of colored paper. One background sheet. You say, “Tear some shapes. Arrange them before any glue.” The child tears a jagged blue river and a red sun with a fuzzy edge. They move pieces three times. Then they glue. You ask, “What did the paper or the press do that you can point at?” They point at the fuzzy sun edge: “It looks soft because I tore it.” You do not re-cut the sun. Naming *collage* can wait until after the arrange.

For print: a foam scrap or a leaf, washable paint, paper. Press. Lift. Look. The surprise mark is the teacher. A second pull is optional. Foam plate lines at 8–10 use a dull pencil — not a craft knife. If a potato stamp appears, *you* cut the potato; the child presses.

Wrong answers you should be able to hear

1. **“Let me cut that so it looks right.”** Adult takeover for polish. Reply: “Tear version first. If you want scissors later, labelled children’s scissors — your hands.”
2. **“Everyone make the same owl from the template.”** Sample-only collage as the hour. Reply: template can be a warm-up look; the make is child’s arrangement from scraps.

3. **“We’ll carve this with a craft knife — it’s more real.”** Wrong tool for this age book. Reply: foam plate + dull pencil, or stamp soft. No craft-knife intaglio here. Later depth lives in other books and older years.
4. **“This glue from the garage works better — it says industrial.”** Solvent adhesive risk. Reply: AP glue stick preferred for 5–7; school glue that is water-based and labelled for children. No solvent glues as kitchen art.
5. **“Just stamp until it matches the sample border.”** Press–lift–look replaced by product matching. Reply: one press, look, talk; repeats for rhythm after noticing, not for identical store finish.

Five-minute parent warm-up. Alone: tear three shapes from scrap paper. Arrange on a background. Move them twice before any glue. Glue once. Ask yourself: “What did the paper do that I can point at?” Notice one torn edge you would usually trim. Leave it. For print warm-up: press a leaf underside with washable paint onto scrap; lift; look at veins before any vocabulary. Put tools away. You are practicing arrange-before-stick and press–lift–look — not building a portfolio piece.

Precise picture — print compare. Foam plate with a dull-pencil spiral. Light ink. Paper pressed with a spoon. Lift. The spiral on paper is softer than the plate. The child says, “It got quieter.” You say, “You can point at what the press did.” Later you may say *print*. You do not recarve the plate to force a sharper match to an Instagram sample. Compare plate to paper is the looking move.

About “real” printmaking. Copper plates, acid, and craft-knife linocut are real in older studios. They are not this book’s tools. Foam, leaf, stamp, and mono pull are not fake art. They are age-fit presses. *Art for Homeschooling* can own later medium depth; this Hour owns press–lift–look without knives.

Warm/cool of paper. Scraps have temperature too — red tissue vs blue magazine sky. After overlap peek, you may invite a soft warm/cool sort of leftover scraps for tomorrow’s bin. Name lightly after their sort. Color chapter skills recycle; do not restart vocabulary class.

Five wrong-answer repairs in one breath. Hear polish → return tool. Hear template-only → scrap basket. Hear knife → foam/dull pencil. Hear solvent glue → AP stick. Hear “match the sample” → locked opening about what *their* paper did.

How to teach it this week

Session shape (Art Hour, ~20–40 min).

1. **Look / notice (3–8 min).** Feel paper edges — torn vs cut scraps already on the table. Or look at a leaf's underside veins. Or look at a stamp's shape before inking.
2. **Short make (8–18 min).** Tear and arrange before glue; or press–lift–look once. Child's hands on scissors only when labelled children's scissors and skill are ready — tear first for 5–7. Demo on demo paper only.
3. **Talk box (3–8 min).** Locked opening. Wait. Point with words at paper or press marks.
4. **Name lightly (2–5 min, optional).** *Collage, print, overlap, repeat* — after seeing. Can wait.
5. **Exit crumb (2–5 min).** Choose a page for the wall with one reason; or say one process sentence: "I tore first" / "I pressed and lifted."

Exact sentences you can say

- "Tear some shapes. Arrange before any glue."
- "What changed when you moved that piece?"
- "Press — lift — look. What do you see?"
- "What did the paper or the press do that you can point at?"
- "I'll cut the potato. You press."
- "Dull pencil on foam only — no craft knives in this hour."
- "Your torn edge stays. We are not trimming it pretty unless you ask after you've looked."

First try-it: COLLAGE-01 Tear Not Cut First (band 5–7; useful reset for any age).

- **Time:** 20–30 min.
- **Materials:** Colored paper; glue stick (AP); background sheet; table cover.
- **Mess / safety:** Medium; glue stick preferred over liquid for 5–7; wash hands; cover table.
- **The fun:** Fuzzy edges and surprise shapes that scissors would have "fixed."
- **The skill:** Tear shapes; arrange before gluing; look at tear edges. Looking at edges of tears is the point.

How to fade help. Day one: you may start one tear to show the motion on demo paper, then stop. Day two: child tears all. Day three: arrange for a full minute

before glue bottle appears. For print: you ink once as demo; they press. Fade until their presses are the page.

When to stop talking. After “arrange before glue.” After the locked opening. During the press. Do not narrate every scrap into a story they did not choose. Do not say “pretty” as the only word.

Age-band moves

- **5–7:** Tear-first collage; glue stick; large scraps; hand/found stamp soft; leaf underside with adult; mono pull with small paint amounts; oral process notice; adult may scribe. Scissors only as labelled children’s scissors with adult present — snips on strips before interior cuts (**SAFE-03**). No craft knives. Choke check if yarn bits or buttons appear.
- **8–10:** Add overlap peek with tissue; cut strip mosaic; found-paper portrait soft (not a photocopy of adult sample); foam plate line print with dull pencil; repeat stamp border with rhythm talk; written process crumb optional. Still refuse craft-knife intaglio. Still child’s presses. If tear-and-arrange habits are weak, stay there even if birthday says nine.

This-week plan. Focus: arrange-before-stick *or* press–lift–look (you may alternate days). Three to five Hours. One OUT cousin — nature leaf collect for PRINT-03, or library picture-book look at collage/print pages *after* a home make, not instead of it. Friday: done-enough + one diagnostic (adult cut everything?).

Sample dialogue (illustration).

Parent: “Tear five shapes. No glue yet.”

Child: (*tears, arranges, rearranges*)

Parent: “What changed when you moved the blue one?”

Child: “It looked like water under the red.”

Parent: “Glue when you like it.” (*later*) “What did the paper or the press do that you can point at?”

Child: “This edge is fuzzy. Scissors would make it sharp.”

Parent: “Yes. That’s something the tear did.”

Scissors card in the week. One short **SAFE-03** sitting: labelled children’s scissors, snip paper strips into a pile for later mosaic. Open/close practice. No invented hard age lock — follow the tool label and the child’s skill. Adult present. Tear days remain available forever; scissors are an add, not a promotion that ends tearing.

Safety this week (paper and press). Labelled children's scissors; adult present; **no craft knives.** Washable stamp pads / tempera. AP glue. Non-toxic plants only for leaf prints; wash hands. Small parts — choke check. Food off table. Cover for inky hours. Solvent adhesives stay in the garage, not on the art table.

Fade map across five sittings. (1) Tear + arrange, adult holds glue until asked. (2) Child glues own arrangement. (3) Add one scissors strip pile. (4) First stamp presses with look-between. (5) Foam plate or leaf compare. Skip ahead only when the prior sitting's skill shows up without nagging. Birthday does not skip the map.

When to stop the make early. If glue frustration spikes, switch to dry arrange-only for five minutes and end with talk box. If ink floods, wipe, smaller amounts, one more press maximum. Ending early with a real notice beats finishing a soggy page for the fridge.

Practice that actually builds learning

Collage try-its (in-home)

COLLAGE-01 Tear Not Cut First — above; default opener.

COLLAGE-02 Scrap Story Soft — band both; 20–35 min.

Materials: magazine or safe scrap paper; labelled children's scissors; glue; background.

Mess / safety: medium; adult present for scissors.

The fun: building a scene or abstract from chosen scraps after a look prompt (“find busy textures” / “find quiet colors”).

The skill: choose after looking; child decides when glued. Not a race to cover the page.

COLLAGE-03 Texture Collage Tray — band both; 20–35 min.

Materials: fabric scraps, paper, yarn bits; glue; tray.

Mess / safety: medium–high; choke check for younger siblings; wash hands.

The fun: feel-then-stick. Rough next to smooth.

The skill: sort by feel; name texture lightly after sorting. Looking with fingers supports looking with eyes.

COLLAGE-04 Overlap Peek — band 8–10; 20–30 min.

Materials: translucent paper or tissue (AP dyes); glue stick; background.

Mess / safety: medium; tissue can stain — cover table; smocks.

The fun: colors change when layers meet — a cousin of paint mix, in paper.
 The skill: layer to see through; notice what changes when papers overlap. Ask: “What do you see through the top piece?”

COLLAGE-05 Cut Strip Mosaic — band both; 20–35 min.

Materials: paper strips (adult may pre-strip for 5–7; child cuts strips at 8–10 with children’s scissors); glue; background.

Mess / safety: medium; labelled scissors.

The fun: filling a big drawn shape with strips like a puzzle.

The skill: pattern talk *after* making. Rhythm of repeats without requiring perfection.

COLLAGE-06 Found-Paper Portrait Soft — band 8–10; 25–40 min.

Materials: scraps; glue; optional pencil guide the *child* draws.

Mess / safety: medium.

The fun: creature or face from unexpected scraps — button eyes only if choke-safe and you agree.

The skill: portrait or creature from scraps — not a photocopy of an adult sample. Child’s guide lines, child’s glue.

SHAPE support (as needed). SHAPE-02 cut a shape family, SHAPE-04 positive/negative tear, SHAPE-05 shape city soft can visit this chapter when shape play helps collage — sort and build before geometric names. They support; they do not replace tear-first or press–lift–look.

Print try-its (in-home)

PRINT-01 Hand/Found Stamp Soft — band 5–7; 20–30 min.

Materials: washable stamp pad or tempera on sponge; paper; foam scrap or cookie cutter; potato optional.

Mess / safety: medium–high; washable ink only; **adult cuts potato if used**; wash hands; cover table.

The fun: press–lift–look; pattern from repeat.

The skill: child’s presses. One look after first press before filling the page.

PRINT-02 Foam Plate Line Print — band 8–10; 25–40 min.

Materials: foam plate or foam sheet; dull pencil; washable paint; paper; spoon or clean hand for press.

Mess / safety: medium; **no craft knives**; adult present.

The fun: lines you drew in foam appear reversed or softened on paper.

The skill: incise lines; ink lightly; pull print; compare plate to print. Talk what the press changed.

PRINT-03 Leaf Underside Print — band both; 20–30 min.

Materials: fallen leaves from a safe area; washable paint; paper.

Mess / safety: medium; wash hands; **non-toxic plants only**; outdoor collect with adult.

The fun: veins appear like a secret map.

The skill: paint leaf underside; press; look at vein marks before naming *print*.

Nature line/texture outing feeds this card.

PRINT-04 Mono Pull Surprise — band both; 20–30 min.

Materials: tray or plastic lid; paint smear; paper.

Mess / safety: medium–high; cover; smocks; small amounts.

The fun: one pull; accident marks welcome.

The skill: talk accident marks; second pull optional. Keep a surprise blob — what could it become?

PRINT-05 Repeat Stamp Border — band both; 15–25 min.

Materials: one stamp shape; paper strip or page edge.

Mess / safety: low–medium.

The fun: a marching border of repeats.

The skill: notice rhythm after making. Not “make them identical.” Notice same-same with tiny differences.

Sample week — Paper and press (menu)

- **Monday:** SAFE-02 + COLLAGE-01 tear not cut. Talk box locked opening. Exit: point at one torn edge.
- **Tuesday:** PRINT-01 hand/found stamp soft (adult cuts potato if used). Press–lift–look before filling the page.
- **Wednesday:** COLLAGE-03 texture tray *or* COLLAGE-02 scrap story. Process sentence: “I felt then stuck” / “I chose after looking.”
- **Thursday:** OUT leaf collect + PRINT-03 at home, *or* library look at collage pages then home tear (look motivates; make still happens).
- **Friday:** PRINT-02 foam plate (8–10) *or* PRINT-05 repeat border (both). Done-enough checklist. Note if adult hands took the scissors too early.

Three Hours plus one OUT is enough. Alternate collage-heavy and print-heavy weeks if attention is thin. Revisit tear-first any time polish anxiety returns.

Out-of-home try-its

Nature leaf & texture (feeds PRINT-03 / COLLAGE-03). Walk with adult; collect fallen leaves from safe plants; notice bark rubbings with crayon on paper if you like (rubbing is a cousin of print). Courtesy on trails; wash hands.

Library picture-book look first (OUT-04 grain). Before or after a home collage hour, look at a picture book's torn-paper or stamped art. Cover the caption. Ask what the paper seems to have done. Then go home and try — looking motivates; it does not replace the make.

Architecture edge walk (OUT-06, 8–10). Notice repeated windows as “stamps” the building already made. Quick sketch optional. Traffic safety with adult.

Talk box

Opening (locked): “What did the paper or the press do that you can point at?”

Follow-ups:

1. Look: “What do you *notice* on that torn edge / in that stamp?”
2. Make: “What did your hands (or the press) do?”
3. Evidence: “What do you see that makes you say that?”
4. Process: “How did you decide when to glue?” / “What changed when you lifted the paper?”
5. Revise: “Want to move a piece before it dries?” / “Second pull — same or different?”

How to wait. Slow three after the opening. Look at the page or the plate, not at the child's face, if silence is hard. After they finish a sentence, wait again. Mid-arrange and mid-press are sacred — do not cut them off to lecture about collage history.

Stuck silence usually means: you asked “what is it?” instead of tell-me/point; wait-time was zero; they fear crooked edges; you always cut for them; identical sample hours trained them to wait for the template; they think a generated collage JPEG is “better.” Point at a specific torn edge or ink blot. Ask the locked opening again. Wait.

Blocked / mixed / incorrect example

Blocked. Craft knives. Solvent adhesives. Adult cuts every shape “for niceness.” Identical template as the only product. Generator collage filed as the child’s work.

Mixed — when to use which. Tear-first when polish anxiety is high. Texture tray when hands need a feel break from scissors. Overlap peek when color mix ideas should transfer to paper. Foam plate when 8–10 are ready for compare-plate-to-print. Leaf print when you need an OUT-linked make. Mono pull when accident-keeping needs practice. Repeat border when rhythm talk is the crumb.

Incorrect example (illustration). Parent downloads a “cute fox collage,” prints templates, pre-cuts all pieces, and has the child glue tabs A–F. Three siblings’ foxes match. Diagnosis: sample-only hour; adult-filled cuts; arrange-before-stick never happened. Repair: scrap basket, tear session, locked opening about *their* edges. Template fox can be looked at, then put away.

Incorrect print pattern. Parent uses a craft knife to carve a detailed stamp “because foam looks babyish,” then hands the stamp to the child for one press. Diagnosis: wrong tool; adult-made plate as fake child authorship if filed as theirs without honesty. Repair: dull pencil on foam by the child; or label adult-carved demo as demo; child’s presses on their own plate.

Practice notes that keep the hour honest

Arrange minute — teach it as a ritual

Set a visible timer for sixty seconds (or count slowly together) during which glue stays off the table. The child may move pieces freely. When the minute ends, ask once: “Ready to stick, or one more move?” This is not rigid theater. It is a teachable pause that blocks glue-as-race. If sixty seconds is too long at five, try thirty and grow.

Demo paper for scissors and stamps

Anything you must show — how to open scissors, how to ink a foam scrap, how hard to press a leaf — happens on paper or scrap labelled DEMO. Then the tool returns. If you ink their leaf “to help,” you stole a press. Ink a demo leaf; let them ink theirs.

Mixing collage and print in one week

You may collage Monday and print Thursday without “finishing” a unit. The shared skill is noticing what the material did. A torn-paper sun and a stamped border can live in the same sketchbook. Caption crumb: “torn” / “pressed” / “layered.” Adult scribes at 5–7.

What stuck silence sounds like in paper hour

- Shrug after “What is it?” — bad question; switch to locked opening.
- “Can you make it nice?” — polish fear; answer with tear-first and process praise.
- Waiting with hands in lap while you cut — adult-takeover training; put scissors down; invite tear.
- Pointing at a phone collage as theirs — authorship honesty; separate sample from make.

Positive/negative and shape city as optional bridges

At 8–10, positive/negative tear (SHAPE-04): tear a shape from dark paper, keep both the shape and the hole, glue both on light ground. Notice both. Shape city (SHAPE-05): build a place from paper shapes — child’s architecture, not a tracing of a map. Use these when collage energy wants structure; return to free tear when structure becomes sample-matching.

Ink and glue amounts

Small beads of glue beat puddles. Thin ink beats soaked foam. More material is not more learning. Mess honesty means naming wetness, not celebrating floods. Wash time on the clock prevents the hour from ending in a fight at the sink.

Courtesy on collects

Leaf and texture walks: take fallen leaves; leave living plants unless you own them and know they are non-toxic. Grocery and library trips for looking do not require purchases. Staff courtesy is part of out-of-home try-its. Looking in public is practice for museum sits later.

Connecting back to color week

Tissue overlap is color meeting in paper. A stamp pad's blue next to yellow scraps can echo two-puddle noticing without opening tempera. Ask: "What happened when these colors met on your page — before we name the mix?" Same locked spirit; different materials. Do not force the color chapter's opening word-for-word if today's locked opening fits better — use ch05's opening for collage/print hours.

Incorrect rescue to refuse

Parent completes the mosaic after bedtime so morning fridge looks finished. That is adult mark filed as child work. Better: unfinished page with a sticky note "more strips tomorrow." Process over polish. The fridge is not a grade.

When siblings share the table

Separate scrap trays. Separate presses. Whose-mark talk: "Point at your torn edges." Older child may demo on demo paper once — then younger works. Do not let the older child's sample become the required product for the younger.

For the student

Paper can be torn, cut, layered, pressed, and pulled. The important part is what *you* do with it — and what you notice when the paper or the press answers back.

Tiny example. You tear a blue shape. The edge looks soft and fuzzy. You place it on white paper, move it, then glue. That fuzzy edge is something you can point at. Or: you paint a leaf's underside, press it down, lift — veins appear. You can point at the veins. That pointing is looking.

Try 1 — Arrange before stick. Tear at least five shapes. Move them around for one whole minute before any glue. Then stick. Tell what the paper did that you can point at.

Try 2 — Press, lift, look. Use a stamp, a leaf, or a paint smear on a tray. Press paper. Lift. Look before you press again. What surprised you?

Explain it back. What should happen first in collage — glue everything fast, or arrange and look? What are the three words for print practice: press, lift, ...?

Challenge. Keep one “wrong” torn edge or one surprise blot on purpose. Tomorrow, tell what it could become. Optional: find a leaf on a walk (with a grown-up) and print its underside at home.

Your page does not have to match a sample fox. A computer picture of a collage is not your collage. Your torn edges and your presses count.

More tries if you want. Layer two tissue pieces and peek through. Fill a big circle with paper strips. Draw a simple face guide yourself, then build it from scraps — your guide, your glue. For print: make a border of repeats and notice which stamp landed heavier. Keep a mono-pull surprise as tomorrow’s “what could it become?” game.

Explain more. Why might a grown-up want to cut your shapes for you? What will you say if that happens? Practice: “I want to tear mine.” You are allowed to say that.

Tiny worked story. Maya tears green paper into bumpy hills. She places a yellow tear for sun, moves it left, then right, then glues. Her grown-up asks what the paper did. Maya points: “The hill edge is rough. I like rough.” That is a complete Art Hour. No owl template required.

Sam paints a leaf, presses, lifts. The first pull is faint. He inks more and presses again. Second pull shows veins. He points: “The press made the lines show.” That is print looking. Crooked leaf stamp still counts.

If it isn’t clicking

Diagnostic 1 — Adult takeover.

You cut everything; child only glues; or you re-press until the stamp is perfect. Next move: hands off cutting for one full Hour — tear only. For print: one demo press on demo paper, then their presses only. Say: “Your edges. Your presses.” If you already cut a stack, put the stack on demo corner and start a fresh tear pile for them.

Diagnostic 2 — Identical outputs / sample-only.

Every page matches the printout; pride is only in sameness. Next move: hide the template after a one-minute look. Scrap basket. Locked opening about differences they can point at. Praise a decision (“you moved the sun three times”) more than likeness to sample.

Diagnostic 3 — Knife temptation or solvent glue.

Someone wants craft-knife carving or garage adhesive “for better craft.”

Next move: refuse for this age book. Foam + dull pencil; washable ink; AP glue stick. Say plainly: knives and solvent glues are not tools for this Hour. Later sculpture and print depth belong in older work and other manuals — not here.

Extra — Scissors freeze or fight. Return to **SAFE-03**: snip strips first; open/close practice; tear-first days. Skill not birthday. Adult present.

When to slow down. Stay on tear-and-arrange until the child moves pieces before gluing without being told every time.

When to go ahead. Add scissors strips, overlap tissue, foam plate compare, found-paper creature.

When to get a human tutor. Persistent scissors pain or sensory distress with glue after small amounts and stick preference — ask OT or trusted teacher for adaptive scissors or glue alternatives while keeping arrange-before-stick. No shame.

Correct without crushing: “Crooked isn’t broken — it’s your press. Want to try a second press and compare?”

Diagnostic 4 — Glue-as-race. Child dumps glue everywhere to finish fast; looking never happens.

Next move: glue stick only; arrange minute with glue in your pocket; then glue appears. Say: “Glue is the last step today.”

Diagnostic 5 — Generated sample as ‘my art’. Phone shows a polished collage; child shrugs at their tears.

Next move: name the phone image generated or photographed sample. Fridge and folder keep *their* page. Looking at samples is fine; filing samples as their mark is not.

Tools, including AI

Physical tools. Colored and scrap paper; glue stick (AP) preferred at 5–7; water-based school glue as needed; labelled children’s scissors; foam plates; dull pencils; washable stamp pads or tempera; sponges; fallen leaves from safe plants; table cover; smocks; trays for mono pulls. No craft knives. No solvent adhesives. Seal-check new inks and glues (**SAFE-01** grain).

Optional AI (parent account only). After the child has arranged or pulled a print, you may ask a tool to explain *to you* what “overlap” means in collage terms, or to suggest scrap themes using materials you already have — then the child builds from real scraps. SCRIPT questions for you after the try are fine. You may not generate a collage or print and file it as theirs, unsupervised during making, or as a “child style” stand-in. Parent holds the account. 5–7: no live open chat as partner. 8–10: parent in the room. Unaided first on arrange and press. Point back to the Art Hour AI box.

Shopping without spiral. Dollar-store foam sheets, kids’ washable pads with AP seals, construction paper, glue sticks. Check seals. Skip “pro” solvent mediums marketed as upgrades for children. Library free look first. Museum postcards of collage can inspire after a make — caption covered first if you practice looking moves from earlier chapters.

AI reminder in one line. Tool may prep *you*; it may not arrange or press for the child, and it may not become the page in the folder.

What “done enough” looks like

- ☐ Child arranged before gluing at least once, *or* pressed–lifted–looked at least once (ideally both across the week).
- ☐ One process notice about what the paper or press did (oral at 5–7; oral or written at 8–10).
- ☐ Tear-first happened before fancy cut goals; children’s scissors only when used; **no craft knives**.
- ☐ Washable inks / AP glues; adult cut potato if any; non-toxic leaves if printed.
- ☐ Talk box used locked opening; child pointed at an edge, layer, vein, or stamp mark.
- ☐ Adult takeover caught and repaired at least once if it appeared.
- ☐ Exit crumb: wall choice with one reason, process sentence, or dated page in the Art folder — child’s marks.
- ☐ No generated collage/print filed as student work.

Place by skill, not birthday. A six-year-old who arranges thoughtfully is done enough for collage week even without scissors mosaic. A ten-year-old who still glues the first placement may need another tear week before foam plate. Work lives under **Art**.

Life of the habit without a ninth chapter: next Tuesday, tear leftover scrap from today's bin into a new arrange. Mix last week's color puddle idea into tissue overlap. Stop while wanting one more press. Look before name; make before polish — paper version. If energy is low, tear three shapes and talk — skip the full mosaic. Dose honesty includes rest. Next Tuesday, open the scrap bin and arrange again. The habit is arrange-before-stick and press-lift-look, revisited, not a one-week craft binge.

Tomorrow's setup can be a scrap basket, a glue stick, and a covered table — or a leaf, washable paint, and paper. Ask what the paper or the press did. Wait. Point. Leave the fuzzy edge alone.

Carry-forward checklist crumb. Note in the sketchbook margin: “tear before cut — yes/no this week” and “press-lift-look — yes/no.” Those two checks matter more than counting how many craft samples you completed. Coverage itch wants twelve projects; looking wants one honest arrange and one honest pull.

Revisit a fuzzy torn edge next Tuesday. Mix a leftover stamp into a border. Stop while wanting one more press. Look before name; make before polish. The paper will teach if you let the child hold it.

When in doubt, ask the locked opening and wait. Point at an edge. Leave the crooked stamp. That is enough for a real Art Hour — and enough to move on when done-enough checks clear.

A final parent sentence: you are allowed to keep a unfinished collage in the folder overnight. Morning glue is still the child's glue. Overnight adult “finishing” is polish stealing authorship. Trust the tear. Trust the press. Trust the wait after the question. Paper art at 5–10 is looking you can hold in your hands — scrap by scrap, pull by pull — without knives, without solvent glue, and without a sample that erases the child's edge.

If this week only yields one honest arrange-before-stick and one honest press-lift-look, you succeeded. Depth is the hour. The scrap bin will still be there next week. So will the locked opening. So will your child's hands.

Put the glue stick beside the scrap basket tonight. Tomorrow, tear first. Arrange. Ask what the paper did. Wait. That sequence is the chapter in miniature — and it is enough to begin again whenever polish tries to take the scissors from your child's hands.

Look before name. Make before polish. Tear before fancy cut. Press, lift, look.

The child's edge is the curriculum. Leave it on the page.

Chapter 6 — Clay and 3-D soft

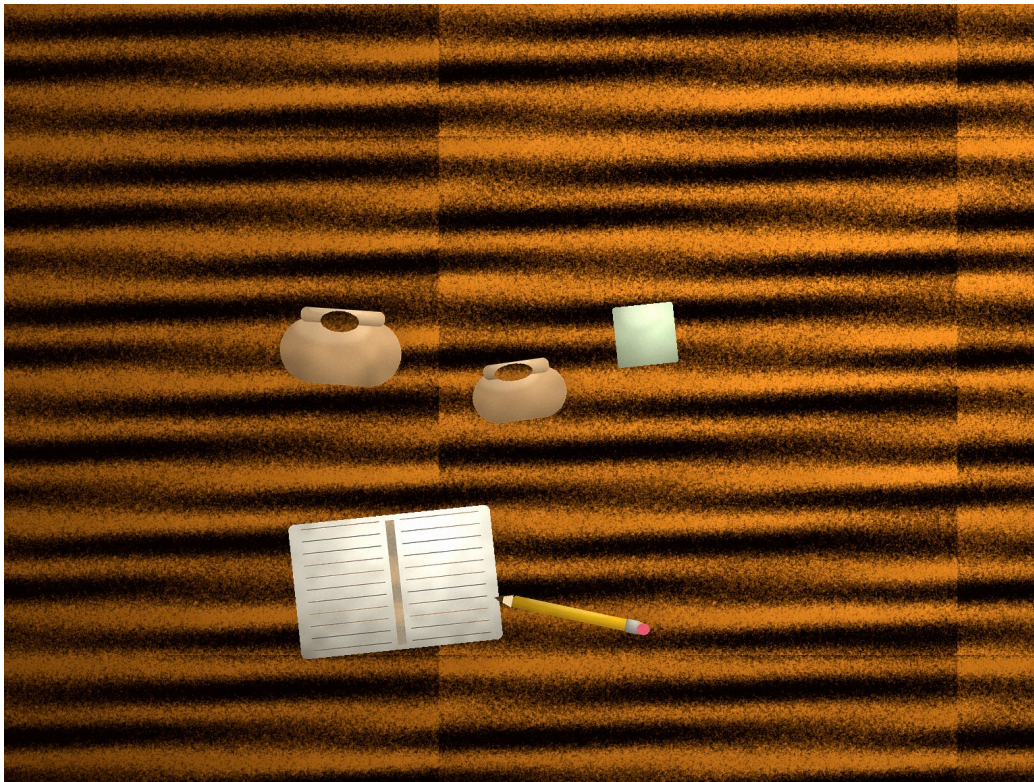


Figure 8: Pinch pots on a wooden table — still-life, no people, no logos.

Why this matters

Clay tells the truth with gravity. A pinch pot's wall thins. A coil softens. A tall idea leans and falls. That fall is not failure — it is the material talking. This chapter teaches redesign when soft 3-D fails, with the child's hands still on the clay.

Look before name: notice what the clay did before anyone says *pinch pot* or *coil*. Make before polish: adult hands do not re-smooth a “nice pot” before the child has struggled, tried, and chosen a next move. Soft clay only — air-dry or playdough with an **AP** seal as the default. No kiln required for this age book. No craft knives as armature default. Toothpicks or skewers, if used, stay adult-supervised and tip-only after struggle.

Worth the struggle: a child who redesigns a fallen form learns stretch-and-explore without a speech about grit. An eight- to ten-year-old who builds something that stands, watches it lean, and tries a wider base is doing real sculpture thinking at kitchen scale. A parent who asks “what did the clay do — and what will you try next if it falls?” is teaching process over fridge-ready polish.

Soft spatial play supports this chapter without becoming a formal perspective course. Big and small on one page, overlap of two objects, where things “sit” on a baseline, near and far from a window — these SPACE tries help eyes that will later draw what clay showed the hands. Clay then draw closes a look–make–look loop: form first, then a drawing from one angle.

This is not a ceramics credit. *Art for Homeschooling* can own kiln and harder sculpture later. Here the Hour owns pinch, coil, stamp texture, stand-up redesign, and soft space. Place by skill, not birthday. Short sits beat long melt-downs. Damp wipe for clay dust. Adult present.

For the parent: understand it yourself

Everyday picture. The child's pinch pot sags. You take it, remake a smooth bowl in ten seconds, and say, “See? Like this.” The child nods. Tomorrow they wait for you to finish every form. Collapse became shame. Your polish became the standard.

Precise picture. Same sag. You wait. You ask, “What did the clay do — and what will you try next if it falls?” The child says, “It got thin here.” You: “What could

you try?” They thicken the wall — or mash and start a coil — or smile and stamp texture on the pancake that remains. You offer a tip only after struggle, on a demo lump if needed, then return their clay. Their walls stay theirs.

Fernando-Smith’s grain (process and product can both have value, with process default in early years) fits here: a standing coil is lovely; a redesigned fall is the teaching. Do not shame collapsed walls. Do not kiln-shame playdough. Soft is the point.

Wrong answers you should be able to hear

1. **“I’ll just fix it so it looks like a real pot.”** Adult re-smooth before struggle. Reply: “Your walls. What will you try next?” Tip after struggle; demo lump, not takeover.
2. **“We can’t do clay without a kiln.”** Kiln as false gate. Reply: air-dry or playdough AP default. Dry on a board. Paint later if you want — washable. No kiln needed for this book.
3. **“It fell — you ruined it.”** Shame for collapse. Reply: “The clay told us something. What’s next?” Redesign is the skill.
4. **“Let’s cut supports with a craft knife.”** Wrong default tool. Reply: thicker base, shorter height, coil reinforcement; adult-only tips for toothpick after struggle if needed. No craft-knife culture in this Hour.
5. **“Just copy my sample dinosaur so it stands.”** Sample-matched 3-D. Reply: child’s form first; stand-up challenge is their engineering, not your sculpture demo filed as theirs.

Five-minute parent warm-up. Alone: roll a ball of air-dry or playdough. Pinch a pot until a wall thins. Let it sag on purpose. Ask yourself the locked opening. Redesign once — wider base or thicker wall. Do not aim for gallery finish. Aim for felt redesign. Wipe the board. You are practicing leave-the-walls-alone and try-next-if-it-falls.

Precise picture — clay then draw. Child makes a lumpy animal. From one angle, they draw what they see — not what they invent from memory alone. Looking returns after making. That loop is gold. Put the form on the table; eyes on form; pencil on paper. Short sit.

How to teach it this week

Session shape (Art Hour, ~20–40 min).

1. **Look / notice (3–8 min).** Soften clay together. Notice warm/cool of the lump, cracks, fingerprints. Or look at a mug's volume before pinching. Or look at two objects overlapping for SPACE soft.
2. **Short make (8–18 min).** Pinch from a ball; or roll coils; or stamp textures; or stand-up challenge. Child's hands. Demo on demo lump only. If it falls, redesign — do not snatch.
3. **Talk box (3–8 min).** Locked opening. Wait. Follow-ups on what clay did and what's next.
4. **Name lightly (2–5 min, optional).** *Pinch, coil, base, texture* — after trying. Can wait.
5. **Exit crumb (2–5 min).** Keep or mash with intention; photo of process optional; clay-then-draw crumb; oral “next time I'll...”

Exact sentences you can say

- “Pinch from the ball. Your walls.”
- “What did the clay do — and what will you try next if it falls?”
- “Thin walls tip. What could thicken?”
- “I'll show a wider base on my demo lump. Then your clay again.”
- “Fallen is information. Mash and redesign, or repair — your choice.”
- “Stamp the slab. What do you see in the print?”
- “Draw what you see from this angle — the clay is still the teacher.”

First try-it: CLAY-01 Pinch Pot Soft (band both).

- **Time:** 20–35 min.
- **Materials:** Air-dry clay or playdough (AP); wipe cloth; board or covered table; water drop optional for air-dry.
- **Mess / safety:** Medium; clay dust — damp wipe; no kiln needed; wash hands; adult present; small parts if adding beads — choke check.
- **The fun:** A hollow appears because *their* fingers pinched.
- **The skill:** Pinch from ball; child's walls. Adult does not re-smooth into “nice pot” unless child asks for a tip after struggle — then demo lump, return tool (hands).

How to fade help. Sitting 1: show open-pinch once on demo lump; their ball. Sitting 2: they pinch without demo. Sitting 3: when it sags, you only ask the

locked opening. Sitting 4: stand-up challenge or clay-then-draw. Fade praise from “pretty pot” to “you thickened after it leaned.”

When to stop talking. After the opening. While fingers work. When they are mid-redesign. Do not narrate worry (“it’s going to fall!”) into the clay. Ask, wait, hint.

Age-band moves

- **5–7:** Playdough or very soft air-dry; short sits (match attention); pinch pots; stamp texture with leaf/fork/LEGO; oral redesign talk; mash-and-restart allowed without shame; SPACE-01 big/small same page as dry cousin day; adult may scribe “it fell / I made wider.” Damp wipe. No kiln talk as pressure.
- **8–10:** Firmer air-dry ok; coil snake build; stand-up challenge with redesign; clay then draw; SPACE-02 overlap, SPACE-04 near/far soft as supporting drawing days; optional toothpick/skewer **adult-only** after struggle for a temporary support experiment — not craft-knife armatures. Still refuse adult re-smooth as default. If pinch walls never get a chance before adult fix, stay on 5–7 clay longer even at age nine.

This-week plan. Focus: pinch + redesign reflex. Three to five Hours. One SPACE soft day if wet clay is too much. One OUT cousin: sculpture garden walk soft or nature texture collect for stamping. Friday: done-enough — child’s walls/coils; at least one redesign.

Safety. AP air-dry or playdough. Damp wipe dust. Wash hands. No kiln default. No craft knives. Adult present for small tools. Food off table. Choke check on add-ons. Read labels. “Non-toxic” ≠ edible.

Practice that actually builds learning

Clay try-its (in-home)

CLAY-01 Pinch Pot Soft — above; open the week.

CLAY-02 Coil Snake Build — band both; 20–35 min.

Materials: clay; board.

Mess / safety: medium; wash hands.

The fun: snakes that spiral into bowls or stack into towers.

The skill: roll coils; stack or spiral; compare soft vs firm coil. Ask what happens when a coil is too skinny for height.

CLAY-03 Stamp Texture Clay — band 5–7 (both enjoy); 15–25 min.

Materials: clay slab; found stamps (leaf, fork, LEGO, lace).

Mess / safety: medium; wash tools; non-toxic leaves if used.

The fun: impressions like secret fossils.

The skill: press textures; look at impressions before naming *texture*. Cousin to leaf print from Chapter 5 — now in soft slab.

CLAY-04 Stand-Up Challenge Soft — band 8–10; 25–40 min.

Materials: clay; optional toothpick/skewer with adult.

Mess / safety: medium; sharp tools adult-only.

The fun: engineering a creature or tower that stands — and redesigning when it does not.

The skill: make something that stands; if it falls, redesign — wider feet, shorter height, coil buttress. Wire/toothpick tip only after struggle (Fernando-Smith process grain). Do not shame the fall.

CLAY-05 Clay Then Draw — band both; 25–40 min.

Materials: clay form; paper; pencil/crayon.

Mess / safety: medium then low.

The fun: your sculpture becomes a still life you made.

The skill: make form; draw what you see from one angle. Look–make–look. No generator still-life stand-in.

SPACE soft try-its (support — not a perspective course)

SPACE-01 Big/Small Same Page — band 5–7; 15–25 min.

Materials: paper; crayons.

Mess / safety: low.

The fun: same creature huge and tiny on one page.

The skill: talk size. Bridges to clay: big base vs tiny head.

SPACE-02 Overlap Soft — band 8–10; 20–30 min.

Materials: two objects; paper; pencil.

Mess / safety: low.

The fun: one apple hiding part of a mug — like real clutter.

The skill: look at real overlap first; draw so one hides part of the other. Name lightly after.

SPACE-03 Baseline Walk — band both; 15–25 min.

Materials: paper; outdoor or window scene.

Mess / safety: low outdoors with adult.

The fun: noticing where things “sit.”

The skill: ground line in child’s schema without shaming. Schema baseline is a map stage, not a defect.

SPACE-04 Near/Far Soft — band 8–10; 20–30 min.

Materials: view out window; paper.

Mess / safety: low.

The fun: experiments — does far look smaller on your page?

The skill: size/placement tries; light naming after. Not vanishing-point class.

Out-of-home try-its

OUT-02 Sculpture garden / sculpture walk soft. With adult: choose one sculpture; walk around it; notice base and balance. Ask what might tip if clay were soft. No touching artworks unless venue allows. Sketch optional.

OUT-03 Nature line & texture. Collect safe textures for CLAY-03 stamping (bark rubbing on paper is dry cousin; leaf for stamp). Courtesy; wash hands.

Architecture edge walk (OUT-06). Notice how buildings stand — wide bases, repeated supports. Quick talk: “What keeps it from falling?” Then home stand-up challenge.

Talk box

Opening (locked): “What did the clay do — and what will you try next if it falls?”

Follow-ups:

1. Look: “What do you *notice* about the wall / the coil / the base?”
2. Make: “What did your fingers (or the stamp) do?”
3. Evidence: “What do you see that makes you say it leaned?”
4. Process: “How did you change it after it fell?” / “Whose hands made these walls?”
5. Revise: “Try another base?” / “Mash and restart — still your work.” / “Draw it from this angle before we put it away.”

How to wait. Slow three. Look at the clay, not the child, if silence is hard. Mid-pinch silence is work. After a fall, wait before rescuing — let them feel the re-design question.

Stuck silence usually means: shame after a fall; you always fixed pots; question was “make it nice”; wait-time zero; they think kiln-only is real; they point at a generated 3-D render as their sculpture. Point at the lean. Ask what’s next. Wait. Do not fill with “pretty.”

Blocked / mixed / incorrect example

Blocked. Adult re-smooth as default. Kiln as required. Craft-knife armatures as default. Shame language for collapse. Generated sculpture JPEG in the child folder.

Mixed — when to use which. Pinch to begin authorship. Coil when rolling helps regulation or height goals. Stamp when looking needs a quiet press day. Stand-up when 8–10 are ready to engineer. Clay-then-draw to close looking. SPACE soft when wet clay is too much or drawing needs size/overlap practice.

Incorrect example (illustration). Child’s coil tower falls. Parent says “I’ll make you a good one,” builds a perfect dinosaur, photos it for the album as the child’s clay day. Diagnosis: adult mark; shame-adjacent; no redesign practice. Repair: mash together; locked opening; child’s next try; album shows child’s walls — adult demo lump labelled demo if kept.

Incorrect kiln pressure. Parent delays all clay “until we get kiln access.” Diagnosis: false gate. Repair: AP playdough this week. Air-dry on a shelf. Process now.

Sample week C — Soft clay (menu)

- **Monday:** CLAY-01 pinch pot; locked opening; exit “next time I’ll...”
- **Tuesday:** CLAY-03 stamp texture; look at impressions.
- **Wednesday:** SPACE-01 or SPACE-03 dry day *or* short pinch repair practice.
- **Thursday:** CLAY-02 coils *or* OUT sculpture walk.
- **Friday:** CLAY-04 stand-up (8–10) *or* CLAY-05 clay then draw (both). Done-enough: child’s form + one redesign noted.

Extended teaching notes for soft 3-D week

Why gravity is a teacher. Paint can hide a weak mix under another swirl. Paper can be glued flat. Clay announces imbalance. That announcement is kind if you let it be information. Parents who rush to prevent every lean steal the announcement. Parents who narrate doom (“it’s going to fall!”) add fear. Parents who ask the locked opening turn gravity into curriculum.

Pinch mechanics without a lecture. Ball in nondominant hand (or both). Thumbs open a mouth in the center. Fingers support the outside. Rotate a little; pinch a little. Stop and look. Thin rim? Add a coil snake as a lip — child’s choice. You may show rotation on a demo lump once. Then silence.

Coil mechanics without a lecture. Roll from the middle outward. Soft coil = thicker, shorter stacks. Firm coil = stronger walls if not cracked. Score-and-slip is studio language you can skip; at this age, gentle pressing together and a dab of water on air-dry (per label) is enough. If coils spring apart, thicker press, shorter tower.

Stand-up challenge framing. “Make something that stands for ten slow counts.” If it falls at six, celebrate the data. Redesign. Try again. Ten counts is a game, not a test score. Widening the feet beats secretly inserting a hidden adult wire before the child has tried.

Clay-then-draw framing. Place the form at eye level. Child sits in one spot. “Draw the side you see — even if you know the other side has a tail.” Knowing vs seeing is the looking lesson. Blind contour soft from Chapter 3 can visit for one minute if they rush symbols instead of edges.

Playdough vs air-dry honesty. Playdough: reusable, great for redesign reps, may not keep a fridge trophy. Air-dry: keeps a form, can crack, needs shelf space. Both are legitimate Art materials in this book. Choosing playdough is not “less than.” Choosing air-dry is not “more artistic.” Process is the effect on the child’s looking and trying.

Sample dialogue after a fall (illustration).

Parent: “What did the clay do — and what will you try next if it falls?”

Child: “It tipped. The head was heavy.”

Parent: “What could you try?”

Child: “Smaller head. Or fatter feet.”

Parent: “Your choice. I’ll watch.”

(Child fattens feet. It stands longer.)

Parent: “What do you see that makes you say it’s steadier?”

Child: “The bottom is wider than the top now.”

When siblings compare. “Whose fingerprints?” beats “whose is prettier?” If one child copies another’s dinosaur, allow homage then ask for one change that is theirs — taller legs, stamped skin, different base.

Outdoor clay? Soft clay outdoors needs a tray and wind plan; often indoor is kinder. Sculpture walks feed eyes; hands work at home.

Link to records. Optional process photo of the lean and the redesign side by side in the dated folder. Label Art. Child’s forms. Not a percentile. Not NAEP.

Link to assessment later. Whose-mark and done-enough from Chapter 8 will ask for child’s walls across weeks. Start collecting those walls now. Adult demos stay labelled.

Emotional weather. Some children smash when frustrated. Offer: “Intentional mash is allowed. Angry smash at people is not.” Redirect energy into stamp slab. Soften clay. Shorten sit. You are teaching regulation beside redesign — calmly, without shame.

What you are not teaching this week. Wheel throwing. Glaze chemistry. Kiln schedules. Lost-wax casting. Craft-knife foam carving as sculpture credit. Formal two-point perspective. Those can wait for older years and other books. Soft 3-D and soft space are enough — and rich.

Vendor pages and sample kits. If a kit includes a step sheet that ends in one identical product, use the clay — skip forcing the sample match. Look at the sample once; put it away; child’s form. Fit, not rank, belongs in resources later; authorship belongs at the table now.

Five-minute emergency Hour. Only ten minutes free? Soften clay, pinch once, ask locked opening, wipe, done. Micro-doses count when they keep the redesign question alive.

For the student

Clay is soft on purpose. It bends. It leans. Sometimes it falls. When it falls, you get to try something next — thicker, shorter, wider, or a whole new idea. That next

try is part of art.

Tiny example. You pinch a ball. The side gets thin. It leans. You push more clay into the thin place — or squash it and roll a coil snake for a new bowl. You did not “ruin” it. The clay told you the wall was thin. You answered.

Try 1 — Pinch and notice. Make a pinch pot. Stop once and look at the walls. Point to a thick place and a thin place. Tell what the clay might do next.

Try 2 — If it falls. Build something that stands (even a tiny person). If it falls, say the opening question to yourself: what did the clay do, and what will you try next? Do that next thing. Optional: draw your form from one side when you like it.

Explain it back. Why might a grown-up want to fix your pot for you? What can you say? Practice: “I want to try next.” Whose walls should be in your Art folder?

Challenge. Keep a “failed” tall coil as a pancake and stamp textures into it. Turn the fall into a new piece. Or: big and small versions of the same animal on paper after you make one in clay.

You are allowed to mash and restart. You are allowed to stop while you still want one more pinch. A computer picture of a perfect statue is not your clay. Your fingerprints in the wall count.

More student tries. Roll three coils — skinny, medium, fat — and stack them. Which stack stands longer? Stamp a leaf into a slab and look before you name it. Put your finished pinch on the table and draw only what you see from your chair — even if the far side is “missing” on the page.

If you feel mad when it falls. Mad is allowed. Hitting people is not. You can mash the clay on purpose and start again. You can take a breath and fatten the feet. You can ask for a tip after you have tried — the tip happens on a demo lump, then your clay comes back to you.

Explain one more time. What is the first job — make it look like the sample, or notice what the clay did? What question should a grown-up ask when your tower leans?

If it isn't clicking

Diagnostic 1 — Adult polish reflex.

You remake their pot “nice” before they try again.

Next move: pockets. Locked opening. Demo lump only if they ask after struggle.

Fresh ball for them. Label any adult form DEMO. Album honesty: child's walls.

Diagnostic 2 — Long sit meltdown.

Tears, smash-anger, or shutdown mid-coil.

Next move: shorten the make. Playdough softer. Stamp texture day. Or SPACE dry day. Mess/dust preview. Damp wipe. End with talk box even if the form is mashed on purpose — intentional mash is still a choice.

Diagnostic 3 — Dust, dry air-dry frustration, or kiln myth.

Cracking, dusty table, or “this isn't real without firing.”

Next move: damp wipe; tiny water for air-dry as label allows; softer clay; name playdough as real for this book. Kiln is not the gate. Process is.

Extra — Shame after fall. Reframe: “Fallen told us the base was small. That's useful.” Then redesign. Never “you ruined it.”

Extra — Generated 3-D as theirs. Separate: looking at sculpture photos is fine; filing a render as their clay is not.

When to slow down. Pinch + stamp + oral redesign until falls are interesting, not catastrophic.

When to go ahead. Coils, stand-up, clay-then-draw, overlap/near-far soft.

When to get a human tutor. Pain in hands, extreme sensory refusal after soft options, or motor concerns — OT/teacher for tool ideas while keeping child's authorship. No shame. Looking can continue with SPACE soft and sculpture walks.

Correct without crushing: “Thin isn't naughty — it's a clue. What's your next try?”

Materials ritual for clay week

Before the first open tub:

1. Check AP / ASTM D-4236 on the package (SAFE-01 grain).
2. Cover or board ready; damp cloth ready; food off table.

3. Mess honesty: “Clay will stick to fingers. We wipe at the end.”
4. Agree where drying pieces live if air-dry (high shelf, labelled).
5. Agree that falls are information — say it out loud once so shame has less room.

These steps take three minutes and save thirty minutes of cleanup fight and polish panic.

Redesign menu children can choose from

When something leans or falls, offer choices — not commands:

- Thicken the wall or foot.
- Shorten the tall part.
- Add a coil buttress.
- Separate into two smaller standing forms.
- Mash flat and stamp textures (new piece from old attempt).
- Clay-then-draw the fallen view, then rebuild tomorrow.

Choice keeps authorship. Command (“do it my way”) returns adult polish through the side door.

SPACE soft — one clear week slot

If wet clay every day is too much sensory load, schedule one SPACE soft Hour midweek:

- Monday pinch, Tuesday coil, Wednesday big/small or baseline walk, Thursday stamp or stand-up, Friday clay-then-draw.

Wednesday’s dry looking still belongs to this chapter because size, sit, overlap, and near/far support the same eyes that judge a clay base. You are not abandoning 3-D; you are letting eyes rest while skills transfer.

What “done enough” is not

Done enough is not a kiln-fired set. Not a store-matched dinosaur. Not a generated render. Not a parent-smoothed bowl with the child’s name taped on. Not a percentile. Not a birthday promotion to “real sculpture.” Done enough is child’s walls, one redesign, soft materials, talk that points at clay.

Parent fatigue line

If you are tired, soft clay still works in ten minutes. You do not need to perform enthusiasm. You need to ask one real question and wait. The clay supplies the drama. You supply the pause.

Bridge to Chapter 7

Process sentences (“I fattened the feet after it leaned”) are already talk-about-art. Chapter 7 will grow tell-me and because-I-see. You can plant one process crumb now without turning clay week into a writing class. Adult scribes at 5–7. Child writes a short line at 8–10 if ready.

Tools, including AI

Physical tools. AP air-dry clay or playdough; board; damp wipe cloths; found stamps; optional adult-supervised toothpick after struggle; paper and pencil for clay-then-draw; table cover as needed. No kiln required. No craft knives. Seal-check packages. Wash tools. Store clay per label so it stays soft for next Tuesday.

Optional AI (parent account only). After the child has pinched or redesigned, you may ask a tool to explain *to you* wider-base tips, or to suggest kitchen still-life angles for clay-then-draw — then the child works from the real form. SCRIPT questions for you are fine. You may not generate a sculpture and call it theirs, unsupervised during making, or as “kids clay style” stand-in. No upload of child’s face. Parent account; parent in the room; unaided first on the clay. Point back to the Art Hour AI box. Bastani remains OFF-AGE for art hour.

Skip list. You do not need a wheel, a kiln, or solvent sealers for this chapter. Library picture books of sculpture can follow a make. Museum or garden walks feed looking. Home soft clay does the authorship.

What “done enough” looks like

- ☐ Child’s own pinch walls and/or coils appear in the week’s work (not adult-smoothed stand-ins).
- ☐ At least one redesign after a fall, lean, or soft wall — talked or visible.
- ☐ Air-dry or playdough AP default used; no kiln required; no craft knives.

- ☐ Talk box used locked opening; child named a next try or pointed at what clay did.
- ☐ Optional: clay-then-draw once, or one SPACE soft try supporting size/overlap/baseline/near-far.
- ☐ Damp wipe / wash hands / food off table observed.
- ☐ Exit crumb: “next time I’ll...”, process photo of *their* form, or dated drawing from clay.
- ☐ Folder shows child’s fingerprints in clay work — not only adult demos or generated statues.

Place by skill, not birthday. A five-year-old with proud thick walls is done enough. A ten-year-old who still freezes at a lean may need more pinch-and-ask before stand-up challenge. Work lives under **Art**. Never Little Thinkers Art I. Never a brand as the transcript line.

Life of the habit (no ninth chapter). Next Tuesday, reopen soft clay and try last week’s “next time I’ll...” sentence. Mix a stamped slab into a coil base. Draw yesterday’s dry air-dry form from a new angle. Stop while wanting one more pinch. Look before name; make before polish — soft 3-D version.

If energy is low, stamp textures for fifteen minutes and ask the locked opening about one impression. Dose honesty includes rest. Gravity will still be there tomorrow. So will redesign.

Practice notes that keep clay honest

Demo lump rule. Any adult touch that models a move happens on a lump labelled DEMO or on your own ball. Their ball stays theirs. If you already smoothed their wall, own it aloud and offer a fresh ball.

Fall script. When clay falls: (1) pause, (2) locked opening, (3) wait, (4) child chooses repair or mash-restart, (5) tip only if asked after struggle. Skip straight to adult rebuild and you taught polish, not sculpture thinking.

Dust and drying. Air-dry pieces need a safe shelf away from pets and toddlers. Pieces break — redesign or clay-then-draw the broken view. Playdough returns to the tub. Both count as Art Hour materials.

SPACE days are not skipping. A window near/far sit after a hard clay day keeps looking alive without more dust. Big/small on paper after a pinch pot helps language for base vs rim. Soft space is support, not a downgrade.

Sibling tables. Separate boards. Whose-mark check: “Show me your fingerprints.” Older demo once on demo lump — then both work their own.

Connecting chapters. Stamp texture rhymes with Chapter 5 leaf print. Clay-then-draw rhymes with Chapter 3 edge following. Redesign talk rhymes with Chapter 7 process sentences. You are building one ladder — WisdomForge Art Hour — not isolated crafts.

Incorrect overnight fix. Parent rebuilds the tower after bedtime for a “better” photo. Refuse the pattern. Photo the lean; photo the redesign; honesty over polish.

Sculpture walk courtesy. Look with eyes; follow venue rules; sketch without blocking paths. Home clay is where hands learn; gardens are where eyes collect balance ideas.

When “I can’t sculpt” appears. Often looking (or fear) ahead of hands. Shorten: one pinch, one notice, one next-try sentence. Fat coils before tall towers. Skill not birthday.

Warm-up for stand-up day. Before CLAY-04, build the shortest standing blob that still “counts” as standing. Success at small height teaches base. Then grow height on purpose until lean teaches again.

More parent clarity on soft space

SPACE soft is not “the perspective chapter.” You will not teach horizon lines as law at age six. You will notice: this tree drawn huge, that one tiny; this cup in front of that box; a line where grass seems to sit; far windows smaller on the page after a try. Name lightly after experiments. Schema baselines (everything sitting on one ground line) are common — map, not defect. Teach through with looking, not with ridicule.

Overlap soft: put mug in front of apple on the table. Look. Where does one hide the other? Draw. Struggle before you sketch it for them on their page.

Near/far: window sit. What is close enough to touch the glass with a finger-guess? What is far? Try sizes. Laugh at experiments. Keep looking.

Student challenge card (optional)

Build a coil bowl. Let it lean. Redesign. Then draw the bowl from the side where the lean still shows a little. Tell a grown-up what the clay did and what you tried next. That story is your exit crumb — better than “pretty.”

Done-enough revisited in plain words

You are done enough for this chapter’s focus when the child’s hands own the walls, a fall became a next try at least once, materials stayed soft and AP, and the talk pointed at clay — not only at whether it matched a sample dinosaur. Everything else is bonus depth for later Tuesdays.

Revisit soft clay next week even if you move toward talking-about-art chapters. A ten-minute pinch keeps the redesign muscle warm. Mix last week’s stamp idea into a new coil. Stop while wanting one more press of the thumb into the wall.

Tomorrow’s setup can be one AP lump, one board, one wipe cloth. Ask what the clay did. Ask what they’ll try if it falls. Wait. Return the clay to their hands. That is Chapter 6 in miniature — and it is enough to begin.

Carry one sentence into next week: “Fallen is information.” Tape it near the clay bin if it helps you. When polish whispers that you should fix their pot before dinner guests see it, read the sentence. Ask the locked opening instead. Return the clay to their hands.

Look before name. Make before polish. Soft clay. Soft space. Redesign when it falls. That is enough for a life of ordinary Art Hours — mug on the table, lump on the board, child thinking with their thumbs.

A closing picture for the parent who feels rusty: you sit beside a board. The child pinches. The wall leans. You feel the old urge to fix. You put your hands under your legs. You ask what the clay did and what they will try next. They fatten the foot. It stands a little longer. You both see it. That shared seeing is the Art Hour. No kiln. No knife. No sample dinosaur required. Soft clay, real looking, child’s next try.

Tomorrow: one AP lump, one board, one question, one wait. If it falls, redesign. If it stands, notice why. Stop while wanting one more pinch. Look before name; make before polish. The thumbs already know how to learn — if we let the clay speak first.

Keep the redesign muscle warm even when the calendar moves on. A single Tuesday pinch between talking-about-art weeks prevents clay from becoming a forgotten tub in the closet. Mix last week's stamp idea into a new coil base. Draw a dry air-dry form from a new chair angle. Ask the locked opening again — it still works on week four.

When in doubt, soften the clay, ask what it did, and wait. Return the lump to the child. Gravity will teach the rest if you do not interrupt with polish. That is the whole soft 3-D promise of this chapter, scaled to a kitchen board and an ordinary afternoon.

Put the tub on the table tonight. Tomorrow, open it together. Pinch. Notice. Ask. Wait. If it falls, try next. Your child's walls — fingerprints and all — are the curriculum. Leave them on the board long enough for looking to happen. Soft clay. Soft space. Real Art Hour.

Look before name. Make before polish. What did the clay do — and what will you try next if it falls? Ask it. Mean it. Wait for the answer in their hands.

That question is the chapter. The clay is the teacher. You are the adult who waits.

Begin again tomorrow with one lump and one honest wait.

Chapter 7 — Talking and writing about art



Figure 9: A sticky-note caption on a child's drawing beside a dated sketchbook margin — still-life of page and note, no people, no logos.

Why this matters

A child can look at a mug, mix two puddles, tear a collage, and still leave the hour with only your praise in their ear. “Pretty.” “Nice job.” “I love it.” The page sits finished. Tomorrow the talk is thinner. The noticing never became theirs.

Talking about art at 5–10 is one authentic question, a wait, and a finger on the work. Writing about art at 5–10 is a ladder: three words, then a because-I-see caption, then a process sentence, then a title chosen after looking — not assigned before the first mark. It is not an MFA critique. It is not a vocabulary quiz. It is not a blank artist-statement page meant to shame a six-year-old who still needs you to scribe.

This is worth the struggle because talk is how looking becomes shared language, and a caption is how looking lasts past the fridge. A fluent summary from a grown-up, or from a machine, is performance. A sentence that could only come from *this* yellow drip or *this* torn edge is art talk.

Preference is allowed. Joy is allowed. “Pretty” alone is not the craft. Preference reports the speaker. Description reports the work. When the only sentence at the table is preference, the child learns that art talk is a mood check, not a look.

Classroom wait-time research started in elementary *science* lessons. Teachers often waited about a second after a question. When they waited longer — a few seconds — the talk changed. A later digest called the pause *think-time*. Use the pause at your table as craft, not as a kitchen experiment you are failing if Wednesday is noisy. This is a useful study shape, not a promise that every home will see the same result.

Materials alone rarely make discussion. A finished collage is not yet a conversation. You still pose, wait, and point. The child answers you, not a tab.

The locked question for this chapter is the whole craft in one line:

“Tell me about your artwork — not whether it is pretty.”

If they can answer that, with a finger or a caption, the week did its job.

A parent who felt rusty on art often defaults to the praise they received as a child: product compliments. That default is kind. It is incomplete. Specific noticing teaches the child what looking *is*. Process questions teach them that the hand’s try matters. Caption crumbs teach them that their words belong under their marks.

None of that requires you to be a studio artist. It requires you to put the page on the table, ask one good question, and wait.

Chapters 1–6 put lookables on the table: notice before name, look at objects and pictures, child’s mark and line, color mix light, collage and print, soft clay. This chapter teaches the mouth and the pencil to stay honest to those looks. Sister English manuals care about oral before heavy print; borrow the kindness, not the phonics scope. Sister thinking manuals care about wait and change-your-mind; borrow the craft, not a playground debate without a page on the table. Then teach art talk. One authentic question beats ten quiz words. One caption that needs the page beats a fluent statement that never looked.

For the parent: understand it yourself

Here is the everyday picture.

The painting is wet. You say, “That’s so pretty!” The child smiles. You ask, “What is it?” They shrug or invent a title to please you. You fill the silence with more praise. On Friday you ask them to tell you about the work. They say “pretty” back at you. The yellow dots they made never got a sentence.

Here is the precise picture.

The make is done. The page is on the table. You ask them to tell you about the artwork — not whether it is pretty. You wait a slow three. They point at a thick blue edge. You uptake: “You said the blue line is thick where the brush slowed.” For a five-year-old you scribe three words. For an eight-year-old they write one because-I-see caption. The praise can fade. The notice stays.

An authentic question is one you do not already have the exact sentence for. “What is the element of art?” with the vocabulary card facing you is recitation. “Tell me about your artwork — not whether it is pretty” is closer to authentic. You may still know more than they do. You have not prespecified their sentence.

Oral comes before heavy print. Spelling help is allowed. You may scribe. Art looking does not wait for fluent writing. Place by skill, not birthday.

“How did you do that?” turns the child into the teacher for one passage. “Look at all the yellow dots you made” is description as care — the yellow-dots grain from early-childhood process talk. “How do you feel about it?” before your gush lets

them own the first report. At 8–10, a soft “already good — how might it be even better?” can invite redesign without shame. None of these is a gallery opening speech.

Studio Habits of Mind name Observe and Reflect among eight habits drawn from high-school studio research. Borrow the light language. Do not claim a kitchen RCT for kindergartners. Visual Thinking Strategies and See–Think–Wonder put observation and evidence before adult interpretation dumps — useful pause craft, not a franchise you must buy.

Wrong answers you should be able to hear

1. Empty pretty loop.

“Pretty... beautiful... I love it...” and nothing that points.

What it usually means: preference became the only talk.

What you say: point with words. “I notice the thick blue where the brush slowed.” Then the locked opening.

2. Rapid-fire quiz.

“What color is that? What shape? What is the vocabulary word?” No wait. No finger on the page.

What it usually means: talk time became a test.

What you say: put the quiz card away. Ask the locked opening. Count three.

3. Overwriting the child’s story.

They start a caption; you erase and write the “right” artist title or a textbook aim instead.

What it usually means: adult voice replaced child looking.

What you say: stop. Keep their words. Add a second line for your note if you must — labelled as yours.

4. Title assigned before making.

“Today we will make a Happy Tree.” The title lands before the first mark.

What it usually means: name-first colonized the make.

What you say: look and make first. Title after the talk. WRITE-04.

5. Generated artist statement as the only draft.

A fluent machine paragraph sits under a blank or thin page as “what I meant.”

What it usually means: performance replaced looking.

What you say: refuse it. Real two-minute look. Child's words. Generated statement is not WRITE bank. Point back to the Art Hour AI box.

Five-minute parent warm-up

Find the child's last page — or the last sentence you scribed. Cover any adult praise sticky.

Ask yourself: what follow-up will I use tomorrow? Practice uptake aloud: "You said ; **I see** on the page."

Practice the locked opening to the empty chair. Count three. Do not answer.

If you like a SCRIPT for later, write four lines for yourself now — questions, not their artist statement. The child never chats a tool. You hold the account. Point back to the Art Hour AI box when you want the full allow-and-ban list.

How to teach it this week

The Art Hour shape stays. Talk and write are the talk box and the crumb, not a second subject named Little Thinkers Art Writing.

Session shape (~20–40 minutes)

1. **Look / notice (3–8 min).** Yesterday's page, a postcard with caption covered, or today's object — mug, leaf, window.
2. **Short make (8–18 min).** Child holds the tool. Demo on demo paper only if needed.
3. **Talk box (3–8 min).** Locked opening. Wait. Point with words. One follow-up.
4. **Name lightly (2–5 min).** Optional. A word that fits what was seen — after evidence.
5. **Exit crumb (2–5 min).** Three-word caption, process sentence, or title after look. Adult may scribe at 5–7.

Twenty-minute day: uncover yesterday's page, locked question, one sticky caption. That is a full hour.

Exact wording you can say

Opening, locked:

“Tell me about your artwork — not whether it is pretty.”

Then wait.

If they only say pretty: “Pretty is your feeling. Point at one place on the page. What do you *see* there?”

If they freeze: “Point first. Then give the point a word.”

If they shrug at “What is it?”: drop that question. Use the locked opening. “What is it?” often hunts a label you already hold.

If they retell your demo: “Put your finger on *your* mark. What did *your* hand try?”

If siblings talk over each other: “I heard you say ; *the page shows* . Do you agree — point.”

When you fade help, stop supplying the description. When you stop talking, look at the page.

Age-band moves

Ages 5–7. Talk stays concrete: notice, yellow dots, how-did-you-do-that, feelings first. Writing is three words on a sticky, dictated or drawn. Process sentence oral; you scribe. Title after look — one or two words. Display choice: fridge, folder, or put away — with one reason if they can. Wait practice. Process over likeness.

Ages 8–10. Add because-I-see captions. Add written process sentences. Soft already-good / even-better on a work-in-progress — never as shame. Refuse generated caption as a meta sit once. Still refuse MFA critique language. If looking habits are weak, stay on oral tell-me and yellow-dots longer. If handwriting is weak, they speak; you write. Skill, not birthday.

First try-it for the student

Ask the locked question once over today’s make. Sit on your hands for three to five seconds. Accept the first real try. Follow up once: “What do you see that

makes you say that?” That is TALK-01 nested with evidence talk. Then WRITE-01 Three-Word Caption or WRITE-03 Process Sentence.

This week, honestly

Focus move: tell-me (not pretty-only); one caption or process crumb in the child’s words.

- **Monday:** TALK-01 Tell Me About It on a fresh make + TALK-02 Point With Words.
- **Tuesday:** TALK-03 Yellow Dots Notice on a painting or collage; WRITE-01 Three-Word Caption (5–7) or WRITE-02 Because I See (8–10).
- **Wednesday:** TALK-04 How Did You Do That on one interesting passage; optional TALK-06 Feelings First before your comment.
- **Thursday:** WRITE-03 Process Sentence; WRITE-04 Title After Look — title chosen *after* talk.
- **Friday:** Sticky crumb. One diagnostic: empty pretty loop or generated caption offer. Optional WRITE-05 Refuse Generated Caption (meta). Optional TALK-05 Already Good / Even Better Soft (8–10).
- **Once this week, out of the home:** LOOK-07 Fridge Gallery Tour as process talk (in-home display) *or* OUT-04 Library Picture-Book Look First — pictures before text; one oral tell-me about a chosen page. Or OUT-01 Museum One Work Sit — tell about the work, not whether it is pretty.

Siblings: each child needs their own page and their own talk turn. The older child is not only the tutor. Separate display choices.

Three to five hours. One outing or fridge gallery. Friday a crumb. Not a writing program. Not a gallery opening. Not a detector-graded statement week.

Practice that actually builds learning

Named try-its carry time, materials, mess/safety, the fun, and the skill. Talk try-its and write try-its share a table. The library, museum, and fridge gallery are practice. They do not replace the tell-me move.

Composite homes are illustrations, not reported families.

Talk box (use every talk/write hour)

Opening (locked): “Tell me about your artwork — not whether it is pretty.”

Follow-ups:

1. What do you *see* / *notice*?
2. What did your hand / the material do?
3. What do you see that makes you say that?
4. How did you do that? / Whose mark is that passage?
5. You may change your mind — keep the drip; what could it become? / How do you feel about it before I talk?

How to wait: After you ask, a slow three is a convention, not a sacrament (classroom-origin wait / think-time — pause craft for Art Hour, not an art RCT). After they stop, wait again. If they are mid-look or mid-sentence, do not cut them off. Look at the page or the materials, not at the child, if the silence is hard.

Stuck silence usually means: the question was vague (“What is it?”); wait-time was zero; they are hunting a vocabulary word because you asked name-first; they are waiting for you to finish the dog; they fear “draw it nice”; every hour has been coloring-book lines; they point at a phone image as “my art”; they shrug because preference was the only talk they ever heard; the caption was uncovered before looking. Pose again. Point back at the page. Do not fill the silence with “pretty.”

Incorrect example to diagnose (illustration)

A parent stands over a tempera page and says only, “So pretty! What is it supposed to be?” The child freezes, then invents “a butterfly” to end the question. A phone offers “Write an artist statement,” and a fluent paragraph appears. The parent files the paragraph under the child’s name.

What went wrong: pretty-only talk; “what is it” as quiz; generated statement as WRITE.

Rescue order: ask the locked opening; wait; hint (“Point at one place”); short demo of *your* noticing on demo paper (“I notice thick blue here”); return the talk to the child. Trash the generated statement. Scribe three of *their* words.

In-home try-its**TALK-01 Tell Me About It**

- **Band:** both
- **Time:** 5–10 min
- **Materials:** Child’s fresh work
- **Mess / safety:** Low
- **The fun:** Being asked like an artist, not like a quiz contestant.
- **The skill:** Replace “What is it?” with “Tell me about your artwork.” Wait.

TALK-02 Point With Words

- **Band:** both
- **Time:** 5–10 min
- **Materials:** Work or reproduction
- **Mess / safety:** Low
- **The fun:** Adult and child both point with language at the same spot.
- **The skill:** Specific noticing beats “pretty.” Describe by pointing with words.

TALK-03 Yellow Dots Notice

- **Band:** both
- **Time:** 5–10 min
- **Materials:** Child’s painting or drawing

- **Mess / safety:** Low
- **The fun:** Hearing the adult name something they actually made.
- **The skill:** “Look at all the ____ you made.” Description as care.

TALK-04 How Did You Do That

- **Band:** both
- **Time:** 5–10 min
- **Materials:** Work with an interesting passage
- **Mess / safety:** Low
- **The fun:** Teaching the grown-up.
- **The skill:** Process question. Child teaches the adult the move.

TALK-05 Already Good / Even Better Soft

- **Band:** 8–10
- **Time:** 5–10 min
- **Materials:** Work-in-progress
- **Mess / safety:** Low
- **The fun:** Permission to revise without “wrong.”
- **The skill:** “Already good — how might it be even better?” Optional; never shame.

TALK-06 Feelings First

- **Band:** both
- **Time:** 5–10 min
- **Materials:** Finished piece
- **Mess / safety:** Low
- **The fun:** First report belongs to them.
- **The skill:** “How do you feel about it?” before adult gush. Then specific comment.

WRITE-01 Three-Word Caption

- **Band:** 5–7 (both if needed)
- **Time:** 10–15 min
- **Materials:** Work; sticky note; adult scribes if needed
- **Mess / safety:** Low
- **The fun:** Three words feel finishable.
- **The skill:** Child picks three words. Adult may scribe. Child’s words.

WRITE-02 Because I See Caption

- **Band:** 8–10
- **Time:** 10–20 min
- **Materials:** Work or museum postcard; paper
- **Mess / safety:** Low

- **The fun:** A real sentence that needs the page.
- **The skill:** Caption = claim + because + what I see. Evidence soft.

WRITE-03 Process Sentence

- **Band:** both
- **Time:** 10–15 min
- **Materials:** Work; paper
- **Mess / safety:** Low
- **The fun:** Retelling the make like a story.
- **The skill:** “First I , *then I* .” Exit crumb for making.

WRITE-04 Title After Look

- **Band:** both
- **Time:** 10–15 min
- **Materials:** Finished work
- **Mess / safety:** Low
- **The fun:** Naming after knowing.
- **The skill:** Title chosen after looking talk — not assigned before making.

WRITE-05 Refuse Generated Caption

- **Band:** both (meta; 8–10 can spot FAKE)

- **Time:** 5–10 min meta
- **Materials:** Phone / AI caption offer (adult-held)
- **Mess / safety:** —
- **The fun:** Honesty as a clear rule.
- **The skill:** If a tool writes the artist’s statement, trash it. Child’s sentence or dictation only.

LOOK-07 Fridge Gallery Tour (display talk)

- **Band:** both
- **Time:** 10–15 min
- **Materials:** Fridge or wall display of child’s work
- **Mess / safety:** Low
- **The fun:** Child as curator.
- **The skill:** Child picks one piece; tells about process, not “is it pretty?”
Adult: specific noticing.

Out-of-home try-its

OUT-04 Library Picture-Book Look First

- **Band:** both
- **Time:** 20–30 min
- **Materials:** Picture book; cover words until after looking
- **Mess / safety:** Low

- **The fun:** Pictures first — like a secret.
- **The skill:** Discuss pictures before reading text. Then one tell-me about a chosen page.

OUT-01 Museum One Work Sit (talk portable)

- **Band:** both
- **Time:** 20–40 min at site
- **Materials:** Museum or gallery; sketchbook optional
- **Mess / safety:** Follow venue rules; adult present
- **The fun:** One work feels like enough.
- **The skill:** Silent look → notice talk → optional tiny sketch. Tell about the work, not pretty. Refuse scavenger mania.

OUT-07 Gallery Child Choice

- **Band:** both
- **Time:** 20–40 min
- **Materials:** Museum; child's pick
- **Mess / safety:** Venue rules
- **The fun:** Ownership of looking.
- **The skill:** Child chooses the work. Adult follows. Talk box on *their* choice.

Blocked vs mixed

Blocked (new move): One talk shape for three days — tell-me only, or yellow-dots only — until the silence softens.

Mixed (when warm): Talk + write same hour — tell-me, then three-word sticky. Or how-did-you-do-that, then process sentence.

Do not run all eleven cards in one week. Banks are a menu.

Sample week (illustration)

Kitchen collage week: Monday tear and arrange; Tuesday talk box with locked opening and yellow-dots; Wednesday three-word caption scribed; Thursday process sentence; Friday title after look; Saturday library picture-book look first. Done enough if one authentic talk and one crumb in the child's words exist.

More talk coaching (parent ear)

When they give only a preference, mirror once, then redirect: "You like it — I hear that. Point at one place. What do you *see*?" Preference stays welcome. It does not get to be the whole hour.

When they invent a story that the page cannot support — "It's a dragon flying to school" on a page of pure color spots — you have two kind moves. One: enjoy the story as story, then ask what the *marks* did: "Where did the brush go first?" Two: if the hour's skill was looking at a mug, gently return the mug: "Tell me about the handle you see." Do not crush imagination. Do not let fantasy replace a looking lesson when looking was the job.

When two siblings compare as critique — "Mine is better" — separate the pages. TALK-06 feelings first for each. Display choice is individual. Comparison as identity is not this book's check.

When the child asks you to "fix it," rescue order still holds: ask, wait, hint, short demo on *demo paper*, return the tool. Talk about art does not mean you grab the brush and narrate over their mark.

Barrett's studio grain (talk that begins with what you see; preference reports the speaker) and early-childhood yellow-dots noticing are neighbors. Use both. Neither requires a franchise poster on the fridge.

Caption coaching details

At 5–7, three words can be nouns or verbs they care about: *thick*, *drip*, *tear*, *slow*, *blue edge*. You scribe. They choose. If they dictate a whole paragraph, keep three words for the sticky and let the rest live as oral talk — print load stays light.

At 8–10, because-I-see wants a claim that the page can back. “I think the leaf looks bumpy because I see the veins and the torn edge.” Finger required. If they write a claim that only restates a book caption, cover the caption and try again.

Process sentences love clay, collage, and print hours: “First I tore, then I glued the red on top.” “First I pinched, then it fell, then I coiled.” Collapse and redesign belong in the sentence. That is make-before-polish in words.

Titles after look refuse the Happy-Tree trap. A title can be funny. It can be one word. It can change Tuesday. It cannot arrive as an assignment before the first mark if looking and making are the lesson.

Display and presenting soft

Presenting still exists at 5–10. It is not only the fridge. The child chooses: wall, folder, sketchbook closed, or gift to a grandparent. One reason is enough: “I choose this because I like the thick blue.” AOEU-style parent guidance and NCAS Presenting as a map both allow showing — without turning the fridge into a grade.

LOOK-07 Fridge Gallery Tour is talk practice on display. Ask process, not pretty. Specific noticing from you. Their choice of which piece to tour.

Second incorrect example (illustration)

An eight-year-old finishes a foam print. The parent opens a chat and asks for “an artist statement in the voice of a talented child.” The model returns a fluent paragraph about “exploring texture and emotion.” The parent tapes it under the print for the co-op show.

What went wrong: WRITE-05 refuse. Authorship blur. Performance for strangers.

Rescue: remove the paragraph. Ask the locked opening. Scribe or write one because-I-see or process sentence from the child’s mouth. Label any adult note as adult. The co-op sees the child’s words or none.

Mixed-age and co-op notes

In a co-op, talk boxes stay short. One authentic question. Wait. Do not turn the circle into a public critique of a shy five-year-old. Pair share first if the group is large: tell your partner one notice; then two volunteers share out. Adult models yellow-dots once.

At home with a toddler underfoot, talk can be two minutes while the page dries. Dose honesty: a short tell-me counts. You do not need a seminar.

Connection to look-before-name and make-before-polish

Talk that names vocabulary before anyone has looked is name-first with a microphone. Talk that only praises polish — “so neat,” “so pretty,” “fix the drip” — is polish-before-make with a smile. This chapter’s locked opening protects both locks. Look first. Keep the child’s mark. Then talk. Then write a crumb. Then, lightly, a name that fits.

Studio Structures rename Talking About Art and Showing Art map onto the talk box and display choice — say once, not as weekly franchise posters.

Parent scripts you can borrow

After a collage hour:

“Tell me about your artwork — not whether it is pretty.”

(wait)

“What did the paper do that you can point at?”

“How did you decide what went on top?”

“You may change your mind about the title tomorrow.”

After a clay hour:

“Tell me about your artwork — not whether it is pretty.”

(wait)

“What did the clay do — and what will you try next if it falls?”

“First you , *then you* . Did I get that right?”

After a museum sit:

“Tell me about this work — not whether it is pretty.”

(wait)

“What do you see that makes you say that?”

“We can leave without naming the artist. Looking was the job.”

These scripts are seeds. Your child’s answers will not match a key. That is the point.

For the student

Art talk is not a quiz show. It is you saying what you notice on your page.

You may point before you speak. You may change your mind when you look again. Preference is allowed — “I like this part” — and then you still point at what you see. “Pretty” alone is not the whole job.

Writing can be three words. Writing can be “I see ____ because ____.” Writing can be “First I, *then I*.” You do not need a long artist statement. You need words that match the look.

Tiny worked example

You painted thick blue where the brush slowed and left yellow dots near the edge. Someone asks you to tell about the artwork — not whether it is pretty. You say: “The blue is thick here because I slowed the brush. I see yellow dots along the edge.” Your finger is on the dots. That is enough.

Two tries

1. Cover any adult praise sticky. Look at your page. Say one thing you notice. Then write or dictate three words or a short caption.
2. Say “First I, *then I*.” Point at the page when you say what your hand did.

Explain it back

Teach a stuffed animal or a sibling: “Ask me to tell about my artwork — not whether it is pretty. Wait. Do not answer for me.”

Challenge

Find a sentence that only says “pretty.” Cross it out gently. Replace it with a sentence that needs your page to make sense.

One more challenge (optional)

Choose a title *after* you talk — not before you start. Write it on a sticky. You may change the title tomorrow.

If someone talks for you

If a grown-up or a sibling or a screen answers before you finish, you may say: “I was still looking.” Then point at the page and try your sentence again. Looking first is your job. Waiting is their job.

Caption ladder at a glance

Step	What it looks like	Band first home
Three words	Sticky: thick / blue / slow	5–7
Process sentence	First I, <i>then I</i>	both
Because-I-see	Claim + because + what I see	8–10
Title after look	Name chosen after talk	both
Refuse generated	Spot FAKE; rewrite from real look	meta / 8–10

Climb one rung when the lower rung is easy. Jumping to long artist statements without a finger on the page trains performance.

Sibling and mixed-age note

A five-year-old and an eight-year-old can share one looking talk about a postcard. The younger child’s sticky holds three words you scribe. The older child’s page holds a because-I-see caption. Both answer the locked question. Neither is Little Thinkers Art I. Both are Art looking with talk.

If it isn't clicking

1. Wait was zero.

You ask and answer yourself. They learn to wait for the rescue.

Next move: sit on your hands. Count three out loud once if you must. Look at the page. Practice TALK-01 alone before the child arrives.

2. Pretty loop only.

Every sentence is preference.

Next move: TALK-02 and TALK-03. You model one specific notice. Then locked opening again. Do not outlaw joy — outlaw empty praise as the only talk.

3. Print load too heavy.

Captions become tears; the hour dies.

Next move: oral exit. You scribe. Three words only. Return to writing when the talk is warm. Sister English craft helps: oral before heavy print — without turning this chapter into a phonics scope.

4. Overwrite habit.

You keep “fixing” their caption into textbook language mid-line.

Next move: second line labelled *parent note*. Their line stays. Apologize once if needed. Trust rebuilds.

5. Generated caption temptation.

A tool offers a perfect artist statement.

Next move: refuse. WRITE-05 once. Point back to the Art Hour AI box. The model may prepare *you*; it may not do their looking or their statement when those are the lesson.

When to slow down: if they cannot yet point to the page, stay on TALK-01/02/03 and WRITE-01.

When to go ahead: if captions point at the work, offer WRITE-02/04 and TALK-05.

When to get a human tutor: if language delay or anxiety makes every talk sit unsafe — a speech-language or teaching adult can help while you keep art looking gentle. No shame.

Correct a wrong reason without crushing the look. Hearing only “pretty” is information. Ask for the finger. Then teach.

Tools, including AI

Point back to the Art Hour AI box. Parent holds the account. Ages 5–7: no live open chat as the child’s partner. Ages 8–10: still parent in the room. Unaided first on looking and marking. SCRIPT after the try — questions you will say, not a paragraph for them to copy as their artist statement.

You may ask a tool to explain a named page *to you*, to draft discussion questions you will vet, or to help you design a blank caption sticky with PARENT KEY held by you. You may not write-my-artist-statement as the only draft. You may not generate a “child drawing” and file it as theirs. You may not detector-grade “the blue is thick.” Detectors fail. A child’s caption is not a fraud case.

Optional analog tools: sticky notes for captions, a “talk prompt” card with the locked opening, a sticky to cover postcard captions, sketchbook margin, fridge magnets for display choice.

If you use a voice tool to dictate a caption the child already said, label it as their spoken words you typed. That is scribe help. It is not invent-statement. If the tool invents details they never said — stop. Look again. Write only what they pointed to.

Grids, traces, and projectors still pass through the child’s eye and hand. Generators skip looking and marking. One crutch sentence, labelled OFF-AGE for art hour: a high-school math trial found an unguarded chatbot could make practice look better and leave students worse when the window closed. That paper is not a 5–10 art RCT. The kitchen rule it supports: the model may prepare the adult; it may not do the child’s looking, marking, or artist talk when those are the lesson.

What “done enough” looks like

Before you move on from this chapter’s focus:

- ☐ Child can answer the locked question with a finger on the page at least once.
- ☐ One caption, three-word sticky, or scribed process sentence exists in *their* words.
- ☐ You waited a slow three at least once without filling the silence with “pretty.”
- ☐ You uptake at least one child phrase accurately (“You said ____”).
- ☐ No generated paragraph is filed as their artist statement.

- ☐ Title, if any, came after looking talk — not before the first mark.
- ☐ One fridge-gallery, library, or museum tell-me happened, or is scheduled.

Life of the habit (not a ninth chapter). Revisit next Tuesday: uncover last week's sticky; ask the locked question again. Mix last week's mark with a new talk follow-up — yellow-dots on Monday's collage, how-did-you-do-that on Thursday's line. Stop while a look remains. A diploma is not in the room. A path through elementary art looking and talking is.

Placement by skill, not birthday. A six-year-old with strong oral notices may use 8–10 talk cards while you still scribe. A nine-year-old who freezes at print may stay oral. A “grade 2 art workbook” is a publisher's scope, not a legal grade, and not a transcript line. The work lives inside **Art**. Never a brand. Never Little Thinkers Art I.

Joy still belongs at the table. Laugh at a funny drip. Celebrate a hard try. Then return to one specific notice. Warm process is the Art Hour voice — notice yellow dots; keep the accidental drip; stop while wanting one more mark. It is not gallery-opening polish and not sample-matched craft cheer.

Done enough is showable talk and a small written crumb — not a critique program, not a percentile, not a culture-war win. The stranger who someday opens the sketchbook should find a child's sentence that points at a look — not a brand, and not a machine paragraph pretending to be a child's eyes.

If Friday's caption still makes sense after a night — they can point to the same yellow dots Monday and say the because-clause again — the talk held. If it does not, next Tuesday is shorter: one page, locked question, scribe only. Revisit is not failure. A short revisit that recovers one notice is worth more than a long lecture that recovers none. Mixing last week's pinch pot with this week's process sentence is allowed once each piece works alone.

Chapter 8 — Short assessments and progress checks

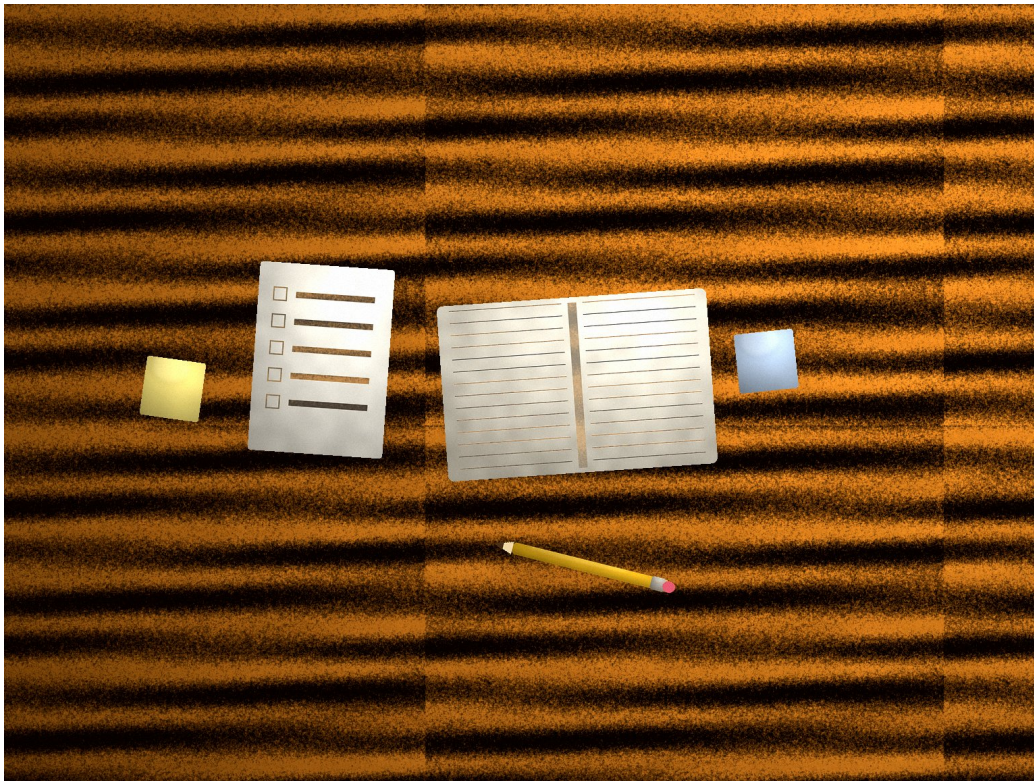


Figure 10: Three sticky exit notes and a dated folder of pages labelled Art — still-life, no people, no logos.

Why this matters

A check at ages 5–10 is a skill object, not a score that follows a child around the house.

Can they look at an edge and mark it? Can they name one thing on the page? Can they tell about the work without stopping at “pretty”? Can they say whose mark is whose? Can they choose a page for the folder and give one reason? If Friday’s look still holds after a night, the week taught something. If it does not, you have a next move. That is enough.

This is worth the struggle because the wrong kind of check teaches the wrong kind of art. A vocabulary list trains name-first. A percentile sticker trains identity: “art kid” or not. A public quiz trains performance. An app that awards points for minutes trains sitting, not looking. A generated image filed in a “child work” folder trains dishonesty. A fridge picture treated as the grade trains polish-before-make. None of those is this book’s job.

There is no nationally published homeschool NAEP Arts score for this age band that this book can turn into a kitchen cut score. Some states ask for tests in reading and mathematics, or for a narrative, or for a parent-written list of subjects. Those sittings stay in their lane. They are not this chapter. This chapter does not give legal advice. You read your own statute when you need to. The stranger who later opens a folder wants **Art** work they can see — a dated sketchbook, a looking note, the child’s make, an optional process photo — not a brand, and never a course called Little Thinkers Art I.

Screening a skill is not an identity. A child who cannot yet follow a mug’s rim today is not “not an art kid.” They need a shorter sit, a fatter tool, or one more night. You already know how to reattach a shoe pair. Use that kindness here. Lowenfeld stages are a map of typical graphic behaviors, not a giftedness or delay verdict. Do not diagnose from a fridge picture.

Kitchen skill checks are load-bearing in this book, not garnish. That is why this chapter is dedicated. Exit crumbs still live in every teaching chapter. This chapter gathers the objects, the diagnostic wrongs, the progress charts without percentiles, and the done-enough language in one place.

The locked question for this chapter is how a check should feel:

“What can you show me two ways today — and what still needs practice?”

Two ways means the look or the make is theirs, not a lucky nod. What still needs practice means the next hour already has a job. A diploma is not in the room. A path through elementary looking and making is — and that path is enough for this week.

For the parent: understand it yourself

Here is the everyday picture.

Friday night becomes a quiz. Ten vocabulary words. Five “name the element” cards. A parent and a child both get tight. The child guesses. The parent hears “not ready.” The folder gets a sad face. Next week the same list, louder. Or the opposite everyday picture: every page on the fridge is graded by how much it looks like the sample. The child’s mark disappears under adult polish. Or a phone JPEG of “kids crayon art” sits in the folder labelled as theirs.

Here is the precise picture.

Friday is short. Look at an edge and mark it from an object already on the table this week. Tell about the work — oral first. Name one notice and one make move. Say whose hand held the tool. If they can show a skill two ways — mark *and* say; sort warm/cool *and* point; choose a page *and* give a reason — you date the sketchbook. If a miss has a reason you can use tomorrow — name-first, adult-filled marks, coloring-book-only week, generated image — you keep the reason. You do not keep a label.

Done enough is local. A five-year-old who looks at a leaf, makes a mark, and says three words about the page is done enough for that check. An eight-year-old who follows a mug rim, writes a because-I-see caption, and says whose mark is whose is done enough for that check. Holding both children to the same MFA rubric is a different product.

When a program you already use includes chapter review pages, you may sit them as *listening and recall* inside that scope. They check whether a lesson was heard. They do not license a national rank. They do not replace the kitchen objects below. Label them as the program’s tools, not as a research trial of your kitchen.

Depth beats a coverage tour on checks as well as on lessons. A long vocabulary list leaves few traces. A small pattern — look, make with own mark, talk once,

leave a crumb — built slowly, is what the mind will keep. This is a useful study shape borrowed carefully, not a promise that every home will see the same result.

No CLEP for elementary. No AP Art and Design for a nine-year-old. No NCAA for art at any age in the elementary file. When the child is older and the family needs portfolio depth, open *Art for Homeschooling*. Then return here for the kitchen objects.

Wrong answers you should be able to hear

1. Fridge-as-grade.

“This one is an A because it looks like the sample.”

What it usually means: product polish replaced process and authorship.

What you say: “The fridge is a display choice. The check is look, make, talk, crumb.”

2. Percentile identity / “not an art kid.”

“This miss means you are behind.” Or: “You’re just not an art kid.”

What it usually means: screening turned into identity — sometimes with a Lowenfeld chart misused as diagnosis.

What you say: “This is a skill we can practice. It is not a name for you.”

3. Birthday lock.

“You’re 8, so you must do blind contour.” Or: “You’re 5, so you cannot do real art yet.”

What it usually means: birthday placement replaced skill placement.

What you say: “We place by what you can show. Looking first if looking is shaky.”

4. Generated image in the child-work folder.

A phone JPEG or “kids crayon style” print sits labelled as Drawing.

What it usually means: authorship blur.

What you say: AS-02. “Whose hand held the tool?” Delete from child work. Start MARK-01 with a real crayon.

5. NAEP promise or homemade high-stakes battery.

A kitchen quiz sold as national readiness.

What it usually means: compliance anxiety or sales language landed on the wrong object.

What you say: “This is a skill check for tomorrow’s teaching. It is not a national score.”

Five-minute parent warm-up

Pick one diagnostic wrong from this week — name-first, adult-filled marks, “draw it nice” freeze, coloring-book-only, generated-as-theirs, empty pretty loop, demo with no child’s page. Write it in six words.

Plan Monday’s isomorphic retest: same skill shape, fresh lookable (new mug, new leaf, new scrap tray).

Practice the locked opening aloud. Practice the second half kindly: “What still needs practice?” You are naming tomorrow, not a verdict.

Lay out tomorrow’s check pieces: sticky triad *or* whose-mark card *or* name-first catch object *or* done-enough checklist. Do the check yourself once as if you were the child.

How to teach it this week

A check week is still an Art Hour week. The try *is* the check. You do not add a second, colder hour titled Assessment.

Session shape (~20–40 minutes)

1. **Look / notice (3–8 min).** A familiar object or a close cousin — not a surprise stack of new content.
2. **Short make / check object (8–18 min).** One kitchen object below — not a battery.
3. **Talk box (3–8 min).** Locked opening. One “still needs practice” line.
4. **Name lightly (optional, 2–5 min).** After evidence.
5. **Exit crumb (2–5 min).** AS-01 sticky triad or caption. Adult error-pattern note private.

Twenty-minute Friday: one exit crumb trio *or* one whose-mark check *or* one name-first catch. Two ways on that one object. Stop.

Exact wording you can say

Opening, locked:

“What can you show me two ways today — and what still needs practice?”

Then wait.

If they freeze: “Show me with the page first. Then show me with words. We can do the second way tomorrow.”

If they perform a memorized definition: “I already know the book sentence. Show me from what you see on *this* page.”

If they ask whether they are good at art: “You can look and make a mark. You are still practicing tell-me talk. That is a map, not a name for you.”

When you fade help, do not supply the second way. When you stop talking, the sketchbook gets one line, not a speech.

Age-band moves

Ages 5–7. Oral exit. Draw or mark from a lookable. Whose-mark honesty oral. Exit spoken; you scribe. Two ways might be: mark *and* say; choose a page *and* point to why. Name-first catch soft — return the mug without shame. Coloring sheets demoted to optional quiet toy if they colonized the week.

Ages 8–10. Oral or short written crumb. Whose-mark honesty including generated-image refuse. Name-first catch with *this* object. Because-I-see as second way. Band placement soft on the plan page. If looking habits are weak, return to LOOK/MARK before fancy checks. Skill, not birthday.

First try-it for the student

Ask them to show the same idea two ways — look at the mug and mark the rim *and* tell about the page. Ask what still needs practice. Write their words. That is the spirit of AS-01 plus a kitchen object.

This week, honestly

Focus move: kitchen skill objects; one diagnostic wrong; done-enough that holds after a night.

- **Monday:** AS-01 Exit Crumb Trio on this week’s focus try.
- **Tuesday:** AS-02 Whose Mark Check — demo paper separate; generated image out of child folder if present.

- **Wednesday:** Kitchen object — look-and-mark *or* tell-about *or* choose-a-page (match the month's work). Optional AS-03 Name-First Catch if drawings went symbol-only.
- **Thursday:** AS-05 Coloring-Book Only Flag if the week's diet was fill-in lines; schedule open MARK/LOOK. Else mix last week's page with a new cousin.
- **Friday:** Locked question. Done-enough boxes (AS-06). Sleep. Saturday or Monday, ask one piece again. If it holds, it held.
- **Once this week, out of the home (optional transfer):** museum one-work retell or library picture-book look first — adult present; not a cold public quiz.
- **Once this month:** AS-04 Band Placement Soft on the plan page — place by mark control, looking, talk — not birthday.

A progress chart, if you like one, has skill boxes: look before name; child's mark; tell about the work; whose mark; caption crumb; choose a page. Dates of tries. No percentiles. No smiley ranks that become a personality.

Three to five hours. One optional outing. Friday a crumb that can survive a night. Not NAEP. Not a homemade high-stakes battery. Not CLEP/AP/NCAA for elementary — those belong to older grain when the child is older. One pointer to *Art for Homeschooling* is enough.

Practice that actually builds learning

Checks are named try-its. They still need time, materials, mess/safety, the fun, and the skill. Fun here is the relief of a finishable task. The skill is showing a look or make two ways.

Composite homes are illustrations, not reported families.

Talk box (use every check hour)

Opening (locked): “What can you show me two ways today — and what still needs practice?”

Follow-ups:

1. What do you *see / notice* on this page or object?

2. What did your hand / the material do?
3. What do you see that makes you say that?
4. Whose mark is this — and how do you know?
5. You may change your mind — what will you practice next Tuesday?

How to wait: After you ask, a slow three. After they stop, wait again. Look at the page. Do not fill silence with a grade face.

Stuck silence usually means: the check felt like a test; wait was zero; they fear “not an art kid”; every hour was coloring-book lines; a generated image was treated as theirs; they only know “pretty”; birthday pressure (“you’re 9, you should...”). Soften. Shorten. Point at the page. Name tomorrow’s practice kindly.

Incorrect example to diagnose (illustration)

Friday becomes ten vocabulary cards and a fridge ranking. The child points at a phone image as “my best work.” The parent writes “A — Artistic Pursuits K–3” on a homemade report card titled Little Thinkers Art I.

What went wrong: fridge-as-grade; generated-as-theirs; brand as title; identity theater.

Rescue: AS-02 honesty; delete JPEG from child folder; AS-01 sticky triad on a real make; title the file **Art**; one diagnostic note for Monday — not a performance grade.

AS bank try-its (dedicated)

AS-01 Exit Crumb Trio

- **Band:** both
- **Time:** 5 min
- **Materials:** Sticky notes
- **Mess / safety:** Low
- **The fun:** Three stickies feel small and complete.

- **The skill:** Exit: (1) one notice, (2) one make move, (3) one wonder. Not a grade.

How to run: End of hour. Child says or you scribe three short lines. Keep the stickies in the dated folder. Wonder may stay unanswered.

AS-02 Whose Mark Check

- **Band:** both
- **Time:** 5–10 min
- **Materials:** Work session; demo paper separate
- **Mess / safety:** —
- **The fun:** Clear honesty without a lecture.
- **The skill:** Whose hand held the tool? Adult demo stays on demo paper. Generated image $\neq$ child's work.

How to run: Ask aloud. If adult marks are on the child's page, acknowledge and start a fresh page. If a generated image is in the folder, move it to a parent-process envelope or delete it from child work.

AS-03 Name-First Catch

- **Band:** both
- **Time:** 5–10 min
- **Materials:** Drawing of a named object; the real object present
- **Mess / safety:** Low
- **The fun:** The mug returns like a friend.
- **The skill:** If drawing is symbol-only (cartoon eye, generic tree), return to looking at *this* mug / leaf. Diagnostic, not shame.

How to run: Put the object back. Silent look. “Draw the handle you see.” One rim is enough.

AS-04 Band Placement Soft

- **Band:** both
- **Time:** 10 min
- **Materials:** Recent folder of work
- **Mess / safety:** —
- **The fun:** Permission to stay where skill is.
- **The skill:** Place by skill (mark control, looking, talk), not birthday. An 8-year-old may still need 5–7 LOOK/MARK.

How to run: Adult private or gentle conference. Sort three pages: looking stamina, mark ownership, talk quality. Adjust next week’s bank picks. No Lowenfeld diagnosis sentence.

AS-05 Coloring-Book Only Flag

- **Band:** both
- **Time:** 5 min meta
- **Materials:** Week’s art diet list
- **Mess / safety:** —
- **The fun:** Honest schedule fix.
- **The skill:** If every hour is fill-in lines only, schedule one open MARK/LOOK. Coloring books not banned as quiet toys; they are not the Art Hour.

How to run: Scan the week. If needed, Monday becomes MARK-01 Child’s First

Mark Block or LOOK-01 Object Before Name.

AS-06 Done-Enough Checklist Soft

- **Band:** both
- **Time:** 5 min
- **Materials:** This week's focus
- **Mess / safety:** —
- **The fun:** Permission to stop.
- **The skill:** Done enough = looked, made with own mark, talked once, left a crumb. Not identical to sample.

How to run: Four boxes. Check what happened. Missing box = next Tuesday's job.

SAFE reinforcement (check week)

SAFE-01 Seal Check Before Open

Before a wet check hour, find ACMI AP and/or "Conforms to ASTM D-4236." Refuse CL-seal products through grade 6.

SAFE-04 No Solvents Kitchen

Default water-based AP paints and glues. No mineral spirits, turpentine, or solvent adhesives for this age book.

SAFE-05 Mess Honesty Preview

Tell the child (and yourself) mess level before a check sit. Product-only fridge hour is not the goal of a check either.

Kitchen skill objects (show two ways)

Use these as the “two ways” meat. Match the month’s teaching chapter.

1. **Look at an edge and mark it** — mug rim, leaf edge, window frame. Ways: mark *and* point at the edge on the object.
2. **Name one thing on the page** — oral or sticky. Ways: say *and* point.
3. **Tell about the work** — locked ch07 opening soft. Ways: oral *and* three-word crumb.
4. **Whose mark** — AS-02. Ways: say *and* show demo paper vs child page.
5. **Choose a page for the folder** — with one reason. Ways: choose *and* say why.

In-home progress without percentile

Progress chart (illustration): columns dated; rows: looked before naming; child’s tool on child’s page; one talk that pointed; crumb left; whose-mark clear. Checkmarks or dates only. No ranks. No “percent complete for grade 2.”

Folder skim test: Can a stranger see the child’s marks across weeks? If every page is adult-finished or generated, the folder fails the honesty check before it fails any skill check.

Out-of-home soft transfer

OUT-04 Library Picture-Book Look First (check portable)

Cover text. Notice. Tell about one page two ways (oral + optional sticky). Not a reading test.

OUT-01 Museum One Work Sit

One work. Notices. Optional tiny sketch. Two ways: notice talk *and* one sketch crumb. Refuse scavenger packets as fake assessment.

Blocked vs mixed

Blocked: One AS shape for three Fridays until it feels ordinary — exit crumb trio only.

Mixed: AS-01 + AS-02 same Friday when authorship got blurry.

Sample month (illustration)

Week 1: LOOK/MARK focus; Friday AS-01. Week 2: color mix; Friday AS-01 + AS-03 if symbols crept in. Week 3: collage; Friday AS-02 after adult almost finished a tear. Week 4: AS-04 placement soft; AS-06 done-enough; optional OUT-01. Progress chart gets four dates. No percentile. No Little Thinkers Art I line.

Second incorrect example (illustration)

A parent prints a Lowenfeld stage chart, circles “behind for seven,” and announces the child is not ready for art until middle school.

What went wrong: map misused as diagnosis; wait-until-middle-school myth.

Rescue: AS-04 skill placement; fat tools; short sits; LOOK-01 tomorrow. Teach. Do not pathologize.

Diagnostic pattern cards (adult private)

Keep these on a clipboard. They are teaching instruments, not report-card lines.

Name-first. Child draws a cartoon eye when asked to draw this mug’s handle. Monday: mug stays; LOOK-01; “Draw the handle you see.”

Adult-filled. Child holds the pencil out for you to finish. Monday: “My marks on my paper. Your marks on yours.” Demo paper only.

Nice-pressure. Child erases until the paper tears. Monday: keep the “wrong” draft; “Show me one edge only.”

Coloring-only week. Child only talks about staying in lines. Monday: AS-05; open MARK-01.

Generated-as-theirs. Child points at a phone image. Monday: AS-02; real crayon; MARK-01.

Pretty-only talk. Only preference at the table. Monday: TALK-02/03; then locked ch08 opening on Friday.

Explain-before-look. Freezes when a caption is shown first. Monday: cover caption; LOOK-02.

Stage diagnosis. Parent hears “behind for seven.” Monday: AS-04; fat tools; short sits; teach.

Write one pattern in six words after Friday. That sentence is tomorrow’s lesson plan.

How “two ways” sounds in ordinary kitchens

Illustration A (5–7): Child tore a collage. Two ways: point at the red scrap on top *and* say “I put red last.” Still needs practice: “scissors stay for next week — we tore today.” Parent scribes the sticky. Done enough.

Illustration B (8–10): Child followed a mug rim. Two ways: show the line *and* write “I see a thick rim because the mug edge is round here.” Still needs practice: “blind contour felt wobbly — try soft again Tuesday.” Done enough.

Illustration C (mixed age): Older child captions; younger child dictates three words about the same postcard. Both answer the locked question. Neither is ranked against the other.

Progress chart template (copy freely)

Skill	Date tried	Showed two ways?	Still needs practice (child words)
Look before name			
Child’s mark on child’s page			
Tell about the work (not pretty-only)			
Whose mark honesty			
Caption / process crumb			

Skill	Date tried	Showed two ways?	Still needs practice (child words)
Choose a page + reason			

No percent column. No smiley rank that becomes a personality. Dates and words only.

When a vendor page sits beside the check

If you use Artistic Pursuits, Draw Write Now, How Great Thou Art early, Atelier early levels, or a library how-to, you may keep one vendor page in the folder as a *starting document* or recall check. It does not replace AS-01–06. It does not become the transcript title. Chapter 10 names programs by fit. Chapter 9 names the file **Art**.

Connection to every teaching chapter's crumb

Ch01–ch06 already leave exit crumbs. This chapter does not invent a second assessment religion. It gathers shapes so a busy Friday has a menu: sticky triad, whose-mark, name-first catch, coloring-only flag, band placement, done-enough. Use one. Note one diagnostic. Sleep.

REAP's finding — arts-rich education correlated with verbal/math in some datasets, without evidence that studying the arts *causes* those scores to rise — belongs in the welcome once. Do not sell Friday's check as a math booster. Justify the check by looking and making.

Parent scripts for the locked opening

"What can you show me two ways today — and what still needs practice?"
(wait)

"Show me with your finger on the page first."

"Now show me with words."

"What will we practice next Tuesday — your words, not a grade."

If they say “I can’t draw”: “Looking got ahead of the hand sometimes. Show me one edge only. That is practice, not a talent verdict.”

If they ask for a score: “We date the page. We name practice. We do not need a letter today.”

Out-of-home check ethics

A museum is not a pop quiz stage. Do not grade a child aloud in a gallery. Do not use a scavenger sheet as assessment theater. One work, notices, optional sketch, walk out. Transfer of looking is enough. Public shame is never a check.

Library hours: pictures before text is a looking check portable. It is not a reading percentile.

Mess and safety during checks

Checks often reuse this week’s materials. Cover the table. AP / ASTM D-4236. Labelled children’s scissors if cutting appears. No craft knives. No solvents. Adult present for wet, sharp, outdoor. Mess honesty before you start — even on Friday. Poison Control 1-800-222-1222 if needed. “Non-toxic” does not mean edible.

Weekly rhythm that keeps checks light

Monday–Thursday teach. Friday checks one skill object. Once a month, AS-04 band placement soft. Once a month, skim the folder for authorship honesty (AS-02). That is a full assessment life for ages 5–10. It is not a 180-day testing calendar.

If a week was only outings — museum Saturday, library Tuesday — the Friday check can be portable: two ways on a postcard notice, or choose one museum sketch for the folder and say why. Looking transferred. Still not a scavenger score.

If a week was sick or travel, skip the check. Dose honesty. A missed Friday is not a character flaw. Resume with AS-01 on the next real Art Hour.

What “held after a night” means

Saturday morning, or Monday before a new make, ask one piece again: “Show me the rim you marked Friday.” If they can find the edge on the mug and make

a cousin mark, the look held. If they cannot, you learned something useful — the sit was too long, the tool was too thin, or talk replaced looking. Shorten. Do not raise your voice. Do not add ten vocabulary cards.

Soderstrom and Bjork’s learning-vs-performance grain (performance in the hour is not the same as learning that lasts) is a useful caution for any subject. Label it carefully. Do not invent an art-hour coefficient. Then teach the next short sit.

Honest vs dishonest folder (illustration)

Honest: 24 September 2026. Looked at oak leaf. Child said edges were pointy. Graphite from leaf. Three-word sticky: pointy / vein / green. Process photo of hands on paper optional, face cropped.

Dishonest: “Little Thinkers Art I, A+, 1.0 credit.” Generated pear JPEG labelled Drawing. Adult-rewritten artist statement. Sample craft identical to twelve other co-op kids with no child’s mark visible.

Chapter 9 turns the honest page into a stranger-readable record. This chapter only needs you to refuse the dishonest one at the kitchen table.

Sibling fairness without ranking

Two children, two pages, two “still needs practice” lines. The older child’s smoother rim is not a crown. The younger child’s bold tear is not a consolation prize. AS-04 may place them on different bank picks in the same week — that is skill placement, not favoritism. Say it aloud once: “Different practice. Same respect.”

For the student

A check is not a trap. It is you showing what you can do two ways — and saying what still needs practice.

Two ways might mean: draw the rim *and* point at the mug. Tell about your page *and* write three words. Choose a page for the folder *and* say why.

What still needs practice is ordinary. Shoes take practice. Mug rims take practice. Talk that is not only “pretty” takes practice.

Tiny worked example

You looked at a leaf. You marked the pointy edge. Someone asks what you can show two ways. You point at the leaf *and* at your line. You say, “I still need practice on the stem.” That is a complete check.

Two tries

1. Pick one page from this week. Show it two ways (look/mark, or talk/crumb). Say one thing that still needs practice.
2. Answer “Whose mark?” about a page. If a grown-up helped on your paper, say so kindly. Start a fresh mark that is yours.

Explain it back

Teach a stuffed animal: “Ask me what I can show two ways. Ask what still needs practice. Wait. Do not grade me.”

Challenge

Find a page that only looks like a sample. Make one new page that shows *your* mark. Put both in the folder. Label whose is whose.

If someone calls you “not an art kid”

You may say: “I am practicing looking and making.” Then show one page. Identity stickers are not this book’s job.

Check ladder at a glance

Check	What it looks like	Band first home
Exit crumb trio	Notice / make / wonder stickies	both
Whose mark	Demo paper separate; no generated-as-theirs	both
Name-first catch	Object returns; draw what you see	both
Band placement	Skill, not birthday	adult + child soft
Coloring-only flag	Schedule open MARK/LOOK	meta
Done-enough	Looked, own mark, talk, crumb	both

Check	What it looks like	Band first home
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Sibling note

Siblings can share a check hour with separate pages. Do not crown a winner. Each child names their own “still needs practice.”

If it isn’t clicking

1. Parent grading the fridge.

Every display becomes a score.

Next move: AS-06. Fridge is choice. Check is crumb + two ways. Remove letter grades from elementary Art pages.

2. Shame after a miss.

One blank page becomes a personality.

Next move: “You mixed symbol and looking. Tomorrow we try one mug only.” AS-03 without a lecture.

3. Folder full of adult marks or generated images.

Authorship is blurry.

Next move: AS-02. Fresh MARK-01. Demo on demo paper only. Delete generated work from child folder.

4. Check feels like NAEP.

Long packets; tight jaws.

Next move: Twenty-minute Friday. One object. Two ways. Stop.

5. Birthday lock fights the child.

Forced blind contour; forced vocabulary.

Next move: AS-04. Return to LOOK/MARK. Skill first.

When to slow down: if they cannot yet leave a crumb, stay on AS-01 oral only.

When to go ahead: if two-ways is easy, add written because-I-see and AS-04 monthly.

When to get a human tutor: if anxiety or motor struggle makes every check unsafe — a teaching adult can help while you keep looking gentle. No shame.

Correct a wrong reason without crushing the look. Hearing name-first is information. Return the object. Then teach.

Tools, including AI

Point back to the Art Hour AI box. Parent holds the account. Checks are unaided first on looking and marking. SCRIPT after the try if you want coaching questions for *you*.

You may ask a tool to help you design a blank sticky triad or a done-enough checklist. You may crop a photo to the *paper* (not the face) and ask what looking mix-up is likely — then *you* talk to the child. You may not photo-to-key a looking quiz. You may not detector-grade a contour. You may not generate the child's project for the folder. You may not write their artist statement as the only draft of a check crumb.

Optional analog tools: sticky notes, dated folder, clipboard checklist, optional camera for process photos (crop faces), demo paper labelled DEMO.

COPPA: whole band under 13. Parent in the room. Not a secret friend.

What “done enough” looks like

Before you move on from this chapter's focus:

- ☐ You can run AS-01 through AS-06 shapes (not all in one day — across weeks).
- ☐ Folder shows child's marks across weeks — not only samples or generated images.
- ☐ One diagnostic pattern is noted for tomorrow's teaching — not a performance grade.
- ☐ Child has answered the locked question at least once with two ways + still-needs-practice.
- ☐ No percentile identity label (“not an art kid”) was filed from a kitchen check.
- ☐ Safety seals checked when wet materials were used; no solvents as default.

Life of the habit (not a ninth chapter). Revisit next Tuesday: uncover last Friday's stickies; ask one piece again. Mix last week's mark into this week's whose-

mark honesty. Stop while wanting one more look. Progress is dated pages, not a diploma.

Placement by skill, not birthday. A “grade 2 art workbook” is a publisher’s scope, not a legal grade, not a transcript line. The work lives inside **Art**. Never a brand. Never Little Thinkers Art I.

Done enough is a parent who can hear name-first, adult-filled marks, coloring-book-only weeks, and generated-as-theirs — and who has a next move for each — plus a child who can show something two ways and name practice without shame. Not NAEP. Not a fridge grade. Not a culture-war win.

If Monday’s retest of Friday’s rim mark still holds — same edge, fresh paper, child’s tool — the check held. If it does not, next Friday is shorter: one object, AS-01 only, scribe the talk. Revisit is not failure. Mixing last week’s tear collage with this week’s whose-mark question is allowed once each piece works alone.

Homeschooling was about 3.4 percent of K–12 students in 2022–23 (~1.765 million). Instruction-at-home 5.2 percent is a different bucket. Those numbers describe the pond, not your child’s rim line. Keep the sketchbook. Teach the next looking move. PFI 2016 reported Art taught that year to 78 percent of K–2-equivalent homeschoolers and 63 percent of the 3–5 band (53 percent total). Those rows describe subject exposure in a survey year — not a kitchen cut score, not NAEP, and not a reason to invent Little Thinkers Art I. Keep teaching looking and making. Keep the checks short. Keep the title Art when a stranger needs a word. When in doubt, shrink the check until kindness returns. One mug. One sticky. One honest sentence about practice. That Friday still counts. Coverage itch is the enemy of looking — and the enemy of fair assessment too. A path through elementary art looking is the promise. A diploma is not. A percentile is not. An art-makes-you-smarter pitch is not.

You do not need a laminated rubric on the wall. You need a dated page, a child who can show something two ways, and a next Tuesday that already knows its job. That is short assessment at 5–10. That is progress without a percentile identity machine. Look before name. Make before polish. Check kindly. Then teach again.

If the only thing you remember from this chapter is the locked question and the AS-02 honesty line, you already have enough to keep Friday human and the folder honest. Ask the question. Wait. Date the page. Begin again. That is enough for this age band. Done.

Chapter 9

Records

The art *work* can be as ordinary as a mug on the table and as serious as any classroom hour. The *credit* is a family claim until a stranger can use it — a receiving third-grade teacher, a Pennsylvania evaluator, a New York quarterly reader, a later high-school transcript the family will someday write. That stranger will not have sat at your table. They will have a page.

This chapter is how you make that page at ages 5–10. Lawful, honest, and readable to a stranger are three jobs. Keep them in view.

This week you can date one looking note and one child's make in a sketchbook so a stranger could almost read them. Today the student tries the page. You write the line when they still need a scribe.



Figure 11: An open sketchbook titled **Art**, a dated looking note, a child's graphite leaf, a sticky caption, an optional process photo cropped to paper. No diploma seal. No grade. No brand. No child face.

What you are making

You are making a **dated sketchbook** (or folder) of **Art**, with a **looking note**, the **child's make**, and an **optional process photo**. You may keep an optional vendor page when you use a purchased program. You are not making a national diploma. You are not making Little Thinkers Art I.

There is often **no** elementary transcript. When a stranger asks, the title is **Art**. **Drawing** only lightly when the year's work is mostly drawing — still not a brand. Never Artistic Pursuits K–3. Never Draw Write Now Book 3. Never Usborne Art Skills. Never How Great Thou Art I Can Do All Things. Never Atelier Level 2. Never Living Art Lessons. Never **Little Thinkers Art I**. The dated sketchbook,

the looking note, the child's make, and the optional process photo live *inside* Art.

There is no federal homeschool diploma and no national art credit at this age. Texas, North Carolina, and New York do not issue one for elementary home instruction. Pennsylvania's supervisor or approved-organization diploma after listed graduation courses is a high-school object, not a five-year-old's file. Virginia's list of subjects is a list, not a transcript. A parent-issued diploma can be a real piece of paper later. It is not a registrar's national art credit now.

Two readers, even at 5–10, if anyone outside the kitchen asks. The **state**, in a thick jurisdiction: an IHIP, an affidavit, a portfolio — with creative materials where the statute named art. A **later stranger**: a public school on transfer; a private school; a future high-school transcript. State compliance is not an art diploma. A thick Pennsylvania portfolio can be in statutory compliance with creative-material samples. A silent Texas year can be lawful with no art file at all, provided bona fide written reading, spelling, grammar, math, and good citizenship are happening. Neither fact is a reason to skip looking and making. Both facts are a reason not to fake a credit.

A family that invents “Little Thinkers Art I, 1.0, A” for a seven-year-old has created a slogan. A receiving teacher cannot map it. NCAA, CLEP, and AP Art and Design belong to an older year and to *Art for Homeschooling*.

In 2016, Art was taught that year to 78 percent of K–2-equivalent homeschooled students and 63 percent of the 3–5 band (53 percent of all K–12-equivalent home-schoolers).³³ Informal looking does not arrive as “Art, 1.0, B+.” If a thick state later wants a log, the translation is: name the task, name the materials or place, date it, keep a sample. Do not paste History's social-studies percents or science-inquiry percents into an art sentence.

Titles a stranger can read

Print these and only these as elementary names, if a name is needed at all:

³³Jiashan Cui and Rachel Hanson, *Homeschooling in the United States: Results from the 2012 and 2016 Parent and Family Involvement Survey*, NCES 2020-001, Table 9: Art taught *that year* — 78 percent K–2 / 63 percent 3–5 / 53 percent total (6–8 50; 9–12 29; male 46; female 60). Quote those. Do not paste History's social-studies percents or science-inquiry percents into an art sentence. The 2023 First Look (NCES 2024-113) did not republish subject-taught tables.

Art. Drawing (lightly, only when the year’s work is mostly drawing). Reading / Language Arts / English. Mathematics / Arithmetic. History / Social Studies. Science. Music, Physical Education.

Those names travel. They are the names public elementary reports already use. They are the names homeschool elementary files, when they exist, already follow.

Never a brand. Never Little Thinkers Art I.

The brand, if used at all, sits in a parenthetical or in a description: “Art (library picture-book looking; kitchen tempera; museum one-work sit; Draw Write Now Book 1).” Combining objects is allowed. Combining does not mint a new title. Library book plus one purchased lesson plus a leaf rubbing is still Art.

A publisher’s “grade 2 art workbook” is a scope, not a legal grade, and not a transcript line. Placement is by skill, not birthday.

Here is an illustration, labelled as such, not a reported family:

24 September 2026. Looked at oak leaf. Child said the edges were “pointy.” Graphite drawing from leaf (not from a cartoon tree). Tempera wash on second page. Sticky: pointy / vein / slow. Process photo optional (hands and paper only).

That is a record a parent, a Pennsylvania evaluator, or a New York quarterly narrative can actually use. It is not a credit. It is not NAEP. It is not a diploma. It is not AP Selected Works.

The law is a pattern, not one form

U.S. homeschooling is state law. There is no federal art office. Dates and subject lists change. Read your current department page and the statute it cites. A color-coded chart on a membership site is not your statute. Five official-page examples show the range. **None of them requires “Little Thinkers Art I.”** Art is sometimes named, sometimes left to the parent’s list, and sometimes neither named nor tested.³⁴ This chapter is not legal advice. The parent reads their own statute.

³⁴Texas *Leeper*, restated on TEA Alternative Schooling: reading, spelling, grammar, math, good citizenship — art not named as a word. North Carolina DNPE: annual nationally standardized test includes English grammar, reading, spelling, and mathematics — not art. Pennsylvania 24 P.S. § 13-1327.1: elementary shall include art; portfolio may include creative materials; portfolio tests in

Texas. The Agency does not regulate home-school programs on the opened Alternative Schooling pages. Parents follow a bona fide written curriculum: reading, spelling, grammar, math, and a course in **good citizenship**. *Leeper*, restated on TEA's page, does **not** name the word art. The kitchen may still look and make every day. The state does not award a homeschool diploma. At 5–10 there may be no external reader at all. The kitchen still benefits from a dated sketchbook if the family later transfers. Transfer is treated like an unaccredited private school. “We did Artistic Pursuits K–3” is not, by itself, a public-school credit. A district may test for placement.

North Carolina. Notice of Intent. Nine calendar months. Each year, a nationally standardized test in **English grammar, reading, spelling, and mathematics** — not art, and not a franchise. The home school, not the State, issues any later diploma. DNPE tells the family not to name the homeschool after a curriculum brand. A sketchbook is extra. It is not the annual test. The annual battery is compliance. It is not this book's kitchen check.

Pennsylvania. Elementary **shall include** art among other subjects. No “Little Thinkers Art.” Portfolio language may include creative materials. Portfolio tests in grades 3, 5, and 8 are in **reading/language arts and mathematics**, not an art sitting. Drop sketches into the portfolio. Skip inventing a parallel “Little Thinkers” portfolio. A supervisor diploma is Pennsylvania's, and it is high school.

Virginia. Notice, a parent-written **list of subjects**, and evidence of progress: a composite score at or above the fourth stanine, or an equivalent SAT, ACT, or PSAT score, or an evaluation letter. Art is not named as required because no subject is named as required; the parent writes the list. **Art** is the ordinary word to write. Those sittings are not this book's short check. A publisher art page does not, by itself, satisfy Virginia's fourth-stanine object.

New York. Letter of intent, an Individualized Home Instruction Plan, quarterly reports, and an annual assessment. Grades 1–6 required subjects include **visual arts** among others. Put looking and making under visual arts / Art in the quarterlies: material covered in each IHIP subject. Name the materials (sketchbook, how-to book, museum day) as the IHIP already wants a list of syllabi. The course title is

grades 3, 5, and 8 in reading/language arts and mathematics. New York 8 NYCRR 100.10: grades 1–6 require visual arts among other subjects; quarterly reports; annual assessment. Virginia § 22.1-254.1: parent writes a list of subjects; evidence of progress. None of the five requires a named “Little Thinkers Art I.” This chapter is not legal advice. The parent reads their own statute. Access date for URLs in these notes: 24 September 2026.

still Art / visual arts. Home instruction does not yield a local or Regents diploma. Grades 7–8 art half-unit and 9–12 art and/or music unit are later objects — not the 5–10 center.

If you live in none of those states, you still have a department page. Open it.

What a short check is (for the file)

Five objects, not a battery — continuity with Chapter 8:

1. **A dated sketchbook.** Date, what was looked at, what the child made, one sentence of looking note. Under **Art** if a title is needed.
2. **Looking note.** What they noticed before a name — oral first; you may scribe.
3. **Child’s make.** The mark on the page. Not a generated JPEG. Not an adult-finished sample.
4. **Optional process photo.** Crop to paper and hands if needed. Do not upload the child’s face into a generator. Do not treat the photo as the grade.
5. **Optional vendor page** when you use a purchased program — as a starting document or recall check, not as the course title.

Look before name; make before polish. The looking note comes before the vocabulary quiz. The child’s mark comes before the “pretty enough for the fridge” filter. A parent who erases the child’s line to make it “right” has polished before the child made. Screening “can the child look longer?” is not an identity label.

What a short check is not

NAEP. A percentile promise. A homemade high-stakes battery. Homeschooling was 3.4 percent of K–12 students in 2022–23 (~1.765 million); instruction-at-home 5.2 percent is a different bucket (homeschool or full-time virtual).³⁵ There is no nationally representative homeschool NAEP Arts score for this age band. CLEP. AP. No CLEP for elementary. No AP at this age. Those objects belong

³⁵NCES 2024-113: 3.4 percent homeschooled in 2022–23, about 1,765,000; K–2 4.0 percent; 3–5 3.6 percent. Instruction-at-home 5.2 percent is a different bucket (homeschool or full-time virtual). NCES has never published a nationally representative homeschool NAEP Arts score for this age band as a lock for this book. There is no opened national study of daily homeschool art minutes.

to *Art for Homeschooling*. NCAA core courses do not include art even in high school; there is no Eligibility Center packet for a seven-year-old's collage. Do not send a parent of a seven-year-old to ncaa.org for art credit.

If they transfer

Transfer is a local placement problem. A brand in the title column will not be read as Art. Another reason the title should already look like Art.

A receiving teacher who sees “Little Thinkers Art I, A” has been given a slogan. A teacher who sees “Art — dated sketchbook; looked at leaf; graphite from observation; child said pointy edges; tempera wash” has been given a year they can place.

Place by skill, not birthday

Can the child look before they name? If not, they are still in the looking chapter, whatever their age. Can they leave a mark that is theirs? If not, they are still in mark-making. Can they tell about the work without stopping at pretty? If not, they are still in Chapter 7 talk. High-sounding *titles* cannot skip those moves. A ten-year-old may still need oral captions. A six-year-old may already follow a rim. Skill first.

What to keep in the file

1. A dated sketchbook: date, looking note, child's make, one wrong turn you will reteach. Under **Art**.
2. Sticky crumbs and process sentences from the weeks — not a crate of every worksheet.
3. Optional process photos — few, cropped kindly.
4. Optional vendor page, if you used one — as a looking check, not as a yearly IQ.
5. State objects that actually apply: a Pennsylvania creative-materials sample if you are in Pennsylvania; a New York quarterly under visual arts if you are in New York; a Virginia list that includes Art if you write the list; a

North Carolina annual battery in its own lane if you are in North Carolina.
Compliance stays in its lane.

Life of the habit, as the file you keep, lives here: date the work; name the skill; keep one wrong turn you can reteach. Revisit next Tuesday is a move in Chapters 7 and 8. The sketchbook is how Tuesday leaves a trace.

A path through elementary art looking is the promise. A diploma is not. A percentile is not. A culture-war win is not.

For grades 1–12 survey, transcript titles, portfolio depth, and later AP edges, see *Art for Homeschooling* — this book teaches the 5–10 Art Hour.

Chapter 10

Resources

This chapter names programs and paths families actually meet. It does not rank them. It does not sell them. It is a fit list so you can match an object to the table you already have: how much of the teaching you will carry, whether looking comes before naming, whether the child still makes an original mark, what it costs in money and in minutes, and whether the title on the file can stay **Art**.

A “grade 2 art workbook” is a publisher’s scope, not a legal grade. Placement is by skill. The record, as Chapter 9 said, still says **Art**. Combining two honest objects does not mint a new title. Library picture book plus one purchased lesson plus a museum sit is still Art.

Independent trials of these programs *in homeschool* remain scarce. A vendor award list is not a kitchen RCT. Choose by fit: parent load, look-then-make versus step-by-step copy, religious versus secular, age label inside 5–10, and whether high-school credit language must be fenced to *Art for Homeschooling*.

This week you can name *why* tonight’s object fits this child — usually a library card and a mug on the table. Today the student tries that page. They are not on a shopping task.



Figure 12: A library card, a museum postcard, fat crayons, a generic book spine with the title unreadable, a sketchbook labelled Art. No logos. No portraits.

How to read a program

Four questions do the work.

Parent load. Are you sitting with a library book you already have? Playing a video lesson? Copying step-by-step drawings? Hunting supplies for a kit?

Style. Look-then-original-make? Step-by-step copy plus handwriting? Christian directed exercises? Secular elements-of-art at the upper edge? Video models a project?

Cost shape. Nothing tonight with a library card or a free museum hour where it exists. A book you already own. A print set whose dollars sat on a page some other access day and will stale. This chapter **omits unverified 2026 list prices.**

Confirm a current price on the page before you buy.

Age label. A five-year-old is not a high-school Drawing credit. A ten-year-old may still need fat tools and LOOK/MARK if looking is the skill. Birthday is a weak prior.

Reach numbers on an organization's page are that organization's copy, not a home-school census and not an effect size.

Library, museum, and gallery — \$0 first

A public-library card. A children's picture-book shelf. A how-to art book on the same shelf. A museum, gallery, or historical site. A sculpture walk. A grocery color cart. A yard texture rubbing. That is tonight.

Fit. Parent load: presence and talk, not a script. Looking: caption cover, one-work sits, and picture-before-text are natural look-before-name prompts. Making: child's page afterward at the kitchen table. Placement: the child's interest and looking stamina, not a grade sticker. Cost shape: **\$0 first** with a card, a free or reduced museum day where it exists, or the yard. Fines, holds, admission, and parking are local objects — this book does not invent a national free-museum guarantee.

In 2016, 66 percent of homeschool households used the library as a source of curriculum and books (78 percent in K–2, 70 percent in 3–5).³⁶ In 2022–23, 53 percent of the Homeschool-total row had visited a library in the past month, against 29 percent of all K–12; 43 percent had visited an art gallery, museum, or historical site, against 23 percent.³⁷ Table 10 (2016) showed arts-and-crafts in the past week at 66 percent homeschooled vs 48 percent enrolled, and gallery/museum/historical site past month at 39 percent vs 26 percent.³⁸ Those are different questions in different years. All of them point at free-or-low-cost looking. Library, museum, and gallery outings motivate. They do not replace the look-before-name move.

³⁶NCES 2020-001 (2016 PFI): library as curriculum/book source — 66 percent total; K–2 78 percent; 3–5 70 percent.

³⁷NCES 2024-113 Table A-5 Homeschool row (2022–23): library visit past month 53 percent vs 29 percent all K–12; art gallery/museum/historical site 43 percent vs 23 percent. Access date 24 September 2026.

³⁸NCES 2020-001 Table 10 (2016): arts-and-crafts past week 66 percent homeschooled vs 48 percent enrolled; art gallery/museum/historical site past month 39 percent vs 26 percent.

A story hour, a gallery walk, or a leaf rubbing is not a transcript line by itself. It does not replace a purchased spine for a family that wants one. It does not replace child's-mark honesty for a week that only filled coloring-book lines. It is the honest starting inventory before a catalog purchase.

Transcript. Materials under Art if a log is needed: “library read-alouds and how-tos, titles listed; museum one-work notes; kitchen tempera.” Never Little Thinkers Art I. Never “Library Hour 1.”

The teaching chapters of this book are written for this object first. A purchased program is a fit, not a requirement.

Artistic Pursuits — early (Brenda Ellis)

Vendor pages describe a K–3 program for kindergarten and early elementary, ages about 5–9; Volume 1 *Art for Children, Building a Visual Vocabulary* (18 lessons); look at masterworks; language of art; produce drawing, painting, sculpture that shows the child's ideas; video lessons on materials; designed with the symbolic stage in mind. Elementary 4–5 *Elements of Art and Composition* sits at the **top edge** of this band (publisher grades 4–5). High-school books with “full credit” language exist — **fence those to Art for Homeschooling**.

Fit. Parent load: low-to-moderate (materials + sit for video/text). Look-then-original-make: vendor emphasizes original work from the child's world, not copying one way to draw a tree. Secular on pages opened. Age: early volumes inside 5–10; HS books out of center.

Transcript. Art. Description may name the book. Never “Artistic Pursuits K–3” as the course title.

Draw Write Now

Vendor pages describe an eight-book series; ages about 5–9; step-by-step drawing plus short sentences for writing; book numbers do **not** equal grade level; start with Book 1 if confidence is low; multi-age use claimed; manuscript in books 1–8; cursive options in later books. Awards cited on vendor pages are vendor citing awards, not trials.

Fit. Parent load: low; sit and draw. Process: explicitly copy-the-drawing steps, plus handwriting. Secular on pages opened. High-school credit: no. This is elementary drawing-plus-handwriting, not Art I. Pair honestly with open MARK/LOOK hours so step-by-step does not become the only diet (Chapter 8, AS-05).

Transcript. **Art** and/or Language Arts depending on whether the family counts drawing or handwriting. Never “Draw Write Now Book 3.”

Usborne *Art Skills* / library how-to

Usborne *Art Skills* (Fiona Watt / Art Ideas line) and kin offer many project ideas for painting, drawing, printing, collage; low-equipment claims; age about 7+ on U.S. store pages historically. Related looking books exist. Treat current price and exact age badge as something to confirm on the live page — this chapter omits unverified list prices. The **fit** stands: library how-to, process ideas, not a 36-week scope-and-sequence by itself.

Fit. Parent load: low. Process: project ideas; child may follow or adapt. Secular trade books. High-school credit: no. Library copies are the NCES-shaped path.

Transcript. May support elementary **Art**. Does not become Art History by sitting on a shelf.

How Great Thou Art — early (Barry Stebbing)

Vendor pages describe Christian-perspective art education; *I Can Do All Things* — comprehensive beginner course, vendor ages **6–10** (drawing, colored pencil, painting, markers); *Lamb’s Book of Art I* — ages **8 & up**, grades about 3–6 emphasis; *Lamb’s Book II* ages about 10+; How Great Thou Art I & II ages 12+ with high-school drawing-credit **vendor** language — **fence those to Art for Homeschooling**.

Fit. Parent load: low once text/DVD is in play; courts the non-artist parent (vendor). Process: step-by-step directed exercises. Religious: explicitly Christian. Age: *I Can Do All Things* and *Lamb’s Book I* inside or at edge of 5–10; HS bundles out of center.

Transcript. **Art.** Never “How Great Thou Art I Can Do All Things” as the course title.

Atelier / Arts Attack — early edges

Vendor pages for Atelier (homeschoolart.com lineage) describe an online video-based program; ages **4–16**; eight levels; elements and principles; art history; press-play; co-op-friendly claims; no art background required (vendor). Arts Attack is the school-side / lineage name on related pages. **Do not mash** this product with a classical sight-size / Bargue atelier tradition (human instructor, cast drawing) — that tradition is a different object and is not verified here as a named homeschool package.

Fit. Parent load: low (materials + play). Process: video models a project; more directed than Artistic Pursuits’ choose-your-subject claim. Secular-to-generic on pages opened. Age: early levels inside 5–10; later levels toward 11–16 are edges / later ladder. High-school credit: vendor ages to 16; do not treat early levels as Art I.

Transcript. Art. Never “Atelier Level 2.”

Elements-of-art / Living Art Lessons — edge of the band

This slot is not a single franchise. It covers elements-of-art titled early/upper-elementary options and neighbors:

- Artistic Pursuits Elementary 4–5 Book 1 *The Elements of Art and Composition* (vendor grades 4–5; observation; original subjects — **edge of 5–10**).
- Living Art Lessons (Master Books / NLPG; vendor grades **4–6**; seven elements; nature observation; Christian — **edge**, adaptable younger per reviewer anecdotes, not a trial).
- Other library how-tos, nature journaling as a **method**, co-op art hours.

Fit. Parent load varies. Use when the child is ready for named elements (line, shape, color...) **after** looking and making — not as a vocabulary-first drill for a five-year-old. Fence anything marketed as middle-school or high-school credit.

Transcript. Still Art.

Fit against fit (no ranking)

Need	Lean (vendor-labelled)
\$0 / card already in the wallet	Library, museum, gallery
Look + original make, secular, early	Artistic Pursuits K–3
Young child, drawing + handwriting, short	Draw Write Now
Library how-to / low load	Usborne <i>Art Skills</i> and kin
Christian, DVD/text, ages ~6–10	How Great Thou Art <i>I Can Do All Things</i> / <i>Lamb's Book</i>
Video does the teaching; co-op	Atelier / Arts Attack early levels
Named elements at 8–10 edge	Elements-of-art titles / Living Art Lessons edge
HS credit / AP / portfolio depth	Fence to Art for Homeschooling

A family may combine (library looking + Draw Write Now + later Artistic Pursuits). Combining does not authorize a franken-course title. The transcript still says Art.

Do not crown one. Do not invent “research-based brain development” as if it were a trial. Do not invent unpublished weekly-minute charts. Do not freeze unverified 2026 list prices.

Placement by skill at the shelf

If looking habits are weak, stay with library looking, LOOK/MARK banks, and fat tools — even if the birthday says 9 and the shelf says “elements of art.” If a seven-year-old can follow a rim and wants a step-by-step book for fun, allow it *and* keep one open-make hour so AS-05 does not trip. Publisher age badges are priors. Skill is the placement tool (Chapter 8, AS-04).

Combining honestly

Library card + mug + tempera is enough. Library + Draw Write Now + museum Saturday is enough. Artistic Pursuits early + kitchen clay is enough. Christian text + secular museum day is allowed when the family’s conscience allows it — the file still says Art, not a mash-up brand.

What combining is not: “Little Thinkers Art I with Artistic Pursuits and AP prep.”
What combining is not: filing a generated image beside a vendor page and calling both student work.

Safety still holds when a program arrives: ACMI AP and/or Conforms to ASTM D-4236; no CL products through grade 6; no solvents as default; labelled children’s scissors; no craft knives for this age book; adult present; mess honesty. Read the current label. “Non-toxic” does not mean edible. Poison Control 1-800-222-1222 if needed.

Fence to Art for Homeschooling

High-school Drawing / Painting / Sculpture credit language, portfolio for strangers, AP Art and Design, AP Art History, oil and solvent paths, kiln encyclopedia, and grades 1–12 survey chapters belong to the older book. One pointer. Then return here for ages 5–10. Do not dump those objects into a kitchen tempera hour.

Sister Little Thinkers manuals (History, Science, Critical Thinking, English, Math) supply session-shape grain. They are not sequels this book continues. One pointer each if useful. Then teach art as looking and making.

Materials still-life (starter, not a kit price)

Paper, graphite, colored pencil, crayon, tempera or watercolor with AP / ASTM D-4236 labelling, air-dry clay or playdough, labelled children’s scissors, school glue, table cover, smock, water jar, towels. Foam plates for soft prints at 8–10. Window viewfinder from scrap card. Dated sketchbook. Museum postcard. No solvents. No craft knives. No invented “\$X per year” kit cost in this chapter.

A short shopping / not-shopping script

Before you buy anything, ask:

1. Do we already have paper, a looking object, and twenty minutes?
2. Did we use the library shelf this month?
3. Is the child’s mark still the center — or are we buying identical outputs?
4. Does the vendor’s “credit” language belong to high school? If yes, fence it.

5. Can the file still say **Art** without a brand in the title column?

If the answers are yes / yes / child's mark / fenced / Art, you may not need a purchase tonight. If you do buy, buy for fit, not for fear.

What “look-then-make” vs “step-by-step” means at the table

Look-then-make programs (Artistic Pursuits early is the clearest vendor example in this list) put observation and original subject choice near the center. Step-by-step programs (Draw Write Now; many How Great Thou Art early exercises; many video models) put a demonstrated sequence near the center. Both can live in a 5–10 home. Neither is crowned. The house lock still applies: look before name; make before polish; child's mark on the child's page. If step-by-step becomes the only hour for three weeks, AS-05 flags the diet — schedule one open MARK/LOOK — without banning the quiet toy or the confidence-building copy page.

Video programs lower parent load and can raise sample-matching pressure. Pause the video. Cover the finished sample if needed. Let the child struggle before rescue. Demo on demo paper. Return the tool. The program is a help. It is not a replacement for authorship honesty.

Co-op and class edges

A co-op art hour can use any of these objects. The family's file at home still says Art. The co-op supply list still wants AP / ASTM D-4236 materials and adult presence. Do not treat a co-op showcase as NAEP. Do not treat a shared craft sample as the only evidence of looking.

What this chapter will not do

It will not rank Artistic Pursuits against Draw Write Now against Usborne against How Great Thou Art against Atelier against Living Art Lessons. It will not crown a brain-development slogan. It will not treat Cathy Duffy-style catalogue pages as trials. It will not reprint *Art for Homeschooling* project lists. It will not promise

that art raises math scores (REAP — say once in the welcome, point back). It will not invent a national art-minutes number.

Fit. Then look. Then make. Then talk. Then date the page under **Art**.

Vendor features in this chapter are taken from vendor pages opened or continuity-checked and labelled as vendor. Omit unverified 2026 list prices. This chapter is not an endorsement and not legal advice.

A Note on Sources

Studies named in the chapters are listed in Notes, in one series at the back. That is where the full citations live, so the teaching pages can stay a teaching voice.

Some items the research behind this book did not open stay out of the teaching voice. I did not invent a coefficient, a statute, or a product feature to fill a hole. If a study is in the chapter, it is in the notes. If we could not open it, it is not used as a finding here.

Program hours, credit claims, and product descriptions in the resources chapter are taken from the companies' own pages. Access date 24 September 2026.